

Spinoza's Ethica

Analysis and Characterization

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Translated from the Danish

Spinoza's Ethica. Analyse og Karakteristik. D. Kgl. Danske Vidensk. Selsk. Skrifter, 7. Række,
historisk og filosofisk Afd. III, 3. Copenhagen: Andr. Fred. Høst & Søn; Bianco Lunos Bogtrykkeri,

1918

Introduction.

1. A philosophical system is an attempt to lead what is given in experience, the things before us, back to one fundamental thing, a primal phenomenon, and thereby to gather all knowledge into one fundamental thought. The validity of this fundamental thought can be sought to be shown partly through an analysis of the things at the philosopher's disposal, partly through an attempt to derive these things from the fundamental thing. By the first procedure the fundamental thing becomes a consequence of the individual things; by the second these become consequences of it. In no system are attempts to apply both procedures lacking. But even if such attempts could succeed, the question would still remain whether the circle of things the thinker commands is not limited; and since new things can always turn up, this question must be answered yes. No system can therefore become anything but a hypothesis built on the analysis of a more or less comprehensive circle of things. As for the second procedure, difficulties of principle will also arise, since it already proves impossible on purely logical grounds to derive a manifold of things from a single fundamental thing; every inference needs, after all, more than one premise.

This consideration may well be said to have penetrated the philosophical world to such a degree that the time of systems is now past. In a certain sense there will of course always be "system" in serious thought, since every single thought must be able to "stand together" with the other thoughts that are held fast. But "system" in the sense of a world-explanation or world-view that is not merely rounded off but closed and definitive belongs to the past.

The study of the philosophical systems of the past has, however, more than a purely historical interest. Such edifices of thought were natural in themselves so long as no thorough critical examination of human knowledge had been undertaken. And on closer consideration it often turns out that problems we are inclined to regard as wholly modern lie hidden as elements in the spontaneous crystallizations that took place in the thinkers of the past. If now the things with which thought is occupied keep their significance, — if the fundamental thoughts with which it works are closely bound up with the nature

of human thought, — and if the work is done in earnest and with a sense for the depth of the problems, — then such a system can not merely stand as the expression of the thought of a bygone time, but can also serve as a model of how one must think under other historical presuppositions. [4]

Of few systems does this hold to the degree that it holds of SPINOZA's.

Nor did SPINOZA, for that matter, think he had set up a complete system, closed for all time, as a frequent but mistaken view of him supposes. In a letter to OLDENBURG (Ep. 30 in VAN VLOTEN's edition) he says that he does not know how things really hang together, and how every part fits into the whole to which it belongs; — for that, one would need to know the whole of nature and all its parts! In a letter to BOXEL (Ep. 56) he says that we do not know the greater part of nature's fundamental properties (attributes); we know only the two fundamental properties that make themselves known in our own being, thought and extension (Ep. 64; cf. *Ethica* II, Ax. 5). And when a young friend of his had gone over to Catholicism and now, in a letter in which he tried to convert him, asked mockingly whether he thought he had found the best philosophy of all, SPINOZA answered (Ep. 76) that he by no means thought he had arrived at the best philosophy, but that he was certain he knew the true philosophy. Not only with regard to nature's fundamental properties (attributes), but also with regard to the existence of the individual, determinate things (*existentia modorum*) we stand on the ground of mere experience (Ep. 10); and as for the understanding of these individual things given in experience, we stand before an infinite task, since the individual thing (the individual being) is understood through its connection with other individual things, so that the series of causes goes on to infinity (*Ethica* I, 28). Knowledge from experience can thus never be closed.

How far the statements brought forward here can be brought into strictly necessary connection with the whole of SPINOZA's other views will appear when we go through the several parts of the principal work. But before we go on to such an inquiry, we must try to find traces of the work of thought from which the system arose. If the finished system can be compared with a crystal, it becomes intelligible only when one can trace the formation of the crystal, that is, find the presuppositions that were decisive for the building of the system.

The students of Spinoza have, especially in the most recent times, laid the main weight on finding historical predecessors of SPINOZA's peculiar line of thought. For all

the learning displayed in this, one cannot say that it has got further than mere possibilities. SPINOZA's first biographers (LUCAS, COLERUS) pointed to DESCARTES. Modern scholars have examined his relation to Jewish medieval theology (JOEL), to the new scholasticism (FREUDENTHAL), to GIORDANO BRUNO (SIGWART, AVENARIUS), to the freer movements in the Dutch intellectual life of the time (MEINSMA), to the theologians of the past in general (DUNIN-BORKOWSKI)¹. It has long since been established that SPINOZA did not spin his wisdom out of himself, and that on the whole he was not the hermit his first disciples found it most advisable to make him appear. He was a well-read man in many fields and was able to take from many sides what he could use. But the decisive thing was a current of thought that arose in him spontaneously and, at first, without clear awareness, and that determined the choice of what he took up from the thoughts of his time, and also decided what place they got in the edifice of his thought. At bottom, a spiritual need that arose in him early was the source of the current of thought and determined its direction as well. [5]

2. The work of thought that began early in SPINOZA started within Jewish theology and was taken up again on the basis of the Western natural science and philosophy into which he had, especially after his expulsion from the synagogue, lived himself. In both fields he went the way of analysis and consequence and sought to hold fast to and carry through presuppositions of which his predecessors had not been clearly aware. And throughout all this work he was led by an urge to understand himself and his connection with the great, lawful and infinite whole of existence, an urge that in him had at once an intellectual and a religious character. These three elements or tendencies I will characterize briefly, before going on to show, through an analysis of the principal work (*Ethica*), how they are refracted in his thought. In the definitions and axioms with which the first book of the *Ethica* begins, thoughts have crystallized that can be traced

¹It has been SPINOZA's fate that his personality and his teaching have repeatedly been defended by men who stood far from, or were even hostile to, his whole direction. Thus the pastor COLERUS, who was himself much offended by SPINOZA's teaching, cleared his memory of various slanders, and has therefore been called a modern Balaam. Such a Balaam was JACOBI too, whose theology of feeling made him look on SPINOZA's philosophy with horror. And in our own day the Jesuit DUNIN-BORKOWSKI has studied SPINOZA's development not only with great learning but also with great sympathy. — The sympathy has its ground in his seeing SPINOZA as a counterweight to the scepticism and dilettante free-thinking of that age and of ours. But compared with what DUNIN-BORKOWSKI calls the world-philosophy, namely the medieval scholasticism with THOMAS AQUINAS at its head, SPINOZA's philosophy nevertheless stands as a great illusion. (STANISLAUS V. DUNIN-BORKOWSKI: *Der junge Spinoza*. Münster 1910, p. 351—485).

back to the three sources indicated. The peculiarity of the system and the personality of its author show themselves in the way in which the three motives work together and strive to come into their own.

a. SPINOZA's youthful work, the "Short Treatise", has a more theological and mystical stamp than the principal work, the *Ethica*. There SPINOZA starts from the concept of God as it had developed in the higher popular religions, and he draws all the consequences of God's being an unconditioned and infinite being, — a being without presuppositions and without limits. It is by this way that he arrives at the strict concept of substance put forward in the first definitions of the *Ethica*, — the concept of that which exists through itself and is understood through itself, that is, whose concept does not presuppose any other concept from which it would have to be formed. Here an urge shows itself to reach something last, something without presuppositions, that does not in turn send thought beyond itself. SPINOZA meets the objection that every definition after all consists precisely in bringing a concept under a higher concept (K. Tr. I, 7, 9–10). That does not hold, he maintains, of the fundamental concepts that condition all knowledge; if [6] they too presupposed other concepts, nothing could ever be fully known! A peculiar union of mysticism and theory of knowledge appears here. The urge to find concluding concepts is not purely intellectual; it is one with the urge to come to rest. If we are not to be thrown out into endless series of thoughts, we must hold to the thought of a single substance, a single fundamental being (K. Tr. I, 2, 10). Our thought finds rest neither by stopping at the knowledge of the spiritual nor at the knowledge of the corporeal, but must go back to that which conditions the existence of these two domains and makes the understanding of them possible: God or substance (K. Tr. II, 22, 5).

In Jewish, in Mohammedan and in Christian theology alike, the concept of God has a theoretical significance: it supplies the principle of understanding, in any case of the concluding understanding of everything. And it is about this side of the concept of God that SPINOZA's thinking concentrates more and more. His relation to theology may be described by saying that he takes the question seriously of what character the concluding thought would have to have. It cannot be unintelligible, and if it is not to lead beyond itself, it must be understood through itself. To make clear to ourselves what SPINOZA's substance must mean, we must therefore ask what it is that is understood through itself and can make everything else intelligible. It can only be the necessary

connection between subject and predicate, or between premises and conclusion, the connection that underlies every transition of thought. Further back than to the principle of all thinking, and thereby also of all the rationality we can find in existence, we cannot go. We can give no reason why the conclusion follows from its premises. It is by an analytic intuition² that we bring out the principle of all rationality. The principle of all understanding stands in SPINOZA's metaphysics as substance as well, the being that underlies everything. His metaphysics is a projection of his theory of knowledge. He begins theologically by saying that God is what makes everything intelligible to us, and he ends by saying that what makes everything intelligible to us is God. Whereas in the Short Treatise he goes from the concept of God to the concept of substance, in the first definitions of the first book of the *Ethica* he goes, conversely, from the concept of substance to the concept of God. This reversal is prepared in the first appendix to the Short Treatise, and it appears decisively in the first letters (see especially Ep. 2).

The concept of God that SPINOZA took with him from his theological period and always held fast to in his principal work was of course very different from the concept of God of the popular religions, and he himself calls attention to the difference (see e.g. Ep. 19. 21. 73). He constructs his concept of God from the presuppositions of all rational understanding of existence, but must then (continuing what Jewish philosophers of religion in the Middle Ages, especially MAIMONIDES and IBN GEBIROL, had begun) seek to purge all anthropomorphisms, all concrete psychological properties, from the content of this concept.

In the same years in which SPINOZA's break with the popular religion in which he had grown up was being prepared by the independence of his thought, another great mind, [7] BLAISE PASCAL, returned through a religious crisis to the concept of God of his popular religion, with an express affirmation of all anthropomorphisms. "God of Abraham, of Isaac and of Jacob, God of Jesus Christ, not of the philosophers and the men of science!" he cries in the passionate utterance that he wrote down on 25 November 1654 and thereafter always carried on him, sewn into his clothing.

SPINOZA's God was precisely "the God of the philosophers and the men of science", in so far as his concept of God is a metaphysical expression of the last presupposition of all thought and science. Now since this presupposition does not stand in an external

²On this concept see my paper on intuition in *Vid. Selsk. Oversigter* 1914, p. 77–80.

relation to the individual things, but makes itself known in our understanding of them and in every fixing of the conditions of their existence, SPINOZA's God must be an indwelling (immanent) God, not an external (transcendent) God. SPINOZA describes his opposition to the usual concept of God thus (Ep. 73): "I hold an opinion of God and nature wholly different from the one modern Christians embrace. For I maintain that God is the indwelling (immanent), not the external (transeunt) (= transcendent) cause of all things." In the Short Treatise (first dialogue) he had illustrated this point by a comparison with the understanding, which is active in all individual thoughts but is not the external cause of them³. — SPINOZA's inner or indwelling cause corresponds to what BRUNO calls "principle", whereas BRUNO by "cause" means what SPINOZA calls external cause⁴. —

From God's being the principle of all understanding it follows not only that he must be the "indwelling", not the "external cause", since he relates to all things as the ground relates to the consequence. It follows as well that no limit can be set to God's being. All the fundamental properties of existence must be God's properties. It is through this line of thought that for SPINOZA the concept of God is not only one with the concept of substance, as we have already seen, but also one with the concept of nature, so that he can use the three expressions God, substance and nature as synonymous. In the first dialogue, which seems to be the oldest part of the Short Treatise, it is asked whether "a being that is most perfect, since it cannot be limited by any other being" can be thought, and the answer is that nature is such a being, since everything is comprised in it. And it is shown besides that this infinity is closely bound up with the concept of the indwelling cause. If the things (the things in the world) were due to an external cause distinct from them, this cause would be limited. — There is thus an inner connection between the principle of understanding, immanence and infinity, and it is SPINOZA's consistent thinking through of the traditional concept of God that leads him to all three concepts.

AVENARIUS⁵ and SIGWART⁶ suppose that the concept of nature became a member of [8]

³HUME, who cannot have known the Short Treatise, and who probably knows SPINOZA only from BAYLE's Dictionnaire, uses SPINOZA's teaching to frighten his spiritualist opponents. When these maintained that our individual sensations and ideas were all members of one and the same consciousness, and did not, as HUME thought, stand in a purely external, mechanical relation of association to one another, then they were using, he says, the same line of thought (the concept of immanence) that led SPINOZA to his impious opinions! (*Treatise on Human Nature*. I, 4, 5).

⁴BRUNO: *De la causa, principio et uno*. Opere ed. Lagarde, p. 230, 272.

⁵RICH. AVENARIUS: *Die beiden ersten Phasen des Spinozischen Pantheismus*. (1868).

⁶CHR. SIGWART: *Spinoza's kurzer Tractat*². Prolegomena. (1869).

SPINOZA's thought through the influence of the thinkers of the Renaissance, perhaps of BRUNO. This is most probable, and on closer consideration it will lead us over to the second great motive of thought in SPINOZA. But as the concept of nature turns up in the first dialogue, in the answer to the question whether there is a being that is not limited by anything else, it is presupposed that an urge has already stirred beforehand to close thought in a concept that in turn leads beyond itself no longer. That is SPINOZA's fundamental urge, and it developed while he thought through the traditional concept of God. It is from the thought of God as the principle of all understanding that he came to the thought of God's immanence and of the infinity of God or nature.

The line of thought that leads SPINOZA to maintain the validity of the concept of infinity, both as regards substance (as absolutely infinite) and as regards its attributes (as each infinite in its kind), may recall the line of thought that led BRUNO to reject the validity of the old, limited picture of the world. The first two propositions of the second book of the *Ethica* indicate the way SPINOZA went, the way that led him to the second and sixth definitions of the first book. We can, it says (*Eth. II, 1. Schol.*), always add thought to thought without there being any limit here, and likewise we can (*Eth. II, 2*) add extension to extension without limit. The world of thought and the world of extension are each infinite within their kind (*in suo genere*), since within them one can always advance further by the same law. And it is the same with the concept that underlies all concepts, namely the concept of something that can appear in infinitely many forms or kinds, since the series of these different kinds (*genera*) or attributes can always be continued, just like the series of the different things within the same kind. Hence the definition of God at the beginning of the *Ethica* (*Eth. I, Def. 6*): "By God I understand an absolutely infinite being, that is, a substance consisting of infinitely many attributes, each of which expresses something eternal and infinite." — In *Ep. 36* this whole line of thought is clearly indicated.

In BRUNO too what we may call the law of continuous series formation is applied. Sensation, imagination and thought alike show us, he says, that we can always add member to member. The sensible horizon can always be widened, and we can add image to image, magnitude to magnitude, number to number, thought to thought to infinity. Therefore he asks whether we can think the world limited: at the very limit we try to set to the world, a new horizon would form around us, if we imagine ourselves transported

there⁷. The logical genesis of the concept of infinity proves to be the same in the two thinkers, and BRUNO is the forerunner here.

The difference between their use of this concept is bound up with the difference [9] between their problems. In BRUNO the widening of the picture of the world is the main thing, — in SPINOZA it is the carrying through of conformity to law within the picture of the world. But there is here a possibility of an influence of BRUNO on SPINOZA that concerns a more essential point than those to which one has usually kept in discussing the relation between the two philosophers.

In both of them, of course, the question remains by what right we ascribe real validity to the psychological or logical possibility⁸ of continued series formation. This question first comes forward in the critical philosophy. If we compare BRUNO and SPINOZA in this respect, SPINOZA stands more dogmatically than his predecessor. Whereas for SPINOZA the fact that we can construct a concept of infinity is proof enough that there is an infinite being, BRUNO distinguishes between construction in thought and reality, and specially between mathematics and physics⁹.

b. After his departure from the synagogue SPINOZA became acquainted with the science, philosophy and literature of the West. And when now, having set up the concept of God as the principle of all understanding, he asks in turn what understanding really means, he maintains that we learn this by keeping to the fundamental thoughts (*notiones communes*) that prove to apply everywhere in nature, in the part as in the whole, that is, to the universal laws of everything existing (Tract. theol. polit. Ch. 6—7). Only by this way can we come to know the divine. “As for me,” SPINOZA says in a letter (Ep. 21), “I have not learned, and have not been able to learn, any of God’s eternal attributes from Holy Scripture.” — Theology had taught him that God is the principle of intelligibility,

⁷See on this *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 118—123. — This thought comes out especially in the book *De Immenso* (Francofurti 1591). This work also presents the relation between freedom and necessity in the same way as SPINOZA. (Eth. I, Def. 7).

⁸It is not clear what principle of series formation SPINOZA has in mind when he says that merely by keeping to the attribute of thought we arrive at the thought of an infinite being (Eth. II, 1. Schol.). It could be a purely psychological series of sensations (Eth. II, 18. Schol.), or (more probably) a series of grounds and consequences (Eth. I, 28), or (improbably) a series of members each of which relates to the preceding as subject to object (Eth. II, 21. Schol.). — Cf. on various kinds of series formation *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 164—172, and specially on series formation by virtue of the principle of repetition *Totalitet som Kategori* (Vid. Selsk. Skr. 1917), p. 34—37.

⁹E.g. *La cena de le ceneri* (Opere ital. ed. Lagarde, p. 184): Altro è giocare con la geometria, altro è verificare con la natura.

and he now turns to the presuppositions of science to learn what understanding is.

Not enough attention has been paid, I think, to what a comparison between the Short Treatise and the *Ethica* clearly shows, that principles of natural science form the background of SPINOZA's philosophy in its definitive form. When he demands (Eth. I, 28) that every phenomenon (thing) be explained by another, this by a third, and so on, this contains the requirement set up by KEPLER (which KEPLER¹⁰ himself applied in criticizing the speculations of his youth), that the causes that can be recognized in science must themselves be capable of being shown in experience. For him this principle coincides [10] with the principle of inertia set up by GALILEO and DESCARTES, which he sets up in Eth. II, Lemma 3 as valid for material things and also applies (Eth. III, 6; cf. II, 1. Schol.) to spiritual things. To this is joined the proposition of the constant relation between rest and motion, another expression of DESCARTES's proposition of the conservation of motion and, like it, an imperfect forerunner of the modern proposition of the conservation of energy (Eth. II, Lemma 7, Schol.; cf. Ep. 32. 64). — In the "geometrical" presentation that SPINOZA unfortunately gave of his teaching, the propositions mentioned are derived from the concept of attribute, which (Eth. I, def. 4) is defined as a property of substance that is understood through itself and therefore is not understood by means of any other property. It follows, among other things, that an extended phenomenon must be explained by another extended phenomenon. But in reality SPINOZA arrived at his strict concept of attribute through analysis of the fundamental concepts of natural science. What is put first in the synthetic presentation came last in the analysis. That extension cannot be limited by thought, or thought by extension, that one must not, therefore, in one's explanation of nature jump over from one attribute to another (Eth. I, def. 2; I, 10 and II, 6), — this is in the end a principle of method found by analysis of the scientific propositions mentioned, although SPINOZA puts it forward as an eternal truth.

One of SPINOZA's correspondents objected to SPINOZA's definition of attribute that it was not, after all, beyond doubt that thought could not be limited by body or body by thought, since thought might be a bodily motion (*motus corporeus*) (Ep. 3). SPINOZA answers (Ep. 4) that extension, considered as extension, is not thought, and that this is all he needs in order to hold fast his proposition that thought and extension cannot limit

¹⁰*Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 165. — There was a work of KEPLER's in SPINOZA's library, but it was a chronological work, not one of his purely scientific ones. Of mathematical and scientific works SPINOZA owned books by VIETA, HUYGHENS, RIOLAN, STENO and BOYLE, besides DESCARTES.

each other. — The principle of series formation mentioned above clearly underlies this. SPINOZA demands series of homogeneous members. And this brings us over to the most fundamental proposition in SPINOZA's system, the proposition of causality, and to the way in which SPINOZA conceives it.

The causal relation is intelligible to us, according to SPINOZA, only when its members, what we call "cause" and what we call "effect", are of the same nature, so that a relation of identity holds between them. In the treatise on "the improvement of the understanding" he says that the knowledge of the effect is nothing but a perfect understanding of the cause, and presupposes it. "If two things have no property in common, they cannot be understood through each other, or the concept of the one does not contain that of the other" — so say the fourth and fifth axioms of the first book of the *Ethica*. And in Ep. 4 it is stated that if two such things were to stand in a causal relation to each other, there would be something in the effect that is not in the cause, and this something would then have its ground in nothing.

SPINOZA thus demands equivalence between cause and effect, just as in inferences that can be converted there is equivalence between premises and conclusion. Within the world of phenomena (things) he wants to find a connection as strict and logical as that between the members of a series of logical inferences that can be converted. One is [11] not to begin with abstractions, but with thoughts that make the origin and succession of things, spiritual and material alike, intelligible. The more we understand individual things, the more we understand God (*Eth.* V, 24), for what makes them intelligible to us is precisely God. What exists through itself and is understood through itself is not itself an individual thing, an individual being. It is the principle of grounding, or of conformity to law, which is the last presupposition of all science and which proves itself in the whole as in all the individual parts of existence. For SPINOZA the knowledge of God and natural science were so far from excluding each other that, on the contrary, they coincided. To think and to inquire was for him a religious act.

In a famous work that appeared some ten years after SPINOZA's *Ethica*, a similar line of thought is in part found. In his "Principia" (and later in the "Optics") NEWTON conceived space as God's sense organ (*sensorium*), the organ of omnipresence. Mathematical inquiry then also became knowledge of God. Both NEWTON's and SPINOZA's thought, if followed historically, would lead back to PLATO. In other respects SPINOZA's and NEWTON's

philosophy of religion are very different. NEWTON wants to ground the assumption of God's existence essentially in a teleological way, from the purposiveness in the structure of the world. But for SPINOZA, to think of God as acting according to purposes was one with thinking of him as a finite and imperfect being, which does not yet possess all that accords with its nature. The sharpest statements found in SPINOZA come precisely in his criticism of teleology.

Whereas in the foregoing weight has been laid on SPINOZA's philosophy, especially his concluding conception of the concepts of substance and attribute, being due to an analysis of the causal explanation of empirical science, an acute student of Spinoza has on the contrary objected that SPINOZA's concept of substance contained no causal determinations, and that no such determinations can be derived from his definition of substance either (Eth. I, def. 3)¹¹. This remark, correct in itself, contains a criticism of SPINOZA, not a criticism of my view of him. Since SPINOZA in fact conceives causality as a purely logical relation, he needed to take no other than purely logical determinations into his definition of substance. SPINOZA's philosophy is an attempt to think the world by the formal categories, to which he led back all real categories (such as causality) and all ideal categories (the concepts of value)¹². One can criticize him partly by showing that he did not in reality carry through the reduction of all categories to the formal ones, partly by establishing the impossibility of such a reduction. But as his work actually stands, one will not be able to deny that it is characterized by an attempt, magnificent in itself, in the direction named. In the following analysis of the several parts of the work there will be occasion to throw light on this main point.

c. By SPINOZA's own declaration at the beginning of the unfinished treatise "on the improvement of the understanding", his personal experience of life was of decisive significance for him in the development of his main thoughts. When he had to account to himself for what significance philosophical thought had for him, or rather, how philosophical thought had become for him that in which he at last found the value of life, the explanation lay for him in this: that the only thing that is in our power and makes us independent of external circumstances is the work of thought itself, and the knowledge that can be won through it of the connection of our mind with the whole of nature. Other [12]

¹¹GABRIEL HUAN: *Le dieu de Spinoza*. Paris 1914, p. 44 f.

¹²On the different groups of categories see *Den menneskelige Tanke*.

goods — pleasures, honour, riches — rest on something that does not spring from our innermost being. But through the work of thought a joy of knowledge and a love of the divine are reached that lift one above all sorrow and unrest. Here he saw an aim for his life, an aim that at the same time made possible, and brought with it, an endeavour that other men may reach the same aim. For, as he later said (Eth. IV, App. cap. 9), the best way in which a man can show what ability and spirit he commands is so to influence others that they come to live under the very rule of true knowledge.

It was not to flee real life that SPINOZA chose this way. He was no pessimist. He would not have sympathized with the young SCHOPENHAUER's words to WIELAND: "Life is a precarious business; I mean to spend mine thinking about it." The life of thought was for SPINOZA the highest life, not because it stood in opposition to the life of reality, but precisely because in its own way it was able to give expression to all the sides of life, just as it was itself a side or form of life.

Whether SPINOZA's noble and earnest conduct of life was consistent from his own standpoint was a question much discussed in and after SPINOZA's own time, whereas nowadays — with the necessary knowledge of his line of thought — one will hardly see any problem in it. There is another question that has more interest for us, namely, to what degree the after-effect of the positively religious standpoint had a lasting influence on his mind.

It has certainly not been mere accommodation when he used the words God, nature and substance as synonymous. In the fundamental concept of his philosophy he saw a religious and a rational content expressed at once. No opposition made itself felt for him here. In particular it has not been mere accommodation when he often, especially in his letters, uses Christian expressions as symbols for thoughts to which he himself gave a wholly different content. It would certainly have been best had he followed the rule he himself lays down in one of his letters (Ep. 23), that a philosopher should preferably avoid using theological expressions; but WUNDT is decidedly right in the remark he makes in his characterization of SPINOZA, that the latter's view was wholly different from that of the Enlightenment: "Whereas the Enlightenment deliberately covers over the mystical depths of religious thought, it is precisely the mystical content of the concept of God and of religious feeling that SPINOZA seeks to translate into the form of rational knowledge"¹³.

¹³*Ethik*⁴, II, p. 113.

Through the working thought itself, whose significance for the genesis of the system I [13] seek to stress in this treatise, SPINOZA thought he heard the voice of the divine. In the first four books of the *Ethica* the mystical character of the system recedes in comparison with the *Short Treatise*, but in the last part of the fifth book it asserts itself very strongly. The mystical element here comes to push the rational element aside.

In the most recent times DUNIN-BORKOWSKI has maintained that SPINOZA was himself caught in an illusion with regard to his "moral energy". "SPINOZA", he says¹⁴, "believed that the light that streamed in over his life came from his self-made philosophical firmament. But this light was in fact due to other stars... [those] that had shone upon him in his youth!" This remark can be supported by a psychological fact of great significance. The effects on feeling of an experience or a line of thought can persist long after the original motive has fallen away; they can also enter as elements into feelings that arise under the influence of new experiences or new thoughts. In my *Psychology* I have called this phenomenon the expansion of feeling. But the learned Jesuit, so sympathetic towards SPINOZA, lays too little weight on the influence of SPINOZA's great and deep-going work of thought in the last twenty years of his life, a work of thought in which his whole personality took part, and which therefore led to a concentration, a total desire, in relation to which other incentives had to pale. The proposition that a feeling can only be subdued or displaced by another feeling of opposite direction and greater strength (*Eth.* IV, 7) SPINOZA could learn from his own experience, as his whole spiritual energy gathered about the urge to know.

When a seafarer comes up from the southern hemisphere to the northern, it is new stars he catches sight of and must take his bearings by. The memory of the southern sky does not therefore fall away, but it no longer has decisive significance.

The three motives of thought that can be traced in SPINOZA, and whose refraction characterizes his system, in our day stand out more or less sharply against one another and give rise to different problems. This difference between problems hardly exists for SPINOZA. He sought thoughts by whose help the different problems could find their solution at once. It is the differentiation of the problems that above all separates us from SPINOZA. But since an inner connection must always be presupposed between the different problems that occupy human thought, SPINOZA's great attempt of thought will

¹⁴*Der junge Spinoza*, p. 145.

always keep its significance as orienting, although we could not now raise edifices of thought in the same style as his.

[14]

First Book.

a. Definitions and Axioms.

The definitions and axioms with which the *Ethica* begins are, as we have seen in the foregoing, not set up arbitrarily, but won by analysis partly of inherited religious ideas, partly of the procedure the new science of the time applied. Definitions, SPINOZA says in a letter (Ep. 9), are arbitrary only when they are set up merely to be tested, not when they are set up because experience leads us to them. Experience, it is true, he says in a following letter (Ep. 10), cannot teach us the essence of things, but it can confine our thought to certain essential sides of things (*mentem nostram determinare, ut circa certas tantum rerum essentias cogitet*).

On closer consideration we find in the first definitions and axioms of the *Ethica* a formulation of the presuppositions on which, according to SPINOZA, all science rests. As we have seen in the Introduction, these presuppositions are not regarded by SPINOZA as purely formal; they are paraphrases of the principle of sufficient reason, of the strict logical relation between ground and consequence, but the norm of truth they express is thought of as an existing being.

The first definition starts from there being something whose existence cannot be denied without contradicting oneself. When this something is called cause of itself (*causa sui*), one must remember that in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding he declares this expression to be purely popular. For it says there: "If something is in itself, or, as is popularly said (*ut vulgo dicitur*), is cause of itself (*causa sui*), then it must be understood through its own essence alone." DESCARTES had already used this expression, and it had been objected against him (in the first and the fourth set of objections to his *Meditations*) that for a being to be able to be the cause of itself, it would have to be before it existed. It is perhaps for this reason that SPINOZA criticizes the expression in his treatise on the theory of knowledge. The fact is, however, that as SPINOZA uses the

word cause, the temporal relation between cause and effect plays in the end no part. Hence ground (*ratio*) and cause (*causa*) become for him one and the same. Hence the first definition coincides with the third, which defines substance as “that which is in itself and is understood through itself, that is, that whose concept does not need the concept of another thing from which it would have to be formed”. What kind of concept [15] can it now be that should be able thus to close our knowledge without pointing beyond itself? As I have sought to show in the Introduction, for SPINOZA it is the principle of all conformity to law in the world – the principle that makes it possible to understand the succession of things as a series of grounds and consequences. The thought of the relation between ground and consequence becomes the first (or last) thought, and its content is, for SPINOZA, the being that underlies everything, while it has itself no ground outside itself.

In the second and sixth definitions a distinction is made between something that is finite in its kind, something that is infinite in its kind, and something that is absolutely infinite. With this the relation between individual being (mode), fundamental property (attribute) and fundamental being (substance) is stated.

As we have seen in the Introduction, the concept of attribute is grounded in there being series formations that can be continued to infinity by the same rule with which they began. This is shown in the first and second propositions of the second book in the case of thought and extension. No limit can be set either to the world of thought or to that of extension, and neither can they limit each other; for in that case the law of the series formation would be changed. While no limit can be set within an attribute, the attribute itself is nevertheless limited in so far as it presupposes a definite rule of series formation. Therefore it can express only a single side or property of existence. And then a new series can be formed of the different attributes of existence. This series too can have no limit (although, as will appear later, we know only two members of it), and the concept of God receives its definition precisely in the concept of the substance consisting of infinitely many attributes (Def. 6).

Through the series in which the attributes show themselves, substance expresses itself. For the individual members (modes) of these series are held together by the law of grounding. But there is (according to Def. 3 and 5) this difference between substance and mode, that the former has its ground in itself, the latter its ground in something other

than itself. The common presupposition is that there must be a ground, wherever it may lie. The principle of sufficient reason coincides for SPINOZA with the principle of causality, as we have already seen, and as is expressly enjoined in the fourth and fifth axioms: "The knowledge of the effect depends on the knowledge of the cause and presupposes it. Things that have nothing in common with each other cannot be understood through each other either, or the concept of the one does not presuppose the concept of the other." The relation between cause and effect is thus a pure relation of concepts, in which the difference of time plays no part.

SPINOZA accordingly had really no reason to set up the proposition of causality as a special proposition. We find, however, that in more special cases, where the discussion seemed to demand it, he expressly formulates it. Thus Eth. I, 8. Schol. 2: "For every existing thing there is necessarily a cause on account of which it exists." Here, then, necessary validity is ascribed to the proposition of causality, and SPINOZA expresses himself in the same way in Ep. 34. Where this necessity lies, SPINOZA does not say, and [16] that he sees no problem in it is understood when one holds fast that cause and ground are for him one, as he expressly says in a demonstration of the eleventh proposition of the first book: "For the existence or non-existence of every thing a cause or ground (*causa seu ratio*) must be given."

But now the difference made between substance and modes nevertheless brings with it a twofold causal relation, since there is a difference between having one's ground in oneself and having it in something else. Eth. I, 28 (this important proposition, already mentioned in the Introduction, and to which we shall come back later) demands that each individual mode be explained by another mode, this by a third, and so on to infinity. But at the same time each individual mode is to be understood as a peculiar determination (*affectio*) of substance (Def. 5), and it must therefore find its explanation in substance — besides finding its explanation in other modes. This twofold causal relation — one might call it the ideal and the elementary — would really have to be reduced for SPINOZA to a single one, the ideal. For substance is, through its attributes, the principle of all conformity to law in the world, and so also of the laws that hold between the different modes; and on the other hand these modes are understood through their mutual lawful content, that is, by being regarded as moments in substance (*affectiones substantiæ*). Besides, according to Ax. 4 and 5, there must be no difference between cause and effect.

The elementary concept of cause, which was to hold for the relation between modes different from one another, cannot therefore be a true causal relation. And in the end the external relation between modes, and with it the elementary causal relation, holds only on the standpoint of sensuous ideas (of the imagination). And the last problem then becomes how the different standpoints — that from which there exists only the purely logical (or mathematical) relation between ground and consequence in mutual equivalence, and that for which there exist different things in an external causal order — can be possible. The reduction of these two standpoints has not been carried through to this day¹⁵ — and certainly cannot be carried through.

— A special form of the proposition of causality, the principle of inertia, is contained in the second definition. For when it is said here that extension cannot be limited by thought, this is grounded, as we have seen in the Introduction, in our being able to think any line or surface or any volume lengthened or enlarged, that is, to form members in a continuous series without leaving the attribute of extension. But this proposition also contains for SPINOZA the methodical principle that every extended thing must be explained by another extended thing, that is, every change in a body by changes in the state or position of another body. SPINOZA works by this principle, as we shall see in what follows, when faced with the special questions. And when he demands (Eth. I, 10, to which proposition, besides Ax. 4, Eth. II, 6 refers back) that every attribute (and so everything that falls under this attribute) shall (*debet*) be explained by itself, this follows, no doubt, in the end from every attribute, according to Def. 4, expressing the essence of substance and so, like substance, having to have its ground in itself. But [17] this definition itself is at bottom a methodical principle, grounded in there having to be homogeneity between cause and effect if the causal relation is to be intelligible. — There is an interesting difference here between the Short Treatise and the *Ethica*. There the principle of inertia is already set up (II, 19, 8), but no consequences are yet drawn from it with regard to method (or, in SPINOZA's terminology, with regard to the relation between the attributes), and therefore no new psychophysical hypothesis is set up, as in the *Ethica*. DESCARTES, in his formulation of the principle of inertia (*Principia Philosophiæ* II, 37–41), had expressly made a reservation with regard to angels and souls. And on the strength of such a reservation the Short Treatise confidently lets the soul influence the direction

¹⁵Cf. my criticism of the Marburg school in *Totalitet som Kategori* (Vid. Selsk. Skr. 1917, p 46–48).

of physiological processes, and on the other hand lets the body influence the soul and thereby be known by it (K. Tr. II, 19, 9–14). Here, then, in the interval between the Short Treatise and the *Ethica*, a change took place in SPINOZA's view, probably under the influence of the methodical principle (*vera causa*) mentioned in the Introduction.

Now it is characteristic of SPINOZA that these different principles (which, for that matter, are not different for him) are not conceived as forms or conditions of human understanding, determined by the nature of human thought and by the character of the tasks set it, but are regarded as expressions of the essence of things, in the end of the essence of the eternal ground of existence. When a thought is true, says Ax. 6, it must agree with its object¹⁶. And what is the content of strict thought — so it says in Eth. I, 30 Dem.¹⁷ as a closer explanation of Ax. 6 — must necessarily be given in nature.

That in our search for the last presuppositions of knowledge we cannot go further back than to certain principles is for SPINOZA proof that these principles express the nature of an eternal and necessary being that underlies everything (*res omnium prima*, as it is called in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding), and that does not itself have its ground in anything different from it. It is PARMENIDES' old teaching that still asserts itself: "Thought and the object of thought are one and the same" (τὰντὸν δ' ἔστιν νοεῖν τε καὶ οὐνεκεν ἔστι νοήμα).

If we want to know more about substance, we are referred to the attributes, each of which expresses the essence of substance from a single side (*in suo genere*). An attribute is, according to Def. 4, that which the understanding perceives of substance as making up (constituting) its essence. From this definition HEGEL¹⁸ concluded, and after him J. E. ERDMANN, that it is only for our knowledge that there are such attributes. But "as" [18] (*tanquam*) does not mean "as if" here. SPINOZA uses "tanquam" in several places of valid perception (see e.g. Eth. II, 45 Schol.). The critical philosophy's distinction between

¹⁶This is the correct translation of Ax. 6 (*idea vera debet cum suo ideato convenire*). In the very law of thought itself the norm of truth is given, which also decides what is false (*veritas norma sui et falsi*, Eth. II, 43 Schol.). In the treatise on the improvement of the understanding SPINOZA develops the view that truth does not rest on anything distinct from knowledge; every false idea will be dissolved through its consequences. We shall come back to this question later. — FREUDENTHAL (Festschrift for ZELLER p. 128) wrongly regards Ax. 6 as a definition of truth and finds in it a remnant of scholasticism.

¹⁷The word "objective" in SPINOZA's usage means "subjectively". Cf. below at II, 7.

¹⁸*Vorlesungen über die Geschichte der Philosophie*², Berlin 1844, III, p. 344: "Wie kommt ausser Gott der Verstand herbeigelaufen, der die beiden Attribute des Denkens und der Ausdehnung auf die absolute Substanz anwendet?"

things in themselves and our perception of them must not without more ado be read into SPINOZA. For he teaches expressly that the attribute, like substance, has its ground in itself. If HEGEL were right, it would have to be said that the attribute had its ground in the human understanding. SPINOZA's characteristic teaching amounts precisely to this, that the last foundation of knowledge is also the last foundation of existence.

In the relation SPINOZA has stated between the concepts substance (fundamental being), attribute (fundamental property) and mode (individual being, thing), his whole philosophy is really contained. The special series of propositions he sets up are only further developments of what is contained in the definitions. They do not come about, as a really "geometrical" method would require, by combining construction from the definitions set up, but are explications, paraphrases, not proper demonstrations. The "geometrical" method is merely a shell that must be broken if one wants to get hold of SPINOZA's real, working thought. And it has the great drawback, which SPINOZA himself sometimes feels, that the different doctrines are put on the same line despite their mutual relations of super- and subordination.

Excursus on Definitions, Axioms and Postulates in SPINOZA.

With regard to SPINOZA's "definitions, axioms and postulates" the following is to be noted.

1) The definitions are set up as nominal explanations of fundamental concepts, but on closer examination prove to be due to an analysis of SPINOZA's concept of science. The results of this analysis are dogmatically fixed under the (unformulated) presupposition that the foundation of thought is also that of existence.

2) The axioms have a different character in the different books. In the first book they state principles regarded as self-evident, but which, like the definitions, prove to rest on analysis of the concept of science. — In the second, third and fourth books the axioms are empirical propositions that stand for SPINOZA as beyond doubt. That "man thinks" (II, Ax. 2), and that "we do not feel or perceive any individual things other than bodies and thoughts" (II, Ax. 5), stand fast as facts of experience. Likewise, that every individual thing will be able to find its master (IV. Ax.). After II, 13 — in connection with borrowed propositions (*lemmata*) from natural science — axioms are set up that rest on experience (e.g. that bodies are either at rest or in motion, and so on). These axioms are the scientific counterparts of the axioms drawn from psychological experience at the beginning of the book. — Of the two axioms in the fifth book, one is an empirical-psychological proposition, the other a proposition of the theory of knowledge derived from a proposition in the

third book.

3) The expression postulate SPINOZA uses only in the second and third books, and he makes no difference in principle between axiom and postulate (cf. III, Ax. 1: *postulatum seu axioma*). The series of postulates set up in the third book after Proposition 13 are only summaries of what was contained in the preceding borrowed propositions (*lemmata*) and axioms. These postulates are referred back to when it says in Proposition 17 Schol.: “All the postulates I have set up contain hardly anything that does not stand fast by experience.”

[19]

b. Propositions 1–14.

Purging of the Concept of Substance and Demonstration of its Identity with the Concept of God.

α . That there must be substance in the world, that is, something that exists in itself without presupposing anything else, is for SPINOZA a matter of course, because the series of our thoughts (of grounds and causes) must find its close in something that does not in turn demand continued thought. The urge to a close shows itself, as already mentioned in the Introduction, in another way in the *Ethica* than in the Short Treatise. In the youthful work it was above all the urge to rest that was stressed. “If we”, it says here (I, 2), “wanted to seek the cause of substance, which is the principle of all things, we should have to seek in turn the cause of this cause, and so on to infinity, so that — since we must necessarily stop somewhere and come to rest, which we must — it is necessary to come to rest in this one substance.” This line of thought SPINOZA later expressly abandoned. The grounding of the existence of substance or God, he says in a letter (Ep. 12), does not lie in our otherwise getting an infinite series of causes, but in there otherwise being no cause necessary in itself of the things that are not necessary¹⁹. That the series of modes (individual beings, things) leads us from A to B and from B to C and so on to infinity, — in this SPINOZA now finds no difficulty. On the contrary, he is — like BRUNO²⁰ — convinced that from substance (nature, the divine) an infinity of consequences or effects must proceed. So long as the work of thought is occupied with modes, no close can

¹⁹ARISTOTLE already has a similar line of thought: “If there is no first, there is no cause at all.” (*Metaphys.* p. 994).

²⁰See *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². I, p. 123 f.

therefore be expected. If a close is to be reached, it must be found in the principle that underlies the lawful connection between all modes, as well as these modes themselves according to their innermost nature; and it is precisely this principle that SPINOZA calls substance, nature or God. Not the urge to rest, but absolutely rational satisfaction now motivates the close.

SPINOZA thus does not think of the series of causes as closed by a first member, from which all other members spring, but finds the close he seeks in the inner law or force that makes itself known in the causal series that empirical science demonstrates. Either nothing exists, it says in *Eth. I, 11 Dem.*, or else an absolutely necessary being exists. And on the other hand it also holds that the more we understand individual beings, the more we understand God (*Eth. V, 24*).

β. When the existence of substance stands for SPINOZA as an eternal truth, it is thus because it expresses the fundamental truth on which all other truth depends, — namely, that in existence there reigns a lawful order which finds its expression in the concept of cause, which for SPINOZA coincides with the concept of ground.

As already remarked, the proposition of causality is expressly set up in the second scholium to the eighth proposition. But this proposition is clearly presupposed in the first eight propositions. For when SPINOZA wants to establish that, according to the definition of substance, there can be only a single substance, he does it in the following way: If [20] there were several substances, they would have to have different attributes, for through attributes the essence of substances is expressed; but substances with different attributes would not be able to be causes or effects of one another, since they would have nothing in common; their concepts could not be led back to one and the same concept.

There is a presupposition for the validity of this line of thought that SPINOZA does not indicate, namely, that different substances cannot be thought without standing in a relation of interaction with one another. This is not necessary, since every substance is to have its ground or cause in itself. It could after all be thought — and LEIBNIZ in his doctrine of monads did think this possibility — that what springs from the one substance does not cross at all with, or stand in a relation of interaction to, what springs from another substance. The different substances could stand in the same relation to one another as, in SPINOZA, the different attributes stand to one another.

If one defines the proposition of causality so that it states that everything we are to be

able to know must stand in relation to something else as ground to consequence (or cause to effect) or conversely, then it would be correct that if there were several “substances”, they would have to stand in interaction with one another. But then the concept of a cause or ground of itself would have fallen away. This concept in reality denotes a blind alley and is a purely negative concept, which states only that one has not found the ground or cause of something and therefore cannot bring it into connection with what one otherwise knows or thinks one knows. The first presuppositions of our conception of the world can only be justified through their consequences, not themselves derived in turn. The concepts they contain are therefore limiting concepts. — This consideration SPINOZA would not be able to accept. It is first carried through by the critical philosophy.

It is of interest to compare SPINOZA's concept of substance with the concepts of substance of scholasticism and of DESCARTES on the one side, and with KANT's “Ding an sich” on the other.

The older concept of substance (that of scholasticism and of DESCARTES) places substance, as existing in itself, in sharp opposition to the properties, and it thereby gets a mystical character, since we know things only through their properties and the connection of these with one another. In SPINOZA, on the other hand, there is an inner relation between substance and its properties (attributes), since each of these expresses the essence of substance. What holds of substance, that it has its ground in itself, holds also of each single attribute. And if the interpretation given above of SPINOZA's substance as the very principle of grounding or of knowledge is correct, the concept of attribute contains the scientific principle that the domains of nature (the spiritual as well as the corporeal) are each to be explained by their own laws. Nature is to be explained by nature itself. — Such an inner relation between theology and science, between the knowledge of God and the knowledge of nature, scholasticism could not recognize. According to it God cannot even stand in a real relation to the world he has created. The world stands in relation to God, namely in a relation of dependence; but God does not stand in relation to the world. The creation has no significance for God's own being²¹. DUNIN-BORKOWSKI accordingly finds the decisive difference between SPINOZA and scholasticism in this, that according to the former there is a relation of reciprocity between the infinite and the

²¹Cf. my *Religionsfilosofi* § 22 and the passages of HUGH OF SAINT VICTOR and THOMAS AQUINAS cited in the note. Cf. on AUGUSTINE the end of § 78.

finite (God and the world), whereas according to the latter the world does indeed stand in a relation to God, but only by way of analogy (which here really means: figuratively) can one speak of God's standing in relation to the world²².

KANT's "Ding an sich" is a residual concept; it expresses that something always remains over when scientific work comes to an end. It is at the same time a limiting concept and a problematic concept, and — what KANT does not always hold fast — doubt can always be raised whether the limit is fixed in the right way. As we have seen in the Introduction, SPINOZA admits that a remainder always remains; only he maintains, and rightly, that this does not rob the knowledge that has really been won of its significance. The criterion of truth is for him (as we shall see in a later connection) the agreement of thought with itself within the world of experience.

γ. The concept of attribute denotes a property in which the essence of substance, as existing in itself and intelligible through itself, shows itself. SPINOZA enjoins (10 Schol.) what ARNAULD and REGIUS had already maintained against DESCARTES, that one has no right, from two attributes being irreducible to each other, to conclude that different beings or substances lie behind them. On the contrary, the more reality or perfection a being possesses, the more different attributes it must possess, and the concept of God is, according to SPINOZA, the concept of a substance that has infinitely many attributes, each of which expresses eternity and infinity (Def. 6 and Proposition 11). The proof of God's existence coincides with the proof of the existence of substance, except that with the concept of God the thought of reality or perfection is of decisive significance. It stands for SPINOZA as absurd that the perfect should not exist, — that only finite, limited beings with few properties should exist, but not an infinite being with infinitely many properties. "Perfection", he says (11 Schol.), "does not take away the existence of a thing, but on the contrary grounds it, whereas imperfection takes it away. Therefore we can be certain of the existence of no thing as of God's, the existence of the absolutely infinite and perfect being." In the sixth definition of the second book reality and perfection are expressly declared one and the same, and in the appendix to the first book SPINOZA rejects the standard of perfection taken from the relation of things to human needs and human wishes: "The perfection of things is to be judged solely by their nature and their power."

²²*Der junge Spinoza*, p. 354: "Dem Verhältnis der Abhängigkeit des Geschöpfes vom Schöpfer entspricht in der unendlichen Ursache kein wirkliches Gegenverhältnis". DUNIN-BORKOWSKI ascribes to this difference "eine ungeheure Tragweite".

There is nevertheless a valuation hidden in SPINOZA's concept of perfection, even if it [22] is made one with the concept of reality. Precisely in this identification there is expressed a deep admiration for the fullness of existence as that which oversteps all limits, as regards richness of quality, time and space alike. The same enthusiasm stirs here for the richness and unboundedness of nature that in MONTAIGNE lay behind his apparent scepticism as well as behind his sense for the manifoldness of individualities, — that made BRUNO burst the bounds of the old picture of the world, — and that also inspired the great Italian artists. LEONARDO DA VINCI was, as JULIUS LANGE has said²³, “in love with the manifoldness of the world”. There is here also an aesthetic element in SPINOZA's view of the world. He admires the power and fullness of nature, which has been able to let both the great and the small, both the good and the evil, both the useful and the harmful come into being (see the closing words of the appendix to the first book). Accordingly he does not merely make reality one with perfection, but declares that perfection and beauty are closely related concepts (Ep. 54).

SPINOZA really rejects the concept of value only when one wants to use it to explain individual, special phenomena of nature. On the other hand he applies it to the innermost ground and highest law of nature when he identifies God and substance and declares reality and perfection one. The urge to value has not vanished in SPINOZA, but it has once and for all come to rest in the fundamental thought of the great conformity to law of existence as determining all that, for finite beings, comes to stand as good or evil. For SPINOZA personally, as the autobiographical hints at the beginning of the treatise on “the improvement of the understanding” show, the knowledge of truth had come to stand as the highest human good, and at the end of the fifth book “the intellectual love of God” is grounded in its being the divine order of nature that makes such knowledge possible. Here there was for SPINOZA a value that had to have its ground deep in the nature of existence.

δ. In the assumption of infinitely many attributes the relation between SPINOZA's religious-speculative line of thought and the knowledge from experience on which he always lays weight shows itself in a peculiar way. For SPINOZA admits, as we have already seen in the Introduction, that he does not know all the divine attributes, not even the

²³ *Udvalgte Skrifter*, II, p. 239. — For MONTAIGNE and BRUNO reference is made to *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*². I, p. 26; 30 and p. 111; 117–123.

greater part of them. In the fifth axiom of the second book it is laid down that we do not feel or perceive any things (modes) other than those that fall under the attributes of thought or extension, that is, souls and bodies, and in Ep. 64 it is explained that this comes from human nature neither presupposing nor offering any attributes other than these two. When SPINOZA nevertheless (Ep. 55) claims an exact knowledge of God, it must be because he is convinced that the logical relation between ground and consequence is the same within all attributes, which, after all, according to the interpretation given in the foregoing, lies in their all being attributes of the same substance. Only an infinite understanding (*intellectus infinitus*) would be able to comprise thoughts expressing the infinitely many attributes. That SPINOZA assumes such an *intellectus infinitus* we shall come to see later. [23]

The very idea of an infinite number of attributes is of Neoplatonic origin. For PLOTINUS the principle of existence was an absolute unity that enclosed in itself a fullness that could not be exhausted in any existence or grasped by any thought. In medieval scholasticism this thought always lay in the background, but it was refracted by the rationalist character of scholastic theology. After DESCARTES had sharply marked off the life of the soul and matter as the two domains of our inquiry, the question naturally came forward by what right we assume that these two domains completely express the content of existence. In a work approximately contemporary with SPINOZA's *Ethica*, MALEBRANCHE comes to this question. "One must not claim", he says (*Recherche de la vérité*. III, 2, 9), "that there are only minds and bodies, beings that can think and beings that are extended. That could be a mistake. For although they suffice to explain nature, and although one can therefore conclude, without fear of being mistaken, that the natural things we can know depend on extension and on thought, there may yet be other beings of which we have no idea and whose effects we do not see. It is then a hasty judgement that men pass when they set it up as an indubitable principle that every being must be either a soul or a body." — The difference between MALEBRANCHE and SPINOZA on this point is only that where MALEBRANCHE, as a Cartesian, speaks of beings or substances, SPINOZA speaks of attributes of one and the same substance.

There is not, as has sometimes been thought, any self-contradiction in the assumption of infinitely many attributes. But a positive proof of this assumption SPINOZA would not be able to give. His most acute correspondent, TSCHIRNHAUSEN, accordingly urged him in

vain to give one. No more has he been able to give an explanation of how the manifoldness of the attributes can be derived from the unity of substance. This difficulty is, however, the same whether only two or infinitely many attributes are assumed. TSCHIRNHAUSEN touches on yet another difficulty, namely how it is known that all attributes stand on the same level. These questions of TSCHIRNHAUSEN's (Ep. 65–66; 70) still stand. In an earlier letter (Ep. 9) to a younger friend SPINOZA had declared that he had two proofs of the manifoldness of the attributes — the one, that the more reality a being has, the more attributes must be ascribed to it; — the other, that the more attributes a being has, the more we are compelled to take it to be real. — Against both these “proofs”, however, stands the fact, acknowledged by SPINOZA himself, that we do after all know only two attributes, and that the surest knowledge of reality we have is built up on the basis of them. — In the Short Treatise SPINOZA appealed to a presentiment we have that there exist other sides of existence than those we know; and he had not given up the hope of coming to know them (K. Tr. I, 1, 7. Note and VII, 1, 1. Note). In the letters and in the *Ethica* this thought does not appear.

SPINOZA could quite simply have kept to the spiritual and the material standing [24] to each other not in a contradictory but only in a contrary relation, since we have no guarantee that all the sides of existence should appear within our experience. Just as little as our experience can be said to be exhaustive with regard to the number of things (modes), spiritual and corporeal, just so little may it be said to be exhaustive with regard to the number of the main kinds of existence it reveals to us. — This consideration is, as I have sought to show elsewhere²⁴, not without significance for our attitude to the problem of the relation between mind and matter.

As for the equal standing of the infinitely many attributes, it rests, according to SPINOZA, on substance being expressed in all of them according to its essence. If now the essence of substance consists in the very logical relation between ground and consequence, the equal standing can hold only in so far as all attributes have a rational character, contain the possibility of applying logic. But there is in itself nothing to prevent their being otherwise, with regard to character and value, highly different — unless (as SPINOZA does tend to) all character is reduced to logic and all value to “reality”. The thought of infinitely many attributes opens a far larger vent for possibilities than SPINOZA was

²⁴*Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 309 f; 334–338.

aware of. The fact that we know only two attributes sets a narrower limit to a scientific view of the world than he saw.

c. Propositions 15–28.

Closer Determinations of the Concept of God in its Relation to the Concept of the World.

(Unity and Manifoldness).

α . If God is the substance consisting of infinitely many attributes, and if extension is one of these, then extension, the fundamental form in which everything material appears, is a form of God's being. When this astonishes or offends many, it is, SPINOZA thinks, because by matter they understand a chaos of separated elements. But it is only for the imagination, sensuous representation (*imaginatio*), that separated elements exist, just as it is only the imagination that lets extension stand as limited. Extension is continuous, and therefore unlimited and indivisible²⁵. That matter, whose fundamental form is extension in space, is a divine attribute does not therefore mean that God is one with the sum of the material things the senses show us (15 Schol.). It is extension as the object of geometry that SPINOZA gives a place in principle in his philosophy, guided by the decisive significance geometry has for all natural science. Besides, the impossibility asserts itself of deriving the material from the spiritual unless one assumes an incomprehensible act [25] of creation. With equal necessity, according to SPINOZA, God reveals himself in material and in spiritual nature. SPINOZA's attribute of extension corresponds to what DESCARTES in the synopsis of his Meditations (*Synopsis Meditationum*) calls "body in general" (*corpus generaliter sumptum*) as opposed to the individual bodies. As DUNIN-BORKOWSKI shows²⁶, attempts were made among the scholastics from the end of the Middle Ages to form a concept of existence in space that could fit both God and finite beings; but with them there was only a question of analogy between divine and material space, not of their identity. — The relation between SPINOZA and NEWTON with regard to the concept of extension has been spoken of in the Introduction.

²⁵HUAN (*Le Dieu de Spinoza*, p. 14) reverses the relation, in that he thinks SPINOZA relies on indivisibility to prove that extension is a divine attribute. But SPINOZA's polemic against the divisibility of matter is only to clear away an obstacle, not to be a proof. Indivisibility follows, like infinity, from continuity. Cf. what was remarked above on series formation.

²⁶*Der junge Spinoza*, p. 357–360; 573.

As was to be expected, SPINOZA's conception of the attribute of extension in its relation to the things that sensation shows us is analogous to his conception of the attribute of thought in its relation to the things that psychological observation shows us. Just as he warns against making matter as a divine attribute one with sensuous matter, so he also warns against conceiving the attribute of thought as one with the states and activities of the soul that psychological observation teaches us to know. Understanding and will cannot belong to God's being in the sense in which they can be used of men. Human understanding shows itself in thinking elaboration and observation, and so presupposes a given material; but for God there can be nothing distinct from him and his thought that would only now have to be worked up into the form of thought: for then God would indeed be dependent and limited! And human willing always strives towards an aim not yet reached; such striving can be thought only in finite beings. For God everything stands in eternal completion, without succession in time (*simul natura*). Only the name could divine and human understanding and will have in common — like the Dog Star and the dog, the barking animal on earth (17 Schol.). — It is of interest to see that KANT in all three of his principal works comes to the same result. For him too only a word remains when one wants to apply psychological expressions to God²⁷. The founding critical philosophy here comes, then, to the same conclusion as the most thoroughgoing dogmatic philosophy.

When SPINOZA nevertheless conceives "thought" as a divine attribute, he undertakes a reduction and idealization of spiritual things similar to the one he undertakes of material things in the attribute "extension". In both places it must be understood thus, that the attribute means the conformity to law that holds within one of the essential sides from which existence can be seen, — a conformity to law that is the condition of the existence of the individual things. Thought as a divine attribute means that the ideal of knowledge exists, is not first to be attained, but is an eternal reality in which it is the task of the man who seeks truth to gain a share. When SPINOZA in his theologico-political treatise (Ch. 14) says that the God of the positive religions has significance as a practical model [26] (*exemplar veræ vitæ*), the same really holds, although SPINOZA would not acknowledge it, of the God of his philosophy. Under the attribute of thought SPINOZA's God is the eternal ideal of truth, and also, by having the ground in himself, the eternal ideal of freedom.

²⁷ *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², II, p. 95.

β. That all individual beings (modes, *res particulares*) that appear as things in our experience spring from God's being as closer determinations of it (*affectiones substantiæ*), SPINOZA grounds in their presupposing substance and the attributes (15–16; 25). It is, as we have seen earlier, the scientific investigation of spiritual and material phenomena that leads to the knowledge of the conformity to law of nature and through it to the knowledge of God or substance. But — it is now maintained in Proposition 28 — what is finite and has a limited existence cannot be derived from the absolute nature of any divine attribute, for from this only what is itself infinite can follow. A finite thing finds its explanation only in another finite thing, this in a third, and so on to infinity. — The principle that SPINOZA maintains here coincides, as already stated in the Introduction, with what one might call the principle of the valid cause, KEPLER's *vera causa*. What appears in experience is to be explained by a cause that can itself be shown in experience²⁸. GALILEO applied this principle in his dialogues when he maintained that in the middle of a special investigation (e.g. of the relation of the earth to the sun) one could not appeal to an intervention by God. And his grounds are the same as SPINOZA's: from an infinite cause follow infinite effects; God is the cause of everything, but in the individual case the task is to find the special causal relation.

The opposition, not to say contradiction, that undeniably exists between Proposition 15 and Proposition 28 can be removed within SPINOZA's presuppositions if one takes as the basis the conception of SPINOZA's concept of substance put forward in the foregoing. When a thing given in experience can be explained by another, and an infinite series of finite causes and effects can thus be formed, then precisely in the law that binds the members of such a series together a principle expresses itself, an order of things, that is not itself a member of the series and does not itself appear as a thing for observation. And it is such a principle that SPINOZA has expressed in his concept of substance and in the concept of attribute partly identical with it. On this conception the two concepts of cause with which SPINOZA operates can be joined. That a thing is explained by its place in the series of things means the same as that it is explained by substance (or by the attribute). Thereby a proposition such as Eth. V, 24 is understood: "The more we understand individual things, the more we understand God."

²⁸In Eth. II, 17 Schol. SPINOZA uses the expression *vera causa* in this way. Otherwise he uses the expression *causa proxima*.

It seems to me that the agreement (or at any rate freedom from contradiction) that becomes possible in this way between the two important Propositions 15 and 28 speaks in favour of the conception of SPINOZA's concept of substance that I have put forward.

But a difficulty still remains, which follows from the identification of ground and cause in SPINOZA's system. The relation between ground and consequence is timeless ("eternal"); the relation between cause and effect presupposes (in so far as it is different from the relation between ground and consequence) a temporal relation. There is a temporal relation, not merely a relation of grounding, between the members of the causal series. Thereby a difference of principle nevertheless remains between modes (things) as members of the causal series that can be built on the ground of experience, and the relation of partial identity in which the individual mode stands to substance. Besides, the individual modes each have their qualitative peculiarity. The problem in SPINOZA, as for modern standpoints in the theory of knowledge, is the relation between the timeless and qualityless world of logic and mathematics and the world of experience, which is the world of qualitative changes. This world presupposes the former if it is to be understood, but cannot be derived from it. TSCHIRNHAUSEN already pointed out that motion and figure cannot be derived from the general attribute of extension, and that the difference and manifoldness of things cannot in general be derived from substance or the attribute in their absolute unity (Ep. 59. 80. 82). [27]

That SPINOZA noticed the problem is seen from his inserting an intermediate concept between substance (and the attributes) on the one side and the concrete things (modes) on the other. This intermediate concept is the concept of the *modus infinitus* (23). Infinite modes spring (see 28 Schol.) immediately or mediately from the essence of substance or of the attributes and are eternal like them. As examples he names under the attribute of thought the infinite understanding, and under the attribute of extension the constant relation between rest and motion (Eth. I, 21. 30. V, 23. 40 Schol.; cf. Ep. 32 and 64). These concepts already appear in the Short Treatise, and SPINOZA there (I, 2), as in Ep. 73, calls their objects "sons of God", to signify that they stand in a closer relation to substance than the finite modes.

If we try to translate these half-mythological expressions into the language of the theory of knowledge, SPINOZA's view can be said to be that the persistence of the life of thought and of motion in the world under all vicissitudes is a consequence of the principle

of grounding or of causality. Just as SPINOZA identifies grounding and causality, so he identifies the proposition of causality and the proposition of the conservation of motion (the imperfect forerunner of the conservation of energy). More recent philosophers too have made this last identification. But just as there is a leap from grounding to causality, so there is also a leap from the proposition that everything has its cause to the proposition that cause and effect are equivalent, and there is again a leap from the general proposition of equivalence to the special, actual transformations that in every individual case take place in a definite direction. Here the critical philosophy must distinguish what SPINOZA identifies²⁹.

That the intermediate members the infinite modes denote do not solve the difficulty lies in this, that the finite modes can no more be derived from them than they can be derived directly from substance. It is a presupposition in SPINOZA that there are, after all, finite things. Therefore, as we shall see later, experience is the first step on the scale of knowledge, and therefore it is only experience that teaches us that modes exist at all (Ep. 10). SPINOZA's philosophy is an attempt to climb up by analysis of the data of experience to attributes and substance. The infinite modes are rungs on this ladder. SPINOZA, without being clearly aware of it, pulls the ladder up after him, so that a deductive descent does not become possible. [28]

The opposition between an elementary and an ideal causal relation, which always asserts itself in scientific work, has in SPINOZA crystallized into an opposition between a world of qualitatively different things (modes), which arise and succeed one another in time, and a system of eternal thoughts, within which continuity reigns (within each individual attribute) and in the end identity (in substance). The former world is a revelation of the latter system appearing to sensation, memory and imagination. Why and how, besides substance, attributes exist, besides the attributes eternal modes, and besides these eternal modes modes differing in quality and determined in time, — or why, besides pure thinking (*intellectus*), sensuous representation (*imaginatio*) also exists, — these are questions SPINOZA does not raise, and which, for that matter, neither he nor anyone else would be able to answer. All science, philosophy too, works with certain presuppositions that can progressively stand their test in the purgatory of experience and criticism, but which cannot be shown to be the only possible ones. SPINOZA's successor in the history

²⁹Cf. on these matters *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 211–215; 281–287.

of philosophy, LEIBNIZ, expressed this in the proposition that the success of a hypothesis does not prove its truth.

d. Propositions 29–36.

Closer Examination of the Relation between the Fundamental Being and the Individual Beings.

α. Besides the concepts substance and God, which (when substance is thought with infinitely many attributes) are identical, there is yet a third concept that becomes identical with them both, so that SPINOZA says “God or nature” (*deus seu natura*, e.g. *Eth. IV*, Preface), just as he says God or substance. This concept is suited to suggest a connection between the two worlds which, as we have just seen, threaten to come into sharp opposition to each other.

After it has been said in 29 that in the nature of things (*in rerum natura*) there is nothing contingent, but that everything is determined by the necessity of the divine nature (*ex necessitate divinæ naturæ*) to exist and act in a definite way, it says in the scholium (29 Schol.): “Before I go further, I will explain, or rather recall, what I understand by nature producing (*natura naturans*), and what I understand by nature produced (*natura naturata*). I think it is sufficiently clear from the foregoing that by nature producing one must understand that which is in itself and is understood through itself, or, what is the same, such attributes (*attributa*) of substance as express eternity and infinity, that is, God in so far as he is regarded as a free cause. By nature produced, on the other hand, I understand everything that follows from the necessity of God's nature or (what is the [29] same) of a divine attribute, that is, all the individual beings determined by the divine attributes (*dei attributorum modi*), in so far as they are regarded as things that are in God and without God can neither be nor be conceived.” — In other words, to *natura naturans* belong the attributes, to *natura naturata* the modes.

As we have seen earlier, SPINOZA set up the concept of infinite modes and stated that such can follow either immediately from the attributes, or mediately, namely through the infinite modes that have arisen immediately (21–23; 28 Schol.). Both these kinds of infinite modes belong, like the finite modes, to *natura naturata*. SPINOZA's most acute correspondent, TSCHIRNHAUSEN, wanted a closer explanation here too and asked for

examples of such infinite modes as sprang immediately, and such as sprang mediately, from God's nature. In his answer (Ep. 64) SPINOZA names as examples of the first kind: within the attribute of thought the infinite understanding, and within the attribute of extension motion and rest (by which, no doubt, as already remarked above, is meant the relation between motion and rest — *ratio motus ad quietem*, as it is put in Ep. 32, that is, the conservation of motion). As an example of the mediately produced infinite modes he names only "the character of the whole universe" (*facies totius universi*, "the physiognomy of the All"), which, despite all changes in the particular, nevertheless remains one and the same, and he refers to the second book, the scholium to the seventh borrowed proposition (Eth. II. Lemma 7. Schol.), where it says that "the whole of nature is one individual, whose parts, that is, all bodies, vary in infinitely many ways without any change in the whole individual". A similar statement is found in Ep. 32, where it says "that every body is surrounded by other bodies, and that all bodies determine one another to be and to act in a certain definite way, yet so that in the whole universe the same relation between rest and motion is preserved". Lowest in the series come then the finite modes, the phenomena of soul and body that are objects of observation.

We thus get the following scheme for SPINOZA's most important concepts:

<i>Substantia.</i>		
	Cogitatio.	Extensio.
		} Natura naturans.
	Intellectus infinitus.	Motus et qvies.
Modi infiniti.	(immediate producta).	
	Facies totius universi.	} Natura naturata.
	(mediate producta).	
Modi finiti.	{ Res singulares (mentes et corpora).	

We see, then, that SPINOZA, as corresponding to "the conservation of motion" in material nature, assumes a spiritual persistence, an infinite thought that remains the same under the alternation of the special spiritual phenomena. From hints given in the fifth book one sees that he thinks of the *intellectus infinitus* as containing the eternal that appears in the individual spiritual beings in a form limited in time and as the correlate of a limited material existence. On the other hand, several students of Spinoza have rightly missed a concept that, within the attribute of thought and subordinate to the *intellectus infinitus*, could correspond to "the physiognomy of the universe", which under [30]

the attribute of extension is subordinated to “the conservation of motion”. Attempts have been made in various ways to construct this missing member of the system. This point is, however, hardly of great significance, although it shows how a system reaches its full articulation only gradually and under the influence of questions and doubts. SPINOZA's own answer to the above-mentioned question of TSCHIRNHAUSEN's is very short and seems written somewhat hastily; he does not even take time to criticize the view of a correspondent according to whom (Ep. 63) the infinite modes that proceed immediately from substance were supposed to be the attributes! This correspondent (SCHULLER) had not made himself familiar with the concept of attribute as that which expresses the very essence of substance. And it is said expressly (23 Dem.) that an infinite mode is an immediate or mediate consequence of the divine nature of an attribute.

The most obvious thing would be to think of a kind of world-soul as the correlate of “the physiognomy of the world” or “the world-individual”. BRUNO sets up such a concept³⁰ as the expression of the force that makes interaction in space possible and also stirs innermost in the individual elements. When BRUNO says of “the world-soul”: *amina tota in toto et qualibet totius parte!* (the whole soul in the whole and in every part of the whole!) — one is reminded by it of the expression that occurs more than once in SPINOZA (*Ethica* II, 37–38; 44): “what occurs in the same way in the part as in the whole”. By this expression SPINOZA has in mind the general laws, whereas BRUNO has in mind a force that carries these laws through in the whole and in the part. This concept was too mystical and poetical for SPINOZA, and he found nothing that could take its place.

For SPINOZA the lawful order of nature, which is conditioned by “the conservation of motion” and the corresponding relations within other attributes, was not an abstraction (a *universale*), but a characteristic side of existence, an individual peculiarity of the unique world we know. The *modi infiniti* are both individual and universal. They probably coincide with what SPINOZA in the treatise on “the improvement of the understanding” calls “the fixed and eternal things, in which the laws of nature are inscribed as in law books”. Of them it is said that “although they are individual (*singularia*), they can yet stand for us as universal (*tanquam universalia*) on account of their omnipresence and comprehensive working; they are as it were general definitions of the changeable things and the nearest grounds of everything”. These fixed and eternal things thus correspond

³⁰ *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 127–129.

to what in the *Ethica* are called *modi infiniti* of the second class (*mediate producta*). In any case this concept bears witness that SPINOZA saw in the order of nature that science discloses a great concrete fact, a unique thing. The general laws serve only to characterize this unique thing. And as will appear later, the knowledge of general laws is not for [31] SPINOZA the highest kind of knowledge³¹.

The question how we rise from the finite modes to “the fixed and eternal things”, and in general to the infinite modes, SPINOZA did not examine more closely. He announces an investigation of “the procedure of the modern empiricists”, but his treatise on the theory of knowledge was not completed, and so this question was not treated by him.

β. When SPINOZA in the definition of *natura naturans* calls God a free cause (29 Schol.), the definition of freedom given from the first (Def. 7), as determination by the nature of one's own being, must be held fast. In Proposition 33, Schol. 2 SPINOZA goes more closely into this question in order to reject the frequent conception of freedom as indifference, an equal possibility of two opposites. Freedom in this last sense would, he thinks, conflict with God's perfection. One likes to think of God first as existing and then as taking his decisions. But for an eternal being there is no “before” or “after”. God's decision is one with his eternal being and can therefore neither begin nor be changed. There is in God no possibility distinct from reality. Yet SPINOZA finds the assumption of an absolute indifference in God less unreasonable than the assumption that God should act for the sake of the good or with the good in view (*sub ratione boni*): that would be to let God strive after a model, an aim, that he has not yet reached, — indeed, it would really make him dependent on a fate (*fatum*), — he who according to the nature of his being is the first cause of everything!

γ. The last proposition of the first book (36) asserts an often misjudged element in SPINOZA's system. It runs: “Nothing exists from whose nature some effect does not follow,” and it is grounded in everything that exists expressing God's nature or essence in a certain definite way (cf. 25–26).

This proposition is of special significance for understanding the part the urge of

³¹This conception of “the fixed and eternal things” is, it seems to me, clearly indicated in *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 302, for which reason HUAN (p. 251) wrongly names me among those who interpret the expression as a designation of general laws. As against HUAN I hold decidedly that *res fixæ et æternæ* are *modi infiniti mediate producti*. — What may perhaps be illuminating here is the demonstration of the significance for the theory of knowledge of typical ideas of individuals: *Totalitet som Kategori* § 12–13.

self-preservation in finite beings plays as the foundation of SPINOZA's psychology and ethics (in the third and fourth books; see, however, already II, 45 Schol.). It is as an element in substance that the individual mode can be said to be cause of itself, to have its ground in itself, although this independence is refracted by the action of other modes, each of which can also be said to have its ground in itself. Every member of the causal series is both cause and effect, although one is inclined to keep to the dependence of the following members on the preceding ones. The refraction of activity and passivity will prove to play a great part in SPINOZA's psychology and ethics.

[32]

e. Appendix to the First Book.

Theology and Science.

α . When SPINOZA asked himself what prevented the recognition of the great connection between the things in the world (*rerum concatenatio*) from becoming general, he found the explanation in men being led in their contemplation of nature by a practical urge, not by an urge for science. They are therefore inclined to believe that everything is arranged for their own good, that which is the object of their own constant striving. From the first they are ignorant of the causes of things, also of the cause of the urge they have to seek their own good. They believe themselves free when they are led by this urge, and they believe that the means of satisfying this urge, in so far as they cannot produce them themselves, are produced by beings resembling themselves. When misfortunes befall them, they derive them from the wrath of the gods over men's sins. And if unsolved riddles still remain, they comfort themselves that the wisdom of the gods far surpasses the understanding of men. Against this whole artificial system (*fabrica*) the cause of truth would have been hopeless had not mathematics, which asks not about purposes but only about the essence and properties of things, given men another norm of truth than the one their blind urge leads them to follow.

The teleological-theological view turns things upside down. It makes the first the last, the cause the effect, the perfect the most imperfect. The eternal order of nature is not the effect of men's urges and wishes, but contains the explanation of men's being able to feel urges and cherish wishes at all. And the perfect is one with the eternal order

of nature, which rests on no presupposition; the imperfect is that which presupposes many conditions. The theological view makes God imperfect by letting him strive after something he still lacks. And it introduces a wholly new way of thinking: instead of proving something by establishing the impossibility of the opposite (*reductio ad impossibile*) it appeals to ignorance (*reductio ad ignorantiam*). And God's incomprehensible will becomes the last refuge of ignorance (*asylum ignorantiae*). Whoever seeks natural causes of what awakens wonder and awe is regarded as an impious heretic by the persons in whom the great mass sees interpreters of the essence of nature and of the will of the gods. And these persons see well enough that if ignorance were removed, the thoughtless awe (*stupor*) would also vanish, without which their authority cannot be kept up³².

One cannot at all, SPINOZA continues, use concepts such as good and evil, order and confusion, beautiful and ugly to explain nature, since such concepts are due to human needs and do not come from any connection that can be shown in nature. And when one complains of the many imperfections in nature, one forgets that it is not human benefit and harm that can supply the standard of perfection and imperfection. The standard [33] must be sought in the very nature and power of things (*ex sola rerum natura et potentia*)³³. If one then asks why God did not create men so that they were led by reason alone, the answer must be that the laws of nature are so comprehensive that everything an infinite understanding could think, from the highest degree of perfection to the lowest, could find its place.

This whole line of thought is highly characteristic of SPINOZA. He stands here as one who asserts the right of the strict scientific method, and also as one who is convinced that by carrying this method through fully nothing is lost of what really has value. Only, men must not measure the value of existence by the needs of their own little world. Within the human world the concepts of value whose cosmic validity he rejects have their justification, as he tries to show in the fourth book.

It is, as already mentioned, a concept of value after all that SPINOZA uses when he identifies perfection and reality. When in the fourth book he goes over to a specially human theory of value, there therefore arises not only a refraction between cosmology and

³²In Ep. 73 SPINOZA distinguishes between religion and superstition thus, that the former is grounded in wisdom, the latter in ignorance.

³³From the identity of reality and perfection it follows that what has no perfection at all cannot exist. Therefore the Devil cannot exist! (*Den korte Traktat*, II, 25).

ethics, but also a refraction between two measures of value. To this we shall come back in its place. Here it need only be remarked that whereas SPINOZA from the cosmological point of view determines the perfect as that which has no presuppositions, from the specially human point of view (which he himself adopts in the fourth book) it must conversely be said that the perfect is precisely that which rests on the most presuppositions. Life has more presuppositions than the lifeless, the life of the soul than merely organic life, the ethical, intellectual and aesthetic life than the elementary life of the soul. The doctrine of categories shows that the concepts of value are the most special of all our fundamental concepts³⁴.

β. In the dispute about SPINOZA's philosophy called forth by JACOBI's "Briefe über die Lehre des SPINOZA" (1785), especially by the oral utterances of LESSING that JACOBI quoted, the question came forward in particular whether everything could be derived from the thought of a highest purpose. In a conversation with JACOBI, LESSING had called himself a Spinozist and declared it a prejudice that thought should be the first and highest; extension and motion are, just as much as thought, grounded in a higher force that is not exhausted in these forms. He had spoken against "unsere elende Art, nach Absichten zu handeln" being held the best method. Besides SPINOZA, LESSING may here have been influenced by HUME, whose "Dialogues on Natural Religion" had appeared shortly before. The conversation between LESSING and JACOBI took place in the summer of 1780. When it became known, it aroused great attention and offence, since the popular theology of the Enlightenment (which, it had been believed, LESSING too held) was overthrown if one could not infer God's existence from the purposiveness of nature³⁵.

According to JACOBI, SPINOZA was an atheist because his philosophy denied God's [34] personality. SPINOZA himself had rejected this designation, which he thought was due to the misunderstanding that he made God dependent on fate. On the contrary, he says (Ep. 43), I hold that everything follows with inevitable necessity from God's nature. For SPINOZA, after all, freedom and necessity do not exclude each other. And he points out besides that in his view the ethical ideals are independent of whether we derive them from God as judge or from the eternal necessity of the divine nature.

It is not easy to decide how SPINOZA's standpoint is to be characterized in the philoso-

³⁴See on this *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 237–241.

³⁵On LESSING's place in the history of philosophy see *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², II, p. 16–25).

phy of religion. It is generally thought that every respectable philosophy must represent some -ism or other, and it is thought besides that one is once and for all in possession of a catalogue of all possible -isms, in which every philosophy must be able to find its place. — As for what is characteristic of SPINOZA, two points above all are of significance. He does not hold the usual theological idea of God and the world as two different beings, but God is for him the innermost being of the world, which makes itself known in its laws. And he denies that the concept of personality can be applied to God, since personality (understanding and will), as we have seen above, presupposes in his view something given that is to be understood, and a resistance that is to be overcome for the sake of a purpose. In the concept of pantheism, which TOLAND introduced at the beginning of the eighteenth century, and which is usually taken to express an inner relation between God and the world and to deny God's personality, it has often been thought that one had a rubric into which SPINOZA could fit. But according to SPINOZA, after all, thought (*cogitatio*), although everything cannot be derived from it, is an eternal attribute of substance, even though the special forms we call understanding and will do not belong to "nature producing". In the concept of this attribute there lies an idealization similar to the one that philosophical theists (such as LOTZE) undertake when they sublimate the concept of personality so that it is supposed to fit a being that is to have its ground in itself. The boundary between pantheism and theism is therefore not easy to draw³⁶.

By this consideration, which has already been put forward in "Den nyere Filosofis Histori" (2nd ed. I, p. 316), I have only wanted to show how difficult it is to bring a deep-going work of thought like SPINOZA's under rubrics fixed in advance. HUAN therefore wrongly names me among those who interpret SPINOZA's concept of God in a theistic direction³⁷. SPINOZA's thought has on the point spoken of here, as on many other points, such an individual peculiarity that it is not easy to classify, but, as HUAN aptly says on the last page of his book, can really only be called — Spinozism!

The boundary between theology and philosophy SPINOZA finds in this, that the former uses psychological expressions of God, whereas the latter denies such expressions [35] any justification. When he warns philosophers against using theological expressions

³⁶See more closely on the concepts of pantheism and theism my *Religionsfilosofi* § 22 and § 95. — On the purely psychological way, adopted there, of considering what underlies these concepts, I have, since I wrote my *Religionsfilosofi*, come to lay ever greater weight.

³⁷*Le dieu de Spinoza*, p. 221.

(Ep. 23), it is this he has in mind. But behind his own presentation, especially in the concluding remark to the first book, there lies a still more fundamental problem, namely the justification of laying concepts of value at the foundation at all in closing our view of the world. SPINOZA himself has kept more of the theological concept of God than he is aware of. His substance, according to the definition, was to contain only the principle of intelligibility (of rationality); but it encloses — through the definition of perfection as reality — a concept of value as well³⁸. The ground SPINOZA gives for this (in the fifth book) is, to be sure, only that it is substance that is the cause of the joy of knowledge. But then the question turns up of the relation between intellectual value and other values.

[36]

Second Book.

a. Definitions and Axioms.

As an introduction to the second book SPINOZA gives some initial determinations and principles that are of interest for the theory of knowledge and for psychology. The content of the second book may be said to be the psychology of knowledge and the investigation of the validity of knowledge (theory of knowledge).

α . Of special importance is Def. 3, according to which an idea (*idea*) is a concept that the soul (*mens*) forms because it is a thinking being. And this definition is explained more closely, the weight being laid on every idea being a product of spiritual activity (*actio mentis*); therefore the word concept (*conceptus*) fits better than the word perception (*perceptio*), which might seem to suggest that consciousness is passive towards its object. — SPINOZA here corrects his own earlier view, since in the Short Treatise he let consciousness stand passive towards its objects and let the one attribute act on the other.

Def. 4 gives a further development of these remarks, in that it determines an adequate idea (*idea adæqvata*) as one that, considered in and for itself and apart from the object, has all the inner properties of a true idea. The outer properties concern the agreement with the object (*ideatum*). What the inner properties are can be seen from the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, where it is said that the form of a true idea

³⁸Cf. my *Religionsfilosofi* § 24 and § 80–89.

rests on its own power and nature and shows itself in the connection between subject and predicate, ground and consequence. This inner connection can lead us out of falsity and doubt and is the real norm of truth. No outer sign of truth can be given; the outer properties of the idea, its agreement with the object, are therefore derived in relation to the inner ones — as can already be seen from Eth. I, Ax. 6, when this axiom is rightly understood. (See above).

When SPINOZA was asked by TSCHIRNHAUSEN what difference there was between an adequate idea (*idea adæqvata*) and a true idea (*idea vera*), he answered (Ep. 60) that at bottom there was no difference, except that the word “true” refers to the agreement of the idea with its object (*ideatum*), whereas the word “adequate” refers to the nature of the idea in and for itself.

From the object of the idea (*objectum* = *ideatum* = *res percepta*) SPINOZA distinguishes (as is seen from Propositions 5, 7, 13 and 15) the content of the idea (*esse formale ideæ*, cf. I, 30 Dem.: *id, quod in intellectu continetur*). The objects of the concepts triangle (I, 11 Dem.) or circle (II, 7 Schol.) are the triangles or circles really existing (*in natura*); the object of the idea in which the soul consists is the body corresponding to the soul. But the content of these concepts is given with their scientific definitions. The objects (triangles, circles, bodies) fall under the attribute of extension, but the content of the concepts belongs to the attribute of thought. [37]

What is striking in this arrangement is, first, that the activity of thought itself, which SPINOZA stresses so strongly in Def. 3 and 4, as well as later on (43 Schol.; 49 Schol.), is not named here. It plainly falls under the attribute of thought, just as much as the conceptual content it leads to fixing, and there might be reason to ask in its case too what corresponds to it under the attribute of extension. It will appear that this point is bound up with an unclarity in SPINOZA's teaching on the relation between the attributes. — Secondly, it is striking that triangles and circles stand on a line with human bodies and are thus regarded as real objects of nature. Thus (II, 7 Schol.) the circle existing in nature is spoken of. This point is bound up with SPINOZA's dogmatic theory of knowledge, according to which a reality corresponds to every scientifically formed concept.

β. The concept of spiritual activity (*actio mentis*) set up by Def. 3 presupposes a definition of activity that SPINOZA, strangely enough, gives only in the second definition of the third book, but which ought to have had its place here. It is not the only occasion

there is for agreeing with LEIBNIZ when he wrote in his own copy of the *Ethica* that demonstration was not SPINOZA's strong side (*SPINOZA non est magnus demonstrator*).

The definition of activity (III, Def. 2) runs thus: "I say that we are active (*agere*) when something happens in us or outside us of which we are the full cause (*adæqvata causa*), that is, when something follows from our nature, in us or outside us, that can be clearly and distinctly understood through it alone. On the other hand I say that we are passive (*pati*) when something happens in us, or follows from our nature, of which we are only partly the cause (*causa partialis*)."

In this definition it is implied that we are never wholly passive, whereas we might very well be absolutely active, that is, the full cause of something that happens in us or outside us. Now to be the full cause is, according to the seventh definition of the first book, one with being free. Full activity or freedom becomes for SPINOZA an ideal (*exemplar*) towards which ethical striving is directed (IV, Preface), and in a series of propositions (IV, 67–73) he describes the free man as the summit of human development. But in experience, as we shall see SPINOZA himself admit, every individual being (mode) is both active and passive. Only substance is absolutely active.

We can, however, still use SPINOZA's definition of activity if we alter it thus: We are the more active, the more the cause of our states and actions lies in ourselves, — the more passive, the more their cause lies outside us.

γ. For SPINOZA's psychology Ax. 3 is of interest. It states that such modes of the soul [38] (*modi cogitandi*) as love, desire (*cupiditas*) and so on presuppose ideas of what is loved, desired and so on, but that there can be ideas without other modes of the soul being present.

SPINOZA is of course right that we cannot love or desire without an idea of what we love or desire. But he overlooks that there can be elementary feelings, such as anxiety, well-being, low spirits, and besides these urge and striving, without there being any idea present of the object of (the cause of) these states. He himself acknowledges this in the scholium to the ninth proposition of the third book, where he distinguishes between the blind urge of self-preservation (*appetitus*) and desire (*cupiditas*), the latter of which presupposes an idea of an object. Indeed, he even adds that we do not need something or will it because it is good, but conversely hold it good because we need it and will it. A refraction appears here between intellectualism and voluntarism, which is characteristic

of SPINOZA's psychology and to which we shall come back later. Here it need only be added that it is in the highest degree doubtful whether SPINOZA is right that there can be ideas without any degree whatever of feeling or urge.

The fifth axiom, that we know no things other than bodies and modes of thought, we have already discussed above.

b. Propositions 1–10.

The Relation between the Attributes.

α . To grasp rightly SPINOZA's teaching on the relation between the attributes, one must hold fast that in SPINOZA, even more than in other philosophers before the eighteenth century, the definite distinction between different philosophical problems that is now gradually making its way is lacking. Religion, view of the world (cosmology), theory of knowledge, ethics, psychology — all the endeavours and tasks denoted by these words are so entwined in SPINOZA that it can be difficult to disentangle them, and that an attempt to do so easily leads to reading too modern a line of thought into this thinker of the Renaissance. As for the relation between the attributes, it is above all the difference between theory of knowledge and psychology (or psychophysics) that we have to deal with.

What SPINOZA puts forward in the first six propositions of the second book about the mutual relation of the attributes is a consequence of the second and fourth definitions of the first book, a consequence already drawn in the tenth proposition of the first book. If every attribute is to express the essence of substance, and if the essence of substance consists in having its ground (or cause) in itself, then every attribute must also contain the ground (or cause) of all the things that fall under it, and no explanation can be fetched from other attributes.

But the question then lies near, what led SPINOZA to set up a definition of the concept of attribute that entails such consequences. Of the motives of thought that asserted themselves on this point we have already spoken in the Introduction (see above). The one motive is scientific and is due to the conception of the method and principles of the new science that SPINOZA had won in the interval between the writing of the Short Treatise and the working out of the *Ethica*, and that demanded that every material thing [39]

be explained by another material thing which, like it, could be shown in experience. The other motive belongs to the theory of knowledge. The criterion of truth proves in the end to consist in the mutual agreement of thoughts and therefore demands that every thought be derived from another thought.

These two motives of thought have in SPINOZA mutually lit up each other. For the continuity in principle that natural science found or demanded in the material domain, and that had already led DESCARTES to conceive everything material as a single substance, SPINOZA naturally sought a counterpart in the spiritual domain. But from II, 1. Schol. and 6. Cor. one sees that the domain of thought itself offered him a lawful connection that could serve as a model for research in the material domain. In 1. Schol. it is shown how series of thoughts can be built that can be continued to infinity by the same law, and in Proposition 2 this is then transferred by analogy to the attribute of extension. In 6. Cor. it says that in the same way and with the same necessity as thoughts follow from the attribute of thought, the objects (*res ideatæ*) follow and are inferred from their different attributes. Here, then, one infers from the inner connection within the attribute of thought to a corresponding connection within other attributes. The only one of these other attributes that experience makes known to us (Ax. 5) is extension. The transfer of the concept of series formation by immanent laws from the attribute of thought to the attribute of extension meant for SPINOZA, who, following DESCARTES³⁹ in this, found the essence of bodies exhausted in purely geometrical properties (see Def. 1), that this concept must hold for all bodies as well. That all bodies are at rest or in faster or slower motion he maintains later in the book (in the two axioms after Proposition 13) as a fact of experience, whose relation to the definition of corporeality as extension he does not examine; in his last years, however, he expressed doubt about the correctness of the Cartesian definition (see Ep. 81 and 83). — That there is such a corresponding connection within every attribute is, on the interpretation of SPINOZA's fundamental concepts set out in the foregoing, what SPINOZA denoted by saying that every attribute in its own way expresses the essence of substance.

A third motive too has certainly been at work, namely the decided rejection of all teleology that SPINOZA pronounces, not only in the appendix to the first book, but in

³⁹*Principia Philosophiæ*, II, 10–11. (Space and body differ only as genus and species, which shows itself clearly in this, that even if we think of all sensible properties as diminishing in degree, so that they vanish for us, space still remains).

several places in the course of the book. His criticism of the theological concept of God and his conception of scientific method worked in the same direction here. All teleology presupposes that a thought or plan is the cause of changes in nature; but that would [40] presuppose, partly that there should be no inner lawful connection in nature, partly that there should be a difference in God's being between thought and power.

In SPINOZA himself, however, no sharp distinction certainly made itself felt between these different motives of thought, which we have here disentangled one by one.

β. In Proposition 7, which states that the order and connection of ideas is the same as the order and connection of things, the hypothesis of identity is stated as holding for the attribute of thought in relation to all other attributes. For by things must here be understood all things within all these other attributes. What is meant by ideas is seen from the demonstration, which refers to the fourth axiom of the first book: "The concept (*idea*) of the effect depends on the concept (*idea*) of the cause and presupposes it." It is clear that the ideas spoken of here are scientifically formed thoughts with their clear and definite content — what SPINOZA (see above p. 36) calls *esse formale idearum*⁴⁰. It is to this clarified content of thought that "things" correspond, the mutual dependence of things corresponding to the dependence of the consequence (the effect) on the ground (the cause). One sees clearly here how substance finds expression in the different attributes: the relation between ground and consequence is presupposed in them all, is what is identical in them all (however many they may be).

In the scholium to the seventh proposition the hypothesis of identity is applied specially to the relation between the two attributes we know from experience. "The thinking and the extended substance", it says, "are one and the same substance, which is now regarded under this attribute, now under that. And so also a mode of extension and the idea of this mode are one and the same thing, only expressed in two ways... So long as we regard things as modes of thought, we must explain the whole order of nature, or the connection of causes, by the attribute of thought alone, and so long as we

⁴⁰ *Formalis* means in SPINOZA what we call objective. And just as we speak not only of objective objects as opposed to mere thoughts, but also of objective thoughts as opposed to associations of ideas, fancies and feelings, so SPINOZA too speaks both of *essentia formalis attributorum dei* (Eth. II, 40 Schol. 2), that is, of objects, and of *esse formale idearum* (Eth. II, 5), that is, of the content of thought. — With regard to the terminology it must further be noted that "objective" (7 Cor.) means what we would call "subjectively", since it is used as the opposite of *formaliter*. See especially I, 30 Dem., where "objective" stands in opposition to "in Natura".

regard things as modes of extension, the whole order of nature must be explained by the attribute of extension alone. And the same holds, in my view, of the other attributes. God is the cause of things as they are in themselves⁴¹, because he consists of infinitely many attributes.”

As the proposition is set up here, it is of the kind that belongs to the theory of [41] knowledge and concerns the relation between scientifically formed thoughts (objective concepts) and other sides of existence. This is seen not only from the reference to the KABBALA's teaching of God, whose understanding and what he understands are one and the same; it is seen also from SPINOZA's example: the relation between the circle existing in nature and the concept of the circle.

But as is seen in what follows (Propositions 11–13 and III, 2. Schol.), SPINOZA regards the relation between soul and body as a special case of the relation between knowledge (that is: scientific concepts) and its objects, and so passes, without noticing it, from theory of knowledge to psychology (or psychophysics). The relation between the mathematical concept of a circle and the circle existing in nature is after all a different one from the relation between the concept as a psychical product and the physiological process to which it is in some way or other bound, and which must fall under the attribute of extension just as much as “the existing circle”. — The confusion becomes clearer still when we ask how it stands with the activity of thought that leads to the forming of scientific (objective, “formal”) concepts. Does not something within the attribute of extension correspond to this too? And the matter becomes clearest of all when we ask how it stands with wrong formations of concepts and self-contradictory ideas. One can suppose that certain physiological (cerebral) processes correspond to these too. But SPINOZA quite certainly does not suppose that anything whatever that “exists in nature”

⁴¹The expression “things as they are in themselves” occurs in SPINOZA in different connections and therefore in different senses. 1) In II, 7. Schol. it denotes things in so far as they are regarded under all possible attributes (which human thought cannot do). 2) In II, 44 Dem. (with reference to I, 29) it denotes things in their necessity as opposed to the way in which they stand for mere observation. 3) In the remarkable letter (Ep. 6) in which SPINOZA discusses some experiments of BOYLE's, concepts such as motion, rest and their laws (these “chaste concepts”, *notiones castæ*) are said to express nature as it is in itself, as opposed to ideas (such as colour, cold, heat, solidity, fluidity and so on), which express only their relation to human sensation. In this sense the word is also used by LOCKE, who (Essay II, 8, 23) says of “the primary qualities” (figure, number, motion and so on) that they are in things whether we perceive them or not, so that they give us “the idea of the thing, as it is in itself”. This sense comes from GALILEO, HOBBS and DESCARTES. 4) Finally the expression “*res in se consideratæ*” is used in the preface to the fourth book (see also IV, 73 Schol.) to denote the opposite of the concepts of value one is inclined to apply to things.

corresponds to the idea “square circle”.

It is SPINOZA's dogmatism that led him to confuse two problems. Like all dogmatic philosophers and natural scientists he is certain that absolute realities must correspond to our concepts formed by strict method (see above p. 16 f). And his strict conception of the inner connection of material nature made it impossible for him to assume an action of the one attribute on the other; states of the soul therefore became for him another expression of certain material states, and conversely. These two relations he has identified. And so now his dogmatic theory of knowledge, now his realist psychophysics has the word. — We shall have occasion several times more to speak of this question.

γ. In Propositions 8—10 it is enjoined that the concept of substance cannot be used of a man, as scholasticism and in part even DESCARTES had taught on account of a vaguer concept of substance. Man is an individual being, a mode, and is as such a member of a series of individual beings. He has his cause in God, not in so far as God is regarded as an infinite being, but in so far as God's being shows itself in the lawful connection of the individual beings. In the divine attributes there are contained possibilities of infinitely many individual beings, just as in a circle there is the possibility of an infinite number of chords cutting one another, whose segments form equal rectangles, whereas in each individual case only a finite number can be given. In this comparison, which is found in the scholium to the eighth proposition, the circle corresponds to substance, the chords to the modes. [42]

c. Propositions 11—15.

On the Relation between Soul and Body.

α. The general relation between thought and extension, which in the foregoing has been determined as a consequence of the relation between attributes in general, is now applied specially to the relation between soul and body. These, then, relate as the idea (*idea*) relates to its object (*res*). The body (*corpus*) is the individual thing (*res singularis*) that corresponds to consciousness (*mens*).

When it says in Proposition 13: “The object of the idea that constitutes the human consciousness (*mens*) is a body, a certain mode of extension, and nothing else”, the meaning must be that man's peculiarity consists in a mode of extension corresponding to

his thought, and not a mode of one of the other attributes. In the demonstration given of this proposition reference is made to Ax. 5, which lays down that we feel or perceive no individual things other than bodies and modes of thought. — Now SPINOZA does assume, after all, that there are infinitely many attributes, all standing in a proportional relation to one another. What holds of human consciousness in relation to the attribute of extension must therefore consistently hold of it in relation to any other attribute whatever, although here the one member of the relation is *x*. (Cf. above p. 22–24).

What holds of man must (13 Schol.) hold also of all individual beings within our experience, by virtue of the general relation between the attribute of thought and that of extension. All individual beings must be animate (*animata*), although in different degrees. The difference between the different beings with souls corresponds to the difference between the different bodies, which above all offer highly different relations between activity and passivity. Already as regards man himself there are great fundamental differences in this respect. The more active and independent the body is, that is, the more its functions depend on itself, the more perfect will the knowledge of the soul also be. Obscurity and clarity in the life of thought correspond to passivity and activity — in the case of soul and body alike. By the obscure ideas SPINOZA has in mind, as far as one can see, sensations of life and elementary feelings of pleasure and pain and mere associations of ideas, perhaps also the obscure urge that is not aware of its aim. According to Def. 3 the word *idea* really denotes only actively formed thoughts; but in Ax. 3 a distinction is made between such thoughts and other modes of thought (*amor, cupiditas* and other *affectus animi*). As already remarked (see above p. 38), a difficulty appears here for SPINOZA's psychology, since these passive elements are always to presuppose the active ones, but not conversely.

β. After Proposition 13 SPINOZA inserts a series of borrowed propositions (*lemmata*) from physics, naturally as he understood the physics of his time. After first laying down [43] that no body is a substance, he sets up the principle of inertia (Lemma 3), which has already been mentioned above (p. 9 f). Next it is maintained that from motion follows motion, from rest only rest. — Here one clearly sees the main difficulty in the Cartesian physics, which was first removed by LEIBNIZ, namely how a thing at rest can come into motion, or a thing in motion come to rest, when rest and motion are two wholly different states. HOBBS, for that matter, following in GALILEO's track, had already indicated the

possibility of a solution through the concept of the tendency to motion (*conatus*), which does not vanish because it is checked by an opposite tendency to motion⁴².

Then it is presented purely dogmatically how the simple elements of which bodies consist bring about, by their different relations of position, the difference between the states of aggregation, between solid, soft and fluid bodies. Several bodies can in turn be joined into a whole through common working, a whole that can persist even if the individual parts change. From such wholes more composite individual wholes can arise in turn, and in the end the whole of nature makes up one great individual, whose parts, the individual bodies, are changed in many ways without change in nature as a whole. — What SPINOZA here calls “the whole of nature” is plainly the same as what in other places (see above p. 29) is called “the character of the whole universe” (the physiognomy of the world), and which through the constant relation between rest and motion has its ground in the attribute of extension.

That the individual changes in the world (*variatio rerum*) cannot be derived from the attribute of extension, and that DESCARTES wrongly defines matter as mere extension, SPINOZA admits in the last letter (Ep. 83) we have from his hand, and he announces a closer discussion that he never came to undertake.

Finally it is laid down (in the form of postulates) that the human body is composed of smaller wholes that are different from one another and each composite, — that the action of other bodies can leave traces (*vestigia*), which consist in one of the fluid parts of the body affected changing a soft part by altering its position, — and that our body constantly needs to be regenerated by the action of other bodies. And from this composite character of the human body it is inferred (Proposition 15), by virtue of the proportionality between soul and body, that the idea that constitutes the essence of the human consciousness is composed of very many ideas.

γ. SPINOZA applies his theory of the relation between soul and body in the special parts of the *Ethica* in such a way that he now infers from the knowledge we have (or that he thinks we have) of the body what goes on in the soul, now from what is known to go on in the soul infers what goes on in the body. Both are justified, since according to SPINOZA the relation between soul and body is a purely logical or mathematical relation of functions, without either of the members being declared once and for all to be the independent [44]

⁴²Den nyere Filosofis Historie², I, p. 268. — GASSENDI too corrected DESCARTES in this way (ib. p. 254).

variable. All attributes are simultaneous expressions of the essence of substance (*simul natura*. I, 17 Schol., III, 2 Schol.). It has wrongly been found inconsistent that SPINOZA goes now the one way, now the other. He goes from the corporeal to the spiritual in Propositions 16–19; the opposite way he goes e.g. in III, 12 Dem. and especially V, 1⁴³.

Concerning the relation between the two series of things SPINOZA uses either the expression “indicate” or “point to” (*indicare*) (II, 16 Cor. 2; III, 14 Dem.) or the expression “presuppose” (*involvere*) (II, 16; III, 29 Dem.). The first expression describes the relation as symptomatic; the second, which is more correct, describes it as a purely logical relation of inference, a relation between a ground of knowledge and what is derived from it. Yet SPINOZA also often uses the expression that the soul “perceives” (*percipit*) the body, an expression bound up with the confusion mentioned above of theory of knowledge and psychophysics, since the relation between soul and body is regarded as a relation between subject and object.

It is perhaps not superfluous to explain the difference between the two points of view by an example. The physicist infers from a sensation of colour a certain degree of refraction of white light. That is a relation belonging to the theory of knowledge. The physiologist infers from the same sensation of colour certain processes in the sense organ and the brain. This is a psychophysical relation. In every sensation both points of view assert themselves. And likewise in every thought, every feeling, every act of will. When SPINOZA thought the concept of substance, a principle of the theory of knowledge was to be expressed by it; but at the same time something went on in his brain (if only we knew what it was!). A heroic resolution (what SPINOZA calls *mentis decretum* as a *species fortitudinis*, see III, 2 Schol. and 59 Cor.) concerns different relations in and outside the resolving subject, and on this rests its ethical significance; but from another point of view such a resolution is a physiological phenomenon (according to LOEB a purely chemical phenomenon), which in the end must be derivable “from the laws of motion and rest”. Which point of view one adopts depends of course on the context in the individual case.

If one wanted to say that thought (consciousness) could itself be a material process, SPINOZA would answer as he answered in a letter (Ep. 4): “Even if I grant this, which I by no means do, it cannot be denied that extension, considered as extension, is not

⁴³It is of interest to compare AVENARIUS' teaching of what he calls the two vital series (the physiological and the psychological) with SPINOZA's teaching of the attributes. See *Moderne Filosofen*, p. 101 f. — AVENARIUS declares the physiological vital series in advance to be the independent variable.

thought”⁴⁴. — Apropos of this remark it may be added that the point of view of the theory of knowledge must find application even if one keeps to the physiological side of man's being. The problem then becomes why and how one can regard a certain state of the brain as a sign of something that perhaps has a wholly different physical character from it, perhaps relating to it as an optical process to a chemical one. SPINOZA himself gives [45] hints in that direction in what immediately follows.

d. Propositions 16—36.

The Psychology of Ideas.

α. SPINOZA introduces the doctrine of ideas from the attribute of extension. Our body stands in constant interaction with other bodies, and its state is therefore at every moment determined not only by its own nature, but also by the character of the other bodies that act on it. The soul's perception (*perceptio*) of its own body therefore also contains a perception of other bodies, but conditioned by the way in which one's own body has been affected by them. It regards them, so to speak, from the standpoint of one's own body. Its knowledge of other bodies therefore cannot become adequate (*adæqvata*) (25), but stands as a consequence without premises, — and the same holds of the soul's knowledge of its own body, since this is always determined by its relation to other bodies (28). — What SPINOZA puts forward here is what is now called the subjectivity of the sense qualities. He puts it forward in a less dogmatic way than one would expect from his doctrine of the attributes.

β. We often perceive several other bodies at once, and when later we perceive one of them again, we come to remember the others. For here the traces (*vestigia*) left by the first perception are at work⁴⁵ (18). — It is the so-called association by contiguity that SPINOZA speaks of here. Elsewhere (Tract. Theol. polit. cap. 4) he gives association by similarity as an independent form of association, and in his explanation of pity (III, 27)

⁴⁴In the treatise on the improvement of the understanding SPINOZA gives among examples of unclear and false ideas the assumption that there are bodies from whose mere composition thought arises (*dari corpora, ex quorum sola compositione fiat intellectus*).

⁴⁵These traces are material (III, Postulate 5). Sometimes the material processes that correspond to memories and fancies are called images (*imagines*), since things stand as present. SPINOZA apologizes for this expression, because those material processes do not reproduce the look of things (II, 17 Schol.). In III, Postulate 2 a distinction is made between traces and images, and the latter are regarded as a consequence of the former (though as material!). Cf. also V, 11—14. — But in II, 49 Schol. “image” is used psychologically.

he in any case presupposes immediate recognition as a condition. When he says in IV, 18 Schol. that a word can call up the idea of an object although there is no similarity between them, this really implies the presupposition that the association of ideas goes more easily when there is similarity between the members.

The association of ideas takes place spontaneously, and from the first we have no reason to doubt the validity of the ideas that turn up in us. What we imagine we regard provisionally as valid, until other ideas come that exclude its validity. In themselves our ideas contain no error; we lack only an idea that could exclude the validity of the ideas before us (17). Just as SPINOZA has called the sensations consequences without premises, so on his view he could also have used this designation of ideas that arise spontaneously.

This interesting way of looking at things was later carried further by English psychology, which connected it partly with a spontaneous tendency to continue a series of ideas until definite obstacles come (HUME), partly with the spontaneous urge to movement that makes us act without criticism on ideas that turn up spontaneously, until this acting brings disappointments or sufferings (BAIN). [46]

γ. SPINOZA then distinguishes very sharply between mere memory or association of ideas and the connection of our ideas that takes place according to the rules of the understanding (*secundum ordinem intellectus*), and that leads to an understanding of things from their first causes, independently of the changes of state that differ for each individual (18 Schol.). True knowledge must comprise the laws that hold for all bodies and for all souls. Human consciousness has only an imperfect knowledge of itself, of its body and of external things, so long as man is determined to his ideas of things from outside, namely by chance encounter. It is otherwise when the ideas are determined by an examination of the agreements, differences or oppositions of things (29 Schol.).

In substance (God) there is a perfect knowledge (*idea seu cognitio*), because it acts at once under all attributes and in all modes, not merely under a single attribute or in a single mode (19–32). Untruth is due to limitation and incompleteness and the confusion that follows from them. An unclear sensation or idea (*idea confusa*) is, as we have seen, a consequence without premises (28 Dem.); if the premises can be supplied, the unclarity ceases. But these imperfect and obscure ideas arise with the same necessity as the perfect, clear and true ideas — and for God, to whom this necessity stands clear, no obscure thoughts therefore exist. The obscurity is present only in so far as the ideas are referred

to a single and limited consciousness (36).

A difficulty has been found in SPINOZA's ascribing to human consciousness an idea of itself, so that it can be an object for itself, just as the body is an object for it (21). SPINOZA has himself given the necessary explanation, saying that this idea of our consciousness (*idea mentis*) — which, since consciousness is itself an idea, is an idea of an idea (*idea ideæ*) — is nothing but the form of consciousness or of the idea, regarded as a mode of thought, apart from the relation to the body (21 Schol.). This corresponds to what is said in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, that the method of thinking is a reflexive knowing (*cognitio reflexiva*), by which we become aware of the form and procedure of our thoughts. Only he who has true thoughts can know what truth is. — When SPINOZA says that this idea of ourselves relates to our consciousness (our soul) in the same way (*eodem modo*) as this relates to the body, “the same way” naturally means only analogy, not identity. There is nothing to prevent there being, within one and the same attribute, relations analogous to the relation between two attributes. — On the psychophysical meaning of the attributes, the task in the case of this self-consciousness, [47] exactly as in the case of all other phenomena of consciousness, will be to find what brain process goes on when it appears.

Propositions 37–47.

Theory of Knowledge.

α. It is the natural science of the time that gives SPINOZA his understanding of what science is at all. He starts from all bodies agreeing in certain properties, above all in being subject to the laws of motion and rest and in the end all falling under a single attribute, the attribute of extension. It is the general mathematical and mechanical laws he has in mind. Their content is something that appears in equal degree in existence as a whole and in its individual parts (37). — The concept of the whole is in SPINOZA derived in relation to the concept of conformity to law. As we have seen (above p. 29 and 43), he conceives the universe as an individual whole, and this conception is grounded in there being in the universe a constant relation between rest and motion despite all changes in the particular⁴⁶.

⁴⁶The expression “that which is equally in the part and in the whole” (*id, quod æque in parte et in toto*

The knowledge that concerns the general laws of existence is thus not conditioned by any particular thing in its difference from other particular things. Or, as SPINOZA puts it in his metaphysical-theological language, God's being appears in the same way whether he is regarded as constituting the essence of man or as constituting the essence of another thing. For what is in question here is what man's body has in common with all other bodies, and therefore man can here have an adequate knowledge (37–39). We stand here before what SPINOZA in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding called "the fixed and eternal things and the laws contained in them", which correspond to what the *Ethica* calls infinite modes (of the second degree); and the last foundation here is the attribute of extension.

At this point theory of knowledge and psychology coincide. If the life of the soul had no other content than that of scientific knowledge of law, there would therefore be no opposition between the interpretation of the doctrine of attributes in terms of the theory of knowledge and its psychophysical interpretation. But SPINOZA himself recognizes that there is other content of the soul than scientific knowledge of law. Partly he maintains, as we shall see, that the knowledge of law is not the highest form of science, because it does not take in the individual phenomena in their peculiarity. Partly he maintains [48] the reality of error, that is, the fact that there are ideas that conflict with what scientific knowledge establishes. Partly, finally, he assumes feelings and desires that have a certain independence in relation to mere thought. And to all these irrational elements (since they all belong after all to the attribute of "thought") elements within the attribute of extension must correspond. Here the psychophysical interpretation shows itself in its opposition to the interpretation in terms of the theory of knowledge. — But we return to the theory of knowledge.

It is the general laws (*notiones communes*) that form the foundation of all thinking

est) has its history. SPINOZA may have it from BRUNO, who teaches that "the world-soul" (which is the principle of nature's conformity to law and is also called *forma universalis*) is "tutta in tutto et qualsivogla parte del tutto" (*Op. ital.* ed. Lagarde p. 203, 242). (Likewise *De Immenso* IV, 15). But he may also have it from the scholastics. It goes back to AUGUSTINE and ATHANASIUS, who surely have it from PLOTINUS. See on this my *Religionsfilosofi*, Note 15. A hint is found already in PLATO (*Parmenides* p. 131 B). — HUME (*Treatise* I, 4, 5) speaks of the expression as scholastic and finds it "shocking when crudely propos'd". He is probably thinking of the mythological and dogmatic use of the concept. But its history is interesting, because it shows that the thought of the conformity to law of existence presses forward as soon as men begin to think. This thought runs through different forms. In SPINOZA it receives a decidedly rational form, although it is put forward dogmatically.

about nature. *Fundamenta ratiocinii nostri* they are called (40 Schol. 1). They disregard all differences of time and can therefore be said to show us things under the aspect of eternity (*sub quadam æternitatis specie*, 44 Cor. 2). By eternity SPINOZA, after all, means not continual persistence, but an existence that follows with necessity from the essence of things (I, Def. 8). And this necessity of things is (according to I, 16) one with the necessity of God's eternal nature (44 Cor. 2).

The expression *notiones communes* comes from the Stoics, and it originally denotes concepts that are common to all men⁴⁷. SPINOZA too assumes that there are certain concepts that are common to all men and that are (in part) perceived by all "adequately, that is, clearly and distinctly"; but this (possible) community is grounded in him by inference from these concepts concerning only what holds "equally of the whole and of every part" (38 with Cor.).

On the way by which one reaches the knowledge of the general laws on which we must rely in our understanding of existence SPINOZA will not speak more closely, but refers to the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, which unfortunately, as we know, he did not finish. He has, however, at an earlier place in the *Ethica* (29 Schol.) given a small hint, in that he sets over against the "external" perception, which is due only to the encounter of chance circumstances, the knowledge that can be called "inner", because it rests on comparison and thereby leads to an understanding of agreements, differences and oppositions; by such a procedure one arrives at a clear and distinct perception of things. (Cf. above p. 46). It is, after all, also on the possibility of ordering our thoughts in series by definite laws that he grounds the concept of attribute. (See above p. 8 and p. 39). Of interest in this connection is also his exchange with the famous chemist BOYLE (with OLDENBURG as intermediary). Against BOYLE he maintains that no experiment can establish the justification of the mechanical view of nature, which leads all sensible properties back to motion and rest and their laws (Ep. 6). It seems to be SPINOZA's meaning that every experiment can only supply an example of these laws, but that these stand as the constant presupposition, which according to SPINOZA is an eternal and necessary truth. Despite the dogmatic line of thought, his position here nevertheless offers an analogy to KANT's. He stood towards the natural science of his time in a way similar to that in which KANT stood towards NEWTON's *Principia*,

⁴⁷Cf. PAUL BARTH: *Die Stoa*. (Frommanns Klassiker der Philosophie). 1903. p. 72 f.

regarding it as a spiritual fact whose foundation was to be found by way of analysis. [49] The analogy lies all the nearer as there is, on this point, still a dogmatic element in the founder of criticism himself⁴⁸.

From the concepts of general, pervasive laws (*notiones communes*) SPINOZA distinguishes such concepts or words as have general meaning only because the ability to comprehend different things in a distinct way has been lacking. To this belong such words as “thing”, “being”, “something”, and besides all concepts of kinds (*notiones universales*) such as “man”, “horse”, “dog” and so on (40 Schol. 2)⁴⁹. This distinction recalls how BRUNO and BACON interpreted PLATO's “ideas” as laws, not as mere general concepts, which is what they originally were.

Among the mere general concepts SPINOZA also counts the concept of number. “We do not perceive things”, he says (Ep. 50), “under the concept of number except after having led them back to a common kind.” I can say that I have two coins when I have a daler and a skilling. And since concepts of kinds, as we have seen, are according to SPINOZA signs of an imperfect power of thought, he cannot give the concept of number any eminent place in thought. It cannot be applied to substance. “Measure (*mensura*), time and number are only modes of thinking or rather of imagining (*imaginandi modi*)” (Ep. 12). It is only arithmetic, not geometry, that SPINOZA has misgivings about. The difference he makes here springs, no doubt, from continuity appearing more clearly in the geometrical than in the arithmetical domain; number is the expression of discontinuity. But from DESCARTES' analytic geometry (which was in his library) he could have learned that geometrical forms can be expressed by arithmetical formulas (the circle, for example, which according to SPINOZA “exists in nature”, by the equation $r^2 = y^2 + x^2$), so that number and extension can go together, the formulas changing as the lines and their relations change, and conversely. Perhaps, however, DESCARTES' analytic geometry influenced SPINOZA's thought in another way, in that the relation between the different

⁴⁸Cf. *Totalitet som Kategori*, p. 36 f.

⁴⁹It is of interest to compare SPINOZA's criticism of general concepts with LEIBNIZ'. For SPINOZA the main point was that general concepts do not state real laws for the relation between the different marks or properties. When LEIBNIZ doubts the validity of general concepts, it is because he is convinced that “nature has differences and likenesses that we do not know”. Therefore our determinations of the natural kinds must always be provisional and conditioned by our knowledge at a given time. Besides, the transition from kind to kind can be continuous, for which reason concepts of kinds can only be set up purely by convention. (*Nouveaux Essais*. III, 6, 14. 23. 28).

attributes is of just the same kind as, according to DESCARTES, the relation between equation and curve⁵⁰. But the qualitative discontinuity, which in general brings such great difficulties for SPINOZA's system, he could not acknowledge as belonging to thought, and therefore he refers it to mere "imagination".

It was first LEIBNIZ who saw that the origin of number is due to the ability to continue a series by the same law by which it began, and that this continuation was always in our power. It is the positive significance of repetition that appears here and marks the boundary between logic and mathematics. A new phase in the history of the problem of knowledge begins with KANT's taking up this point of view as decisive, if rational empirical science is to be seen in its grounding and justification⁵¹. [50]

Another, and more justified, use of his critical attitude towards concepts of kinds SPINOZA makes in his criticism of the assumption of a "free will" in the sense of the word in which everyone is supposed to have the same power of self-control. This assumption is due, he thinks, to an abstract concept of men and overlooks the great difference between men's abilities and between the ways by which individuals must work their way forward to perfection. (Ep. 19 and 23).

β. It is not SPINOZA's meaning that only material nature is subject to general laws. In the teaching on the mutual relation of the attributes there lies hidden the presupposition that the spiritual cannot be derived from the material and must therefore be regarded as a peculiar side, a special attribute of substance. What is common to the different attributes is, after all, precisely the relation between ground and consequence, the relation that appears in different forms within the different attributes. All individual things (no matter under which attribute they are referred) are subject to a world order that determines their existence at a given time and place, and that has in the end its ground in the necessity of the divine nature. (II, 45 Schol. and V, 29 Schol.). As for the laws that hold under the attribute of thought, one could in SPINOZA — owing to the confusion of the points of view of the theory of knowledge and of psychology shown above — just as well expect a reference to logical-mathematical as to empirical-psychological connections. Whereas, where there is talk of the possibility of always continued series formation under the attribute of thought (Eth. II, 1), one would most readily think of logical-mathematical

⁵⁰See the interesting discussion in L. BRUNSCHWIG: *Les Étapes de la philosophie mathématique*. p. 144 f.

⁵¹Cf. *Totalitet som Kategori*, p. 34–37.

series of concepts (see above p. 9 Note), SPINOZA himself, where (Tr. theol. polit. cap. 4) he has to name examples of conformity to law in nature, points to the law of the association of ideas as the correlate of the laws of motion in the material domain. And in the third and fourth books, and the beginning of the fifth, he shows how, through the association of ideas, displacements can take place in the domain of the life of feeling and will, and he infers from these phenomena to correlated material processes (V, 1). And on the other hand he finds in the spiritual domain a counterpart to the principle of inertia holding in the material domain (III, 6) in the urge of self-preservation, which plays so great a part in his ethics. It was in general his conviction that “whether one regards nature under the one or the other attribute, it is one and the same order or connection of things one has before one” (III, 2 with reference to II, 7 Schol.). And on this foundation he builds, in the last three books of the *Ethica*, his teaching on the highest development of human life.

γ. As for the actual development of knowledge, SPINOZA distinguishes three stages (II, 40 Schol. 2). On the first stage knowledge is conditioned by individual, scattered observations, which stand as conclusions without premises. (Cf. above p. 45). In the [51] treatise on the improvement of the understanding a closer characterization of them is given. Their scattered and chance appearance (*sensationes fortuitæ et solutæ*) is stressed and connected with their not springing from the energy of consciousness itself, but being due to external causes. Scatteredness and passivity are thus closely bound up together. It does not matter, SPINOZA adds, how one thinks of the sensuous ideas and their origin⁵²; the decisive thing is their vague and passive character. With these scattered and passive observations SPINOZA puts the ideas that are due to report and tradition, and that are formed on the likeness of what we ourselves have seen and heard. This first stage of knowledge SPINOZA calls vague experience (*experientia vaga*), opinion (*opinio*) or imagination (*imaginatio*). The second stage is the scientific standpoint just described, which leads to the knowledge of general laws and relies on the critical comparison of observations and reports (29 Schol.). Besides natural science and psychology, SPINOZA could count historical criticism here, as he himself applied it to the books of the Bible in his theologico-political treatise. This second stage SPINOZA calls reason (*ratio*). Already here

⁵²HUME too (*Treatise* I, 3, 5) leaves it open [for the theory of knowledge] how the sensations arise. Had KANT taken a similarly cautious position, the concept of the Ding an sich would hardly have been formed.

we know things “under the aspect of eternity”, because we rely on what is independent of times, places and individual differences (44 Cor. 2). The third stage is designated intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*).

Intuitive knowledge stands in opposition both to the knowledge that builds on observation or tradition and therefore concerns only individual things (*singularia*), and to rational knowledge, which demonstrates general laws. It unites the peculiarity of both in itself, in that it is a knowledge of the essence of an individual thing through the understanding of the lawful connection within which the thing stands as a peculiar member. The example by which SPINOZA illustrates this description of intuitive knowledge is taken from simple arithmetical proportions. We see immediately that 6 is the number that is to 3 as 2 is to 1. Underlying this, to be sure, is a knowledge of the nature of numbers and of proportional relations; but this knowledge is not applied with full awareness. In this example (II, 40 Schol. 2) SPINOZA plainly regards the number 6 as an individual, a *res singularis*, which by virtue of the law of proportionality fits in a definite way into a whole connection.

This third and highest kind of knowledge can be reached only by one who has gone through the first two degrees. Insight into the conformity to law of existence is a condition of its arising. In this the *Ethica*'s concept of intuition differs from the more mystical concept of intuition in the Short Treatise. In the fifth book of the *Ethica* intuition is said to consist in gaining, from the very essence of an individual thing (*ex ipsa essentia rei cujuscunqve singularis*), insight into its dependence on the substance of existence, as regards both essence and existence, and it is added that in the first book it had only been shown how things in general were dependent on substance (V, 36 Schol.). The line of [52] thought in the first book thus belongs to the second kind of knowledge (*ratio*), which does show us things under the aspect of eternity, but in an abstract way (I, 25). The individual being that SPINOZA in the fifth book wants to show in its connection with substance is the human mind, which through the knowledge of the laws of existence stands as a member of the whole connection that has its last ground in substance through the infinite understanding and the attribute of thought.

It is perhaps characteristic that some of the examples of intuitive knowledge that SPINOZA gives in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding are lacking in the *Ethica*. Thus the example that when I know something, I know from it what it is to

know. This is an analysis, or, if one will, an immediate inference. In the treatise named, method is defined as knowledge of (consciousness of) knowledge (*cognitio reflexiva*), an idea of an idea (*idea ideæ*). (See also *Ethica* II, 20–21; cf. above p. 46). In the *Ethica* too it is expressly maintained that whoever has a true idea must also know that he has a true idea and cannot doubt its truth, since an idea is not something dumb, like a picture (*pictura*) one can stare at, but is an activity, is the very act of understanding. Every true idea contains the norm of truth in itself (II, 43). When SPINOZA in the *Ethica* does not name this as an example of intuition, it is thus not because he does not acknowledge its correctness. It is rather because he thinks that it is not the kind of intuition he calls the third and highest degree of knowledge. When the immediate knowledge of what goes on in an act of knowing is called intuition in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, it is what I have called analytic intuition, the consciousness that expresses itself in every immediate inference, every simple transition from member to member in a demonstration⁵³. In the *Ethica*, on the other hand, SPINOZA lays weight on an individual thing (*res singularis*) being known by intuitive knowledge in its connection with existence as a whole. Here it is not a matter of simple analysis, immediate transition of thought, but of an apprehension of the whole, a construction, which forms the close of a long work of thought and builds on the knowledge of law won through this work of thought. This is what I have called synthetic intuition⁵⁴. I suppose, as indicated above, that SPINOZA in his example from numbers regards a number (here the number six) as an individual, which by an intuition won on the basis of the law of the formation of the series of numbers gets its place fixed in relation to other numbers. Only so does the example fit what it is plainly his intention to express. In the fifth book it is the thinking man himself, let us say SPINOZA himself, whose personality is seen as a member of the connection of the world, as an eternal element of mind (*æternus cogitandi modus*) (V, 40 Schol.).

Analytic intuition must already be at work in the transition from the first stage of knowledge to the second. It is applied in the careful comparison that does not stop at scattered observation, but through examination of the likenesses and differences of things finds the foundation of our thinking, which consists in concepts of general relations (II, [53]

⁵³ *Om Begrebet Intuition* (Vid. Selsk. Oversigt 1914), p. 77–80).

⁵⁴ *Om Begrebet Intuition*, p. 80–82.

28–29; 44 Cor.). Analytic intuition is thus a means, a preparation. Synthetic intuition, on the other hand, which SPINOZA sets up in the *Ethica*, is an apprehension of the whole that stands as the last aim and great ideal of knowledge⁵⁵. What SPINOZA says of intuitive knowledge in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding must be understood of it: “What I have so far been able to understand by this kind of knowledge is very little (*perpauca*).” It is clear, after all, that a wholly transparent, rational connection between the individual and the universal sets an infinite task for thought. LEIBNIZ, who had so clear an eye for the individual and nuanced and for the countless transitions, saw this clearly. It is impossible to know the full individuality of a thing, since every individual being stands in an infinity of interactions with everything else in the world, and since there is an infinity of small differences not known to us (*Nouveaux Essais*, III, 3, 6). It is nevertheless of great interest that precisely SPINOZA set up synthetic intuition as an ideal, he who has so often been regarded as the man of abstractions.

The mathematical example SPINOZA uses to illustrate “synthetic intuition” shows that he very well acknowledges the possibility of such intuition in special domains, especially in the mathematical domain. He would thus not disagree with ZEUTHEN, who maintains that synthetic intuition (a knowledge of the whole) is possible in mathematics, though he adds that this comes from mathematical knowledge being itself symbolic. “For it in reality comprises only a limited number of particulars, which can be gathered into a whole, which one can then, by the use of suitable symbols, let appear as a particular, either in a further mathematical investigation or in one of the applications of mathematics”⁵⁶. As I have suggested in my paper on intuition, a knowledge of the whole can also be reached in special domains of experience, e.g. the psychological and the historical. But there it receives a decidedly hypothetical character.

There is a difference between the way in which intuitive knowledge is spoken of here in the second book and later in the fifth book. The fact is that in the fifth book the life of feeling and will works together with the life of thought. The joy of knowledge, which

⁵⁵JOACHIM (*A Study of the Ethics of Spinoza*, 1901, p. 183) is right only in this, that intuition is already presupposed at the second stage of knowledge, if one has analytic intuition in mind. HUAN (*Le dieu de Spinoza*, p. 16–19) has seen this clearly. — What I call analytic intuition is already described by DESCARTES (*Regulæ*, Ch. 8), and after him by LOCKE (*Essay* IV, 2, 1 and 10, 3) and HUME (*Treatise* I, 3, 1–3). DESCARTES uses examples similar to SPINOZA's in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, and SPINOZA may well have known the *Regulæ*, which are known to have circulated in copies in SPINOZA's circle (see on this BRUNSCHWIG: *Les Étapes de la philosophie mathématique*, p. 141).

⁵⁶ZEUTHEN: *Om Anvendelse af Regning og Ræsonnement* (Vid. Selsk. Overs. 1914, p. 275).

in the end gave life its value for SPINOZA, reaches its summit when it appears that it is the innermost ground of existence that makes knowledge possible, just as knowledge itself on its side reaches its completion in the thought of this innermost ground and its appearance in attributes and in modes. Thereby SPINOZA's synthetic intuition gets a religious stamp and falls under what I have called practical intuition. It also gets an artistic stamp, since it presupposes the ability to see the individual in its whole concrete [54] peculiarity and yet as though shot through with the great laws of existence.

What in the paper named I have called concrete intuition, under which fall the images of intuition that form spontaneously in sensation, memory and imagination, corresponds to SPINOZA's first stage of knowledge (*imaginatio*). It is on the basis of it that analytic intuition can lead to the knowledge of law⁵⁷ and thereby possibly pave the way to synthetic intuition. For SPINOZA the general laws were not the last and highest task of science. The last aim was the understanding of the particular and individual by means of the knowledge of law⁵⁸. —

With epigrammatic brevity SPINOZA has stated the main stages of human knowledge, beginning with the gathering of things, rising to science and closing with the intuitive knowledge that stands on the border of science, religion and art, and that also — which, however, SPINOZA would hardly admit — must in each individual case bear a different stamp according to the thinker's individual personality and experience of life. Nor would he have admitted that a rounded picture of the whole, such as is to mark the summit of knowledge, must scientifically be regarded as hypothetical.

f. Propositions 48—49.

The Concept of Will.

α. SPINOZA closes his psychology of knowledge and his theory of knowledge by enjoining once more that one must not confuse thought, image and word. A real thought,

⁵⁷An interesting example of a transitional form between concrete and analytic intuition is offered by the Indian mathematician APASTAMBA's presupposition that two triangles that are equal to one and the same third are equal. It is intuition (the perception of surfaces) that rules; but it marks a beginning of analysis that that presupposition is separated out from the whole visual experience. ZEUTHEN: *Hvorledes Matematikken i Tiden fra Platon til Euklid blev rationel Videnskab* (Vid. Selsk. Skr. 1917), p. 55 f. — In the relation between the perception of surfaces and the perception of contours demonstrated by EDGAR RUBIN (*Synsoplevede Figurer*. 1915) there is another fine example of the transition of concrete intuition to analysis.

⁵⁸See on this point *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 222—227. — *Totalitet som Kategori*, p. 63—66.

consistently developed, is not something resting and passive, but the fruit of the mind's activity and itself constantly at work, unfolding its consequences further. When it is thought that one can believe or see something and yet not will it, one understands by belief or insight a passive relation to an image or word ("a dumb picture on a tablet"), not a spiritual activity. The activity by which a thought unfolds itself in its consequences is one with a willing, and conversely: willing (*volitio*) is consequence of thought. It is impossible to have the idea of a triangle and not affirm (*affirmare*) that the sum of its angles is equal to two right angles. — It is also enjoined that one can have full certainty only of what is fully and clearly seen and proved. Certainty is not the same as an absence of doubt, which may be due to the chance circumstance that no occasion for unrest in the mind has arisen.

By the word will (*voluntas*) SPINOZA understands in this connection only the ability to affirm or deny. Affirmation is quite simply a consequence of an idea one has. SPINOZA [55] declares expressly that by will he does not understand desire (*cupiditas*), which expresses itself in an urge towards something or aversion to something.

What SPINOZA has at heart in this whole line of thought is to enjoin the active character of the life of thought, its springing from man's innermost being, which in turn is an individual mode of the substance at work in everything. It is in the concept of self-activity that understanding and will are one for him. His standpoint here recalls that of SOCRATES. SOCRATES too maintained, after all, that whoever knows cannot do otherwise than act on his knowledge; if he does not, that is for SOCRATES a proof that in reality he had no knowledge.

When DESCARTES taught that the will can extend further than the understanding, SPINOZA grants this only in so far as by understanding one means the ability to think clearly and distinctly. He grants, of course, that there are obscure thoughts; but they rest only on incompleteness. And he grants that there is error; but it is something negative, resting on the absence of cases that conflict with what one has provisionally settled down with.

When SPINOZA declares willing and thinking one, he has in mind such characters as those in whom deliberation is able to give a clear idea of the different possibilities, so that the decision becomes a simple consequence of the relation between these possibilities, — and in whom, next, the thought on which the mind has concentrated in the decision

is held fast in its consequence until it is realized. But even such characters have gone through a development that led through obscurities and errors, and if what is meant by the word will is not something that first comes into being at the stage of completion, there must be other forms of will than the one that is one with clear thinking, forms that may very well be called active, since they can have their real cause in man's own being. Such forms of will are what is denoted by words such as urge, striving, longing, desire, appetite. They can often stand in opposition to the willing grounded on clear reflection — as when GOETHE says of his friend:

Noch ist, bei tiefer Neigung für das Wahre,
ihm Irrthum eine Leidenschaft.

In the admission that the will can under certain circumstances and in a certain sense extend further than the understanding, there lies the hint of a fuller concept of will than the one SPINOZA maintains in this place. The one-sidedness of it is that obscurity and error are conceived only as something negative, although they are real, positive states. Absence of doubt means spontaneous belief, trust or assent, and does not exclude clarity and full consistency within the circle of ideas at one's disposal. That SPINOZA did not see the positive character of such states is bound up with his not distinguishing between two kinds of positive judgement, — primary ones, which come about by immediate reflection (analysis) on given things, and secondary ones, which reject a denial or a doubt concerning such things. He misjudges above all the significance and independence of immediate intuition, especially of imagination, when he claims (49 Schol.) that to imagine a winged horse is nothing but to predicate wingedness of the horse⁵⁹. [56]

Finally, the identity of understanding and will can in itself just as well mean the reduction of understanding to will as conversely. What SPINOZA cares about is the assertion of spiritual activity. To this side of the matter I shall come back later (at III, 9).

β. Whereas SPINOZA here has made willing one with thinking, in the third book (9 with Schol.) he conceives willing as the expression of a striving for self-preservation (*conatus perseverandi in suo esse*), which, when it is felt, is called urge (*appetitus*), and when it is joined with the idea of its aim is called desire (*cupiditas*). And in the definitions

⁵⁹See on the matters touched on here *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 53–57; 78 f. — *Totalitet som Kategori*, p. 8.

that form the appendix to the third book, desire (*cupiditas*) is said to be the very essence of man in so far as it is determined from an inner state to undertake a certain action. Finally the word desire is given so wide a meaning that it can denote all human striving (*conatus*), impulse (*impetus*), urge (*appetitus*) and willing (*volitio*).

It is plainly two different concepts of will that are set up at the end of the second book and at the beginning of the third, that is, in close proximity to each other.

Attempts have been made in various ways to explain this difference. SIGWART supposes (in his translation of the Short Treatise p. 208) that the urge of self-preservation shows itself in the very affirmations and denials spoken of in II, 49. He thus takes the presentation in the third book as the more fundamental. But he admits that SPINOZA himself does not say this in so many words, however near it must have lain to him. BAENSCH goes (in his translation of the *Ethica* p. XVI) the opposite way, finding in the third book precisely the summit of the intellectualism that already asserts itself in the second book: feeling and urge, which according to II, Ax. 3 were merely to be dependent on ideas, are made one with them in the third book, and the urge of self-preservation is then to be nothing but the self-affirmation of the idea (*idea*) that constitutes man's essence. But BAENSCH must admit that at its summit the intellectualism then turns over into its opposite, since it is maintained (III, 9 Schol.) that we do not strive after something, do not will it, because it is good, but conversely regard it as good because we will it. Here urge and willing are expressly set as more fundamental than knowledge. TÖNNIES (*Studien zur Entwicklungsgeschichte des SPINOZA. Vierteljahrsschrift für wissenschaftliche Philosophie* VI) has sought to solve the difficulty by the assumption that there was an interval of time between the second and third books in their present form, and that the third book was only completed after HOBBS' psychology had influenced SPINOZA. What speaks for this explanation is that HOBBS conceives the will precisely as urge or desire. In the *Elements of Law* (1640) the last desire that expresses itself in deliberation is called (I, 12, 2) the will. Urge, fear and hope cannot be willed (voluntary) because they [57] are the will. The same determinations of concepts are found in *De Homine* (1658) Ch. 11 and in *Leviathan* (1651). Their historical presuppositions we shall come to speak of at the third book. — There is much that speaks for TÖNNIES' hypothesis. But it is and remains striking that SPINOZA in the final working together of his drafts did not notice the discrepancy. The explanation could lie in his having spontaneously identified the

urge and desire that cannot be made one with pure thinking with the willing that is led by obscure or false ideas. In his concession to DESCARTES he has, after all, as already remarked, hinted at a widening of the concept of will he sets up in II, 49. But to this comes, as the discussion of the last three books will show, that a refraction between an intellectualist and a voluntarist conception runs through his whole psychological and ethical view.

γ. In a concluding remark SPINOZA first rejects the assumption of the indifference of the will ("free will"), partly by maintaining that an idea is not a resting image but an activity of thought that cannot be reconciled with indifference, partly by directly rejecting the possibility of absolute states of equilibrium. A man who is equally hungry and equally thirsty and therefore cannot decide either to eat or to drink, SPINOZA would — alluding to BURIDAN's famous ass⁶⁰ — rather call an ass than a man.

Finally SPINOZA shows how the conviction of the necessity of all things teaches us to strive to reach the highest possible understanding of existence, leads us to calm and resignation towards the swings of fate, enjoins compassion and gives guidance for the right government of the state.

[58]

Third Book.

a. Preface, Definitions, Axioms and Postulates.

In the preface the conviction is expressed in forceful words that definite laws reign in the spiritual domain, just as in the material domain. Nature is always the same, its power and efficacy everywhere alike; it is the same laws by which everything happens and all transformations from one form to another take place. Therefore it is senseless to blame nature, and it is also senseless to derive human weakness and inconstancy from sinfulness,

⁶⁰As for this animal, SCHOPENHAUER already searched in vain for it in the writings we have of BURIDAN (a scholastic of the first part of the fourteenth century). Later SIEBECK (*Beiträge zur Entwicklungsgeschichte der neueren Psychologie*. Giessen 1891) hunted for it without success. SIEBECK supposes that BURIDAN used the example in oral teaching to show the difference between man and animal: man will be able to find a difference where the animal finds none. — SPINOZA's line of thought regarding the ass goes precisely in this direction. — As SCHOPENHAUER shows (*Die beiden Grundprobleme der Ethik*², p. 58 f) the example is older than BURIDAN. It occurs already in DANTE and is hinted at in ARISTOTLE. What is new in BURIDAN is that it is an ass that is caught between two equal possibilities.

or to laugh or weep or be indignant over human nature as it is. What matters is to come to know the nature of human feelings and, on the basis of this knowledge, to show what the mind itself can do to harmonize (*moderari*) them, even if it does not, as DESCARTES thought, have absolute mastery over them. But apart from this, the understanding of human feelings is as valuable as the understanding of the phenomena of material nature, and therefore SPINOZA will here apply the same method as elsewhere and regard human actions and impulses as if it were a question of lines, surfaces or bodies.

The second definition speaks of the important determination, already mentioned, of the concepts of activity and passivity, which, as will appear, is of decisive significance for understanding the development of the feelings. It finds application at once in the very definition of what feeling is. Taking his starting point here from the bodily side, SPINOZA defines feeling as a bodily state by which the body's power of action (*agendi potentia*) is increased or diminished, and to which a certain idea (*idea*) corresponds.

With the systematic-deductive presentation of the psychology of the feelings that now begins, one must constantly compare the more purely descriptive presentation given in the appendix to the third book, which is often very illuminating, although it does not always agree with the presentation in the book itself. The descriptive appendix ends, e.g., with a "general definition of the feelings", by which these are conceived as passive states and made one with "confused ideas" (*confusæ ideæ*). Here, then, no account is taken of feelings, by Def. 3, being able to be both active and passive, according as they have their origin in man's own nature or are due to external causes. And no account is taken of its being expressly shown in Propositions 58–59 how a feeling can get an active character.

Both in Def. 3 and in the appendix feeling is made one with idea (*idea*). Here, as with [59] the concept of will at the end of the second book, an intellectualist conception lies at the foundation. It is only in the part of the book that begins with Proposition 4 that a more realistic and voluntarist line of thought asserts itself.

The concept of idea (*idea*) has on the whole a fateful influence in SPINOZA. By the soul's being defined from the first as the idea corresponding to the body (*idea corporis*), the confusion of theory of knowledge and psychology shown in the foregoing is made possible. And on account of the active character of ideas, which SPINOZA rightly stresses, an absolute identity between knowledge and will is maintained (II, 48–49), although there is only partial identity between them, since there is spiritual self-activity other than

that which appears as knowledge. As for the psychology of the feelings in particular, it is overlooked that there is a difference between feeling conditioned by sensation and feeling conditioned by ideas (elementary and ideal feelings), — and that the very feelings that are most of all conditioned by ideas are just as little absolutely identical with them as the expressions of the will are.

b. Propositions 1—3.

Spiritual Activity and Passivity.

We are passive when we have only inadequate ideas (*ideæ inadæqvataæ*), that is, such as cannot be understood from our own nature alone but presuppose action from outside. But so as not to be misunderstood, SPINOZA enjoins very energetically and clearly the view of the relation between soul and body that in his opinion follows from the relation between the different attributes maintained in the first two books: III, 2 Schol. is grounded without more ado on II, 7. A state or activity of the soul and of the body, e.g. a resolution and the bodily state corresponding to it, are one and the same thing and assert themselves simultaneously (*simul natura*). By virtue of this both a psychological and a physiological explanation must be demanded of the passive or active states men can be in, and of the changes they can undergo.

By maintaining, in consequence of his doctrine of attributes, the simultaneity of the states of the soul and the corresponding bodily states, SPINOZA, without being aware of it, comes indirectly to point to the only possible way in which the problem of the relation between soul and body could be thought to receive a really experimental decision. For if it could be established that a state of the soul, a sensation for example, set in only after the corresponding bodily state had arisen, — or that (in action) a movement was only begun in the brain after a resolution had been taken, the popular doctrine of interaction would be proved. We should then in the one case get a series of material states that at a certain point was broken off and continued by a shorter or longer series of states of the soul, — and in the other case a series of states of the soul that at a certain point was broken off and continued by a series of material states. Now it is not easy to see [60] how one should come to make such an experiment. It is another matter that interesting experiments have established the continuous course of material processes (in as outside

the organism) and their agreement with what is now called the law of the conservation of energy, even where processes of the soul could be ascertained at the same time, and that a proportionality between the organic and the psychical has further been shown. But although SPINOZA could not know on these points what we now know or think we know, it is nevertheless precisely, as the scholium to III, 2 shows, the continuity of material phenomena and the proportionality between the psychical and the organic that he appeals to here. And the general doctrine of attributes to which he appeals in the end has itself, as I have sought to show, arisen as a consequence of the method of the “new science”. He appeals expressly (in III, 2 Schol.) to the method of empirical science. No limit has yet been shown, he says here, to what can be explained within the organism by the laws of bodily nature, and to appeal to an intervention of the soul to explain bodily processes is only to admit one’s ignorance. This reasoning is the same as he applies elsewhere (in the concluding remark to the first book) against the teleological explanation of nature and (in Ep. 75) against the belief in miracles. Spiritualism, theology and belief in miracles rest for him on the same principle. In this connection he regards his doctrine of attributes (the hypothesis of identity) as a working hypothesis, as is more and more the case with modern adherents of this doctrine too. At bottom no other working hypothesis can be applied in treating the relation between soul and body than the hypothesis of attributes, which builds on the possibility of inferring from the one circle of phenomena to the other, although a causal relation (which is also a temporal relation) is not assumed. — Expressions such as parallelism or duplicism, so often used of the Spinozist hypothesis, are due to a misleading analogy⁶¹. If one seeks an analogy that really fits, one can use FECHNER’s image of the relation between the convex and the concave side of one and the same curve, or BRUNSCHWIG’s analogy (which according to him is more than an analogy) with the relation between algebra and geometry in analytic geometry.

c. Propositions 4—12.

The Urge of Self-Preservation.

α. As an introduction to the psychology of the feelings SPINOZA puts forward the teaching that every being has a tendency to preserve and maintain itself. What is to be

⁶¹On the other hand the expressions named (and the polemic they usually give rise to) fit CHR. WOLFF’s teaching. Cf. *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 524 (Note 76).

able to take away the existence of a thing must be something other than the thing itself. The ground of this proposition is sought in every individual being (mode) being a special form (manner) of the being and working of substance and therefore having its share in its own way in the ability of substance to exist through itself and be understood through itself. The tendency to self-preservation is not a subordinate property, but is one with the innermost nature of the individual being. SPINOZA refers here to the proposition set up [61] earlier (I, 36), that there is nothing from whose nature effects do not spring, a proposition grounded precisely in everything that exists expressing God's being in its definite way. It is the positive side of the relation between substance and mode that SPINOZA brings forward here. The very positive (*quid positivum*) by which things are determined to act springs from God (I, 26 Dem.). For the most part SPINOZA stresses the negative side of that relation, on the strength of the presupposition that every limitation, every closer determination, is a negation (*omnis determinatio negatio*, Ep. 50). We know individual beings only from experience, but since they do after all exist, substance must show itself in them, and therefore their power or striving (*potentia sive conatus*) for self-preservation is one with their given, actual nature (7 Dem.).

Nevertheless this concept appears rather unprepared in SPINOZA. He does not, like GALILEO, GASSENDI, HOBBS and later LEIBNIZ, make any use of this concept in natural philosophy. Such a use could have led him beyond the Cartesian theory of motion, whose untenability he admitted (in his last letter to TSCHIRNHAUSEN). In the physical doctrines in the second book he gives a purely mechanical theory of motion in the Cartesian spirit.

It is plainly by a purely psychological way that he was led to give the concept of self-preservation a fundamental significance in the science of mind, and here he has BRUNO⁶² and HOBBS, and through them TELESIO, as forerunners. Through TELESIO, as DILTHEY⁶³ has shown, this whole line of thought leads back to Stoicism.

β. As regards man, the urge of self-preservation expresses itself both in so far as he has clear and distinct ideas and in so far as he has obscure ideas. Therefore a widening is now made of the concept of will set up in II, 48–49. The urge of self-preservation is called will (*voluntas*) in so far as it is referred to the soul alone, urge (*appetitus*) in so far

⁶²Of interest for the relation between SPINOZA and BRUNO is that the Short Treatise (I, 5) regards the individual thing's striving for self-preservation as the expression of a special providence. A quite similar thought is found in BRUNO. (*Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 128).

⁶³*Weltanschauung und Analyse des Menschen seit Renaissance und Reformation*. (1914). p. 433. 463.

as it is referred to both body and soul, and desire (*cupiditas*) in so far as we become aware of the urge [and its object]. What we hold good rests on the urge of self-preservation, that is, on will (in the widest sense of the word). We therefore do not will something because it is good, but we hold something good because we will it (9 Schol. and 39 Schol.). We can will what at bottom we do not will, and turn away from (*nolle*) what at bottom we will, as when, e.g., fear of a greater evil makes us will a lesser evil or give up what would otherwise be a good (39 Schol.).

Without going again into the relation between the concept of will that appears here and the one set up at the end of the second book, I shall only remark that even if, as was stated in II, 49, understanding and will were absolutely one and the same, one could with the same right say that we know the good because we will it, and that we will it [62] because we know it. When $A = B$, it holds after all both that A is B and that B is A . If we look at the development of the life of the will, the first proposition can hold at more primitive stages, the latter at higher stages: we begin by holding good what we will (have a liking and an urge for), and we can end by willing what we have learned to regard as a good. The most fundamental proposition is and remains, however, that our willing is the expression of our urge. This proposition has its validity right up into the highest regions of the life of the mind. We will science and art only because we have an urge for them. Only by this consideration does it become possible to build a bridge between SPINOZA's two concepts of will. But SPINOZA did not undertake such a consideration, since the genetic point of view does not fully come into its own in him.

The significant difference between the two concepts of will is seen from IV, 7–8 and 14, where it is enjoined that the knowledge of good and evil is a power in us only because it is a feeling (*affectus*), not because it is true knowledge. A feeling or urge is thus in play wherever knowledge does an inner work (and is not merely itself a work).

γ. The difference between urge (*appetitus*) and desire (*cupiditas*) consists in our being aware, in desire, of what we strive after, whereas the mere urge is blind (III, 9 Schol.). To this difference, however, SPINOZA attaches no decisive significance. In the appendix to the third book (Ch. 1 Expl.) he says that whether a man is aware of his urge or not, it is the same urge, and he can therefore use the word desire (*cupiditas*) to denote all striving (*conatus*), urge (*appetitus*), impulse (*impetus*) and willing (*volitiones*).

It is a large question whether SPINOZA is right in this. The awareness of the aim

of our urge can become of decisive significance. When the urge is no longer blind, its direction can become more definite; means can be sought that do not offer themselves immediately; attention can be roused to obstacles. If only a single idea, that of the aim of the urge, is given, it can call up other ideas, even very remote ones, and the action can thus be determined by a larger circle of experiences. It is the introduction to what we, in purely psychological terms, call a higher development of the life of the will, that the awareness of aims and means becomes clear. With blindness easily go unruliness and unrest, whereas clarity about aims and means gives the limitation that makes mastery possible. This development from obscurity to clarity does not go on without danger. The immediate urge, the spontaneous craving of the reflex movement and of instinct, can be weakened by reflection and speculation. But precisely this danger shows that the relation between conscious and unconscious urge is not so indifferent as the Spinozist proposition quoted states. And SPINOZA's own brilliant presentation of the significance of knowledge for the life of feeling in the following sections of the third book must also hold for the life of the will, since, as we shall see, all feelings of pleasure and pain are for SPINOZA symptoms of urge⁶⁴.

In his interesting work "Psychologie des emotionalen Denkens" (1908) p. 566—574 [63] HEINRICH MAIER denies that there are expressions of will without ideas. He regards will as the innermost being of the life of the soul, but spontaneous and reflex movements he does not take to be psychical at all, and in instinct, he claims, there is always an idea of the aim present. Now it is indeed so that spontaneous and reflex movements can take place unconsciously. But expressions of consciousness can be bound up with them, partly in that they are felt while they are carried out, partly also in that pleasure is felt when they have free outlet and pain when they are checked, partly even in that an unrest is felt, swinging between pleasure and pain, before they can be carried out. In all this a tendency or urge makes itself known that is intelligible only through the importance for self-preservation of the movements it leads to. It is this that SPINOZA has in view in his concept of urge (*appetitus*). — As for the second point, it is a far-reaching

⁶⁴On the narrower and the wider concept of will and on the significance of degrees of consciousness for the life of the will see my paper *Begrebet Villie* (in the third series of *Mindre Arbejder*). — Whereas SCHOPENHAUER expresses himself in a similar direction to SPINOZA, FICHTE assumes an altogether decisive difference between unconscious and conscious urge. — In the most recent times HENRI BERGSON has regarded the replacement of instinct by reflection as a kind of fall. Cf. *Henri Bergson's Filosofi*, p. 16 ff; 39 f.

anthropomorphism, that is, here, an interpretation from the standpoint of the grown and reflecting man, when MAIER reads an idea of purpose into every instinctive action. He adds, it is true, that this idea of purpose appears only as a member of a complex, is not analysed out of it. But precisely this difference can be of great significance. A psychical element cannot without more ado be said to be the same before and after it has been analysed out of the complex in which it first appeared. The undifferentiated approaches the unconscious as regards the individual elements. There is in any case a whole series of transitions. And it is always risky to jump over them without more ado and to read into the still undifferentiated states what one has found in the more differentiated ones. The difference is qualitative.

After this psychological excursus we return to SPINOZA.

δ. From the urge of self-preservation there follows (11–13) an urge to hold fast or prefer what increases the power of action in spiritual and bodily respects. With regard to the power of action or power of existence (*potentia agendi* — *vis existendi*), which is one with perfection or reality (11 with Schol. and the closing section of the third book), a transition can be experienced now to greater, now to less activity or perfection. In the first case joy (pleasure) (*lætitia*) arises, in the second case sorrow (pain) (*tristitia*). In the appendix to the third book (Ch. 2 and 3) SPINOZA stresses very strongly that joy and sorrow consist in the very transitions (*actus transeundi*) from less to greater, or from greater to less perfection, — not in the very perfection or imperfection to which the transition is made. The decisive thing is thus the relation to the preceding state. One must, after all, possess a certain perfection (power of action or of existence) to be able to pass over to less perfection, and conversely a certain imperfection must be present for a passage to greater perfection to be possible. What SPINOZA enjoins here is what in my Psychology I call “the law of relativity in the domain of the feelings”. In the closing section of the third book it is enjoined again that it is the transition itself that matters. But here it is not the difference between transition and state that he wants [64] to impress. He maintains here, on the contrary (something in which he puts several modern psychologists to shame), that no express comparison need take place between the preceding and the following state; it is an altogether immediate relation between two states that conditions joy and sorrow. SPINOZA's fineness as a psychological observer perhaps appears nowhere more than in these remarks.

Beside joy and sorrow, desire is set as the third fundamental feeling (*affectus primarius*). From these three all other feelings can be derived (11 Schol.). Later on (57 Dem.) joy and sorrow are said to be one with urge or desire in so far as this is furthered or checked by external causes. And this is consistent within SPINOZA's whole philosophy, since man, like every individual being, stands as a special form of substance, represents as it were a part of its power: it then depends on what the relation is between the working determined from within and the external circumstances, that is, between the individual mode and the other modes, which like it are special forms of the power of substance.

When this relation is such that self-assertion is favoured by it, there is, according to SPINOZA, a tendency to dwell in the imagination on everything that can maintain and develop it (12). And the same tendency shows itself also when a man feels joy in and love for another being; then the ideas of what serves the preservation and development of this being will be held fast (25). — This is one side of the phenomenon (described by HUME, LOTZE and others) that may be called the expansion of feeling. But SPINOZA speaks of the phenomenon only in so far as it is the expression of self-assertion. He shows (26 Schol.) how it can lead to overvaluation of oneself and of those one loves, and to undervaluation of others. But experience shows that such expansion can also take place with feelings (such as fear and pity) that do not further self-assertion. The relation is not so simple as SPINOZA thought. The individual elements of the life of the soul can, by virtue of a psychical law of inertia, tend to spread at the expense of the life of the soul as a whole. Here there is more possibility of disharmony than SPINOZA assumed⁶⁵.

Before we go over to SPINOZA's presentation of the special feelings and desires, the remark presses forward that the unfitness of SPINOZA's "geometrical method" shows itself nowhere so clearly as in the section that now follows. The different phenomena all come to stand on a line with one another, although they fall into different groups, and although within each individual group there is a difference between fundamental and derived phenomena. Yet SPINOZA occasionally (especially in the appendix) indicates certain points of division, and on the strength of them the following survey can be given of the psychology of the feelings in SPINOZA:

I. Passive feelings (13—57).

[65]

⁶⁵In 13 Cor. SPINOZA says that the soul is averse to imagining what diminishes or checks its own and the body's power. — But owing to the tendency to expansion a strange urge can arise to dwell precisely on what checks (to bury oneself in sorrow, for example).

- α . Influence of ideas on feeling (13–18).
- β . Feelings can be determined 1) by the relation to others (19–29) or 2) by the relation to ourselves (30–35).
- γ . Feelings can have the character of desire (36–59).
- II. Active feelings (58–59).

d. Propositions 13–57 (and the corresponding sections of the Appendix).

Passive Feelings.

α . Two special feelings SPINOZA derives at once from the fundamental feelings (which are, as we know, joy, sorrow and desire), namely love (*amor*), which is joy (*laetitia*) joined with the idea of its cause, and hatred (*odium*), which is sorrow (*tristitia*) joined with the idea of its cause. Both contain urge or desire, the former to hold fast and preserve, the latter to remove and abolish. Already here the influence of ideas on feeling shows itself clearly. It is by being joined with the idea of its cause that joy becomes love, sorrow hatred. When something that would in itself awaken sorrow also has sides from which it can give us joy, it will be able to call forth love and hatred at once; the mind will then waver to and fro between the two feelings. This wavering of the mind (*animi fluctuatio*) corresponds in the domain of feeling to doubt (*imaginationis fluctuatio*) in the domain of ideas. And there is at bottom, says SPINOZA (17 Schol.), only a difference of degree between the two phenomena. — By this last remark SPINOZA comes to admit that there are no ideas without effect on feeling. Besides, a certain discrepancy must be noted between 17 (the proposition and the demonstration) and the scholium belonging to it. In the proposition and in the demonstration there is talk of the simultaneity of the two feelings, but in the scholium of a wavering, that is, of an alternation⁶⁶. It is naturally difficult for observation to distinguish between a rapid transition and a simultaneity.

β . 1) A whole series of feelings is determined by whether what we love or hate exists or perishes, is furthered or checked. What is connected in an external way or by likeness

⁶⁶That the word wavering (*fluctuatio*) must be understood as an alternation is seen from a passage in the second book to which SPINOZA refers here. For it says there (II, 44 Schol.) that when an idea has earlier, at different times, been joined with two different ideas, it will later call up now the one of these, now the other, and this state is called the wavering of the imagination (*imaginationis fluctuatio*).

with the object of love or hatred will get a share in our feeling towards that object. By this way pity, benevolence, indignation, envy, shame arise, — all by the same principle, only in different modifications and complications. SPINOZA stresses in particular (32 Schol.) how pity, envy and ambition spring from the same property of human nature, namely from the way in which a feeling of joy or sorrow is altered through the influence of ideas of their causes or of things that in one way or another stand in connection with these causes. — Pity, however, SPINOZA explains not merely by the association of ideas — namely by our getting a certain feeling ourselves when we imagine a being like ourselves dominated by it; — but also by a reflex tendency to imitate the states and movements of others. “He who flees because he sees others flee, or fears because he sees others fear, or he who draws back his hand when he sees another burn his hand, — of him we say that he imitates the feelings of others” (Appendix Ch. 33, Note). A starting point is indicated here for the explanation of sympathetic feelings, later carried further by ADAM SMITH⁶⁷. [66]

2) In the appendix it says, after the group of feelings just spoken of has been gone through: “These are the feelings of joy and sorrow that are conditioned by the idea of an external thing as immediate or mediate cause. I now go over to other feelings, which are determined by the idea of an internal thing as cause.” (Ch. 24 Expl.). This internal thing is ourselves. — In the third book itself this distinction is not made, since there love of oneself and love of another being are spoken of together (see Proposition 25). If we follow the appendix, which is more systematic, we now come to a series of feelings determined by the idea of ourselves and our lot. To this belong self-contentment (*acquiescentia in se ipso*), humility, repentance, pride, dejection, shame. — SPINOZA thinks that humility and dejection are very rare, since human nature has a spontaneous urge to dwell on or stress everything that can strengthen its power of action and keep it up. Very often it turns out besides that those who seem to be in the highest degree dejected and humble are exceedingly ambitious and envious. (Appendix Ch. 29, Expl.).

Through this whole teaching on how ideas of external or internal, immediate or mediate causes of feelings can bring about changes of quality and direction in the life of feeling, SPINOZA has become the real founder of the theory of the displacement of motives, which was later carried further by English psychology in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, and which is so important for understanding the development of

⁶⁷See *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 450.

the soul. There is probably a historical connection between SPINOZA and the English psychologists, since HARTLEY, the first in their line, shows traces of Spinozist influence⁶⁸.

γ. After the account of the two groups of feelings due to the relation to others and to ourselves, it says in the appendix (Ch. 31, Expl.): "With this I have closed the description of the feelings that belong under joy and sorrow; I now go over to the feelings I count under desire (*cupiditas*).” Nor is this division used in the third book itself. And besides, SPINOZA himself teaches (Proposition 57, Dem., see above p. 64) that joy and sorrow are really one with the urge or desire of self-preservation, arising according as this is furthered or checked.

The first example of a feeling of desire is longing (*desiderium*), which (Appendix Ch. 32) is described as urge or desire checked by the idea of something that excludes [67] the existence of its object. Longing is thus a desire that expresses itself under strong resistance. It presupposes more composite and mutually conflicting connections of ideas than the simple desire determined merely by a single idea. In the third book itself longing is called a sorrow determined by the absence of a loved object (36 Schol.), and in the appendix too it is admitted that it forms the opposite of the joy felt at the absence of a hated object; when it is nevertheless counted as a feeling of desire, it is because of the predominance of the active element. — There is here a difference of degree, determined by the relation between the feeling and the element of will in longing.

In Propositions 37–38 it is enjoined that a desire will stir the more strongly the greater the decline in power, that is, the greater the sorrow that the desire replaces, and how the same holds of joy that replaces sorrow or hatred. It also holds conversely that sorrow and hatred become stronger when joy and love have gone before. — SPINOZA does not mention that there is a limit here to heightening by contrast. For the decline can become so great that no power can be released afterwards, and so no joy arise. In the opposite direction the limit does not announce itself so easily; yet there may be cases where excessive joy and rapture use up all power to such a degree that after their cessation there is only the possibility of torpor, not of suffering and sorrow. SPINOZA was too much of an optimist to go into this side of the matter.

Hatred is increased by mutual hatred, but can be abolished by love (Proposition 43).

⁶⁸See *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 455. — In the same work II, p. 372 I wrongly ascribed a very clear presentation of the theory to JAMES MILL; it is due to MACKINTOSH.

And even if joy is felt that what we hate suffers or perishes, this joy will not be without an element of sorrow when what perishes is a being like ourselves (47).

The more we think of the being we love or hate as isolated or “free”, the greater will the love or the hatred become, because then no other ideas and feelings can arise that could limit or check the influence of the object on our feeling (49).

After putting forward some further propositions on individual differences and complex phenomena within the life of feeling, SPINOZA remarks (57 Schol.): “All this concerns the feelings that arise in man as a passive being (*qvatenus patitur*). I have now left to add a few things about the feelings man has as active (*qvatenus agit*).”

e. Propositions 58–59.

Active Feelings.

α. By active feelings SPINOZA, following his general definition of activity and passivity (III, Def. 2), would have to understand all feelings whose whole cause (or at any rate the greater part of whose conditions) lies in our own nature. But since it is a presupposition with him that only as clearly thinking or understanding beings are we in states that have their ground wholly in ourselves, only those feelings are to be called active for him [68] that are determined by clear thoughts. In the demonstration of 59 he expressly sets the power of understanding (*potentia intelligendi*) as one with the power of acting (*potentia agendi*), and can thereby appeal to III, 1. But in III, 9 he had maintained that the urge of self-preservation expresses itself both in so far as we have obscure ideas and in so far as we have clear ideas. That is, we have an urge to hold fast the stage at which we happen to stand, whether it is rational or not. Even in the demonstration of 58 this is held fast; it is only in the demonstration of 59 that the narrower definition of spiritual activity comes into force. — Nowhere does one see so clearly as here how intellectualism and voluntarism are refracted in SPINOZA.

In LEIBNIZ' doctrine of monads, according to which the universe consists of psychical beings at all possible stages of obscurity and clarity, and yet each unfolding itself by an inner law, SPINOZA's concept of self-preservation has come more into its own. And later, in the nineteenth century, the importance of man's living out of himself, whatever stage of the knowledge of truth he may stand at, has been maintained from different

sides. Experience had been gained of the intricate and composite nature of the human life of the soul, and the belief of rationalism that man's being was exhausted by "reason" was no longer held. Nature, originality, is wanted at any price, because it is a necessary condition for getting further. And the possibility of self-activity is found at every stage of development, since there can stir a striving to free oneself from everything taken up from outside in an external and superficial way. Then, and only then, is clarity won about how life stirs in individuals. Such a view came forward in Denmark in POUL MØLLER's and KIERKEGAARD's concept of personal truth⁶⁹. In this concept the proposition in SPINOZA is taken in earnest that man strives to assert himself not only when he is led by clear, but also when he is led by obscure thoughts. SPINOZA himself, after all, also held the conviction that if one only worked consistently with the thoughts one has, the way would be paved for clarity and truth. (See above p. 17).

β. Not all feelings can get the active character. Sorrow, as the expression of the checking and diminishing of the power of action, is excluded in advance. Only joy and desire can be conditioned by clear knowledge. Clear knowledge is due to self-activity and causes the joy of knowledge and thereby an urge to continued self-activity (58 Dem.), — a love of spiritual freedom (*amor libertatis*), as SPINOZA calls it in a later connection (V, 10 Schol.).

All working that springs from active feeling SPINOZA counts under strength of mind (*fortitudo*), which is courage (*animositas*) when, e.g. in self-control and presence of mind, it aims at what is good for the individual himself, and is generosity (*generositas*) when, e.g. in mildness and modesty, it aims at what is good for others (59 Schol.).

It is a consequence of the sharp opposition SPINOZA thinks he finds between activity and passivity, and therefore between active and passive feelings, that he denies that sorrow can be an active feeling. Yet in sorrow too an urge stirs, namely to hold fast, [69] in spite of everything, to the value of what has been lost; or rather, sorrow itself is an expression of a conflict between the urge to hold fast to something valuable and the experience of its loss. Therefore man's innermost nature must be able to express itself in sorrow too. And in any case sorrow can become an element in a more composite feeling that can have the character of activity, even if each single element in it should be passive; the activity then shows itself in the power by which the elements are united in spite of

⁶⁹*Danske Filosofer*, p. 123–127; 125.

their different, perhaps opposite, character. SPINOZA too has seen this (58 Schol.). But he passes very lightly over the complex feelings; he contents himself with remarking (59 Schol.) that exceedingly many different compositions of the fundamental feelings are possible. He has not followed the path that GIORDANO BRUNO took in his enthusiastic work *Dell' heroici furori*. BRUNO and SHAKESPEARE are the first who have been able to present complex feelings in their peculiarity and in their value. SPINOZA himself has described, in "courage" and "generosity", two complex feelings (total feelings) of great value; but he would not admit that "passive" elements entered into them⁷⁰. —

SPINOZA's account of the psychology of the feelings is justly famous. He has striven to treat this part of psychology with scientific objectivity. In the foregoing we have dwelt on the inconsistencies that arise from the conflict of different points of view, and on the intellectualism that asserts itself again and again in spite of significant beginnings in another direction. But all the most important questions that the psychology of the feelings must raise come up in him and have also been brought out in the foregoing. Thus the relation between feeling and urge, the influence of idea on feeling, the displacement of motive, the effect of contrast as distinct from comparison, expansion, etc.

The psychology of feeling stands in SPINOZA as the introduction to an ethics. Man can become unfree, overwhelmed by feelings called forth from without. The question then is how spiritual freedom and strength become possible. Already in the third book several hints in this direction are given. When hatred can be overcome by love (43. 47), — when new connections of ideas can tear the feeling away from its original object (48–49), — and when there are even feelings that are not of a passive nature but are expressions of strength of mind (58–59), then there are possibilities of development in the direction of activity and freedom. At this point the fourth book takes up the question.

[70]

⁷⁰Cf. *Den store Humor*, p. 39 f; 154–159.

Fourth Book.

a. Preface, Definitions and Axioms.

α . In the preface to the fourth book the transition is made to ethics, which has given the whole work its name. For an ethics, concepts of value of one kind or another are necessary. And yet SPINOZA begins by repeating his polemic, from the end of the first book, against applying concepts of value to nature. But men and their actions too do after all belong to nature — according to SPINOZA's energetic statements at the end of the first book and in the preface to the third book! An explanation is then required of how SPINOZA himself can nevertheless think himself entitled to undertake an ethical valuation of human qualities and actions.

When the application of concepts of value in our view of nature is rejected by SPINOZA, the reason given is that such concepts are formed by our comparing the phenomena with general concepts or with purposes. We call things good or evil, perfect or imperfect, according as they agree with the general types we have formed for ourselves, or with the purpose we think they are to serve. But such comparison and its results have nothing whatever to do with things as they are “in themselves”. The infinite being that we call God or Nature acts with the same necessity as that by which it exists. There is no higher concept and no purpose by which it could be measured.

Nevertheless, SPINOZA suddenly declares, we must hold fast to the concepts of perfection and imperfection, good and evil, for we desire (*cupimus*) to form an intuitive ideal of man (*exemplar vitæ humanæ, quod intueamur*), in relation to which we can judge human actions!

If it is asked why we desire this, the answer is that our power of action is limited; it can constantly be increased or diminished, and there is always — as the only axiom of the fourth book asserts — something mightier than any individual being; — therefore we naturally strive for the greatest possible power of action, and with it for the greatest possible freedom (in the sense of the ability to have the cause of one's states and actions in oneself). At its height this power or freedom (as SPINOZA shows in the fifth book) makes man one with substance (God or Nature), the only thing that exists through itself and is understood through itself. SPINOZA can so far say that he still holds fast to the definition of perfection as one with reality given in the second book (Def. 6). But I have already had [71]

occasion above (p. 33–35) to state that this cosmological concept of perfection or reality is already colored by a determination of value, is due to a valuation, an idealization. Only thereby does it become possible for the ethical concept of perfection, too, to find a place within SPINOZA's system. According to SPINOZA, ethical striving becomes possible only in that a ray of substance vibrates in every individual being, and in that this ray can reach ever higher degrees of clarity.

Properly speaking, then, SPINOZA could very well have said that it is substance (God or Nature) that is the highest ethical model. And thereby there arises an analogy between his philosophy and his view of positive religion. The ideas of God of the positive religions have significance for him only in the practical sphere. In religion God is "a model of the true life" (*veræ vitæ exemplar*) (Tr. theol. polit. Chap. 14), while religion or theology cannot teach us anything about God's being in itself. It is characteristic that the expression "model" (*exemplar*) can be used in religion of God, in philosophy of the true man. The cosmological view forms a transition between the two worlds of thought.

β. But there still lies a difficulty in the reason SPINOZA gives why concepts of value cannot be applied to existence itself. The reason was to lie in their being modes of thought, concepts we form by comparing things with one another (*cogitandi modi seu notiones, quas formamus ex eo, quod res ad invicem comparamus*). (See also Ep. 21.) Now it holds of all our concepts, the purely theoretical ones too, that they are formed by comparison. All science rests, according to SPINOZA's own theory of knowledge, on comparison. The second kind of knowledge (*ratio*), science proper as opposed to chance experience, consists precisely in our not considering things in isolation but understanding their "agreements, differences and oppositions"; only thereby does clear and distinct knowledge come about (II, 29 Schol., see above p. 43). All things, not values alone, become objects of clear and distinct concepts only through comparison. The very concept of truth or reality can be applied only by means of a standard (*norma veritatis*), which according to SPINOZA is given in the purely logical relation between ground and consequent (see above p. 6–7). Just as the theoretical concepts have their norm in this relation, so for SPINOZA the concepts of value have their norm in the concept of the highest power or freedom. Considered as concepts of comparison, then, the concepts of value stand on a line with all other concepts. The difference is that the norm of value (the fundamental value) is more special and concrete than the norm of truth, since it springs from the

needs and the urge of human nature. In this special form the norm of value cannot be transferred to existence. In this, according to SPINOZA, philosophy differs from theology. Since the theologians regard God as an ideal man, it is consistent of them to transfer concepts of value to him and to attribute to him wishes, and pleasure and displeasure at what happens in the world (Ep. 23 and 54).

Even from the concrete human point of view the concepts of value have, according to SPINOZA, only a limited validity, namely so long as man has not reached perfect freedom [72] but must still struggle to assert himself in his peculiar being. Only so long does he need a model, and only so long has he any use for concepts of good and evil. Towards the end of the fourth book SPINOZA sets up the proposition that if men were born free, which presupposes that they had only complete (adequate) ideas, they would form no concept of good and evil (68).

At the height of spiritual development we thus come "beyond good and evil". To that extent the ethical, on SPINOZA's standpoint, can be said to be only a means and a preparation for realizing the ideal of human nature, which for SPINOZA consisted in the freedom that is one with knowledge of our mind's connection with the whole of nature. In the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, where SPINOZA tells of the choice he made among the various ends men can set themselves, he names moral philosophy as one of the means of reaching the end that is for him the true one. This agrees entirely with the train of thought in the *Ethica*⁷¹. — It is not right to say with WUNDT (*Ethik*, II, p. 113) that cosmology and theory of knowledge were for SPINOZA only aids and preparation for reaching an ethical view of the world. For SPINOZA the ethical is a stage of transition. On the other hand one can say that all the thoughts he has laid down in his system signify for him the way to what was for him at once the highest goal of thought and of the urge of life, even if on his view it would be meaningless to regard it as the goal of all existence, since existence in itself is eternal and unchangeable. For it is precisely in this eternity and unchangeableness that man must seek to gain a share.

There is one problem SPINOZA does not touch on (except right at the beginning of the treatise on the theory of knowledge), namely whether there is a norm of value that can and must be acknowledged by all men, just as there is a norm of truth to which all

⁷¹It is in reality also a misunderstood idealism that would set the ethical up as the highest spiritual form of life. Cf. on this my *Etik* IV, 2. 7 (4th ed. p. 88. 103).

must bow in the end. It is at this point that the real sting, in ethical respects, shows itself more and more to lie.

γ. The last difficulty as regards the position of the concept of value within SPINOZA's system comes to be this: how there can be anything at all other than the eternal and unchangeable. Why are there differences and degrees as regards "reality or perfection", so that there can be talk of a transition from one state to another, as in the definition of joy and sorrow in the third book, and so that there can arise the task of reaching from lower stages to higher? — In other words it is the differences of time and of quality that cause difficulties. Why does anything at all exist other than substance, that which has its ground in itself and therefore alone can be called perfectly free? Why does it cost so hard a labor to reach up to the stage where neither impulses nor concepts of value are to hold?

SPINOZA's answer is given in the closing words of the first book: "There has been no lack of material for producing everything, from the highest down to the lowest degree of perfection. The laws of nature were so comprehensive that they could contain everything that an infinite thought could contain." But this answer would settle the matter only if SPINOZA's fundamental concepts could comprise not only the constant but also the [73] changing, not only the completed but also the striving, not only the continuous but also the discontinuous. It is the unchangeableness of existence in its innermost ground that here expresses itself in its consequences and causes difficulties, both for ethics and for the theory of knowledge. There betrays itself here a presupposition that goes far back in the history of thought, and whose stubbornness is perhaps best seen from its still asserting itself in the founder of the critical philosophy, in his dogmatic holding fast to the constancy of the "Ding an sich"⁷².

It must at once be added, however, that while this difficulty comes out especially sharply in SPINOZA's system, it makes itself felt in all science. Science can lead us from differences of time and quality to general laws, which can perhaps even be formulated in the form of mathematical equations; but it cannot derive from these laws and equations that just these or those differences of quality and differences of time exist in the world. It is precisely a chief point of interest in SPINOZA's system that it leads us to see so clearly this relation between the fundamental concepts in which we think existence and the

⁷²See on this *Kontinuiteten i Kant's filosofiske Udviklingsgang* (Vid. Selsk. Skr. 1893), p. 34. — *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 327 f.

factually given things that make up the content of existence. SPINOZA was not himself conscious of this relation. His philosophy is, as I have expressed it above, an attempt to think existence by means of the formal categories alone.

b. Propositions 1–18.

The Relative Strength of the Feelings.

α . The strength of a feeling, its ability to maintain itself, is not determined by our own urge of self-preservation alone, but depends on the relation of this urge to the external causes by which we are affected. I am only a part of the whole of nature, and therefore undergo many changes that cannot be explained by my own being alone. And still less can the whole order of nature be explained from my being. But it is possible for a single feeling to gain the mastery over all the other feelings, when the relation between inner and outer causes favors it (2–6). Here the difference between true and false knowledge makes itself felt, though not directly. For, as shown in II, 32–35, error is nothing positive, but is due to the absence of supplementing and correcting ideas, and therefore true knowledge does not in and of itself annul what is positive in the state to which the error belongs (1). I have the same sense image of the sun whether I think its distance from me is great or small. When the true knowledge dawns on me, some of the ideas attached to the sense image are changed, but not the image itself. If it is objected that the fear of a danger falls away when it turns out that in reality there was no danger, SPINOZA replies that the fear also falls away when the news that there is no danger is false. It is thus not the true as such (*qvatenus verum*) that annuls the fear, but the strength [74] with which the ideas that exclude the imagined dangers come forward (1 Schol.).

β . When SPINOZA here speaks of the strength of ideas, in such a way that this seems to be something different from the logical opposition (the relation of exclusion) between them and other ideas, it must be assumed that this strength rests on the feelings attached to the excluding ideas. For in 7 it is maintained that a feeling is not displaced except by another and stronger feeling. The proof is conducted from the law of inertia. Neither a spiritual nor a bodily state is annulled except by means of another and stronger state.

The important proposition SPINOZA sets up here occurs also in PLATO, when he (as in the *Phaedo* and in the *Republic*) sets the urge for knowledge as a counterweight to the

urge for sensual enjoyment or for honor — the same application of the proposition that we shall see SPINOZA make in the fifth book. SPINOZA may have come to the proposition by way of his own experience. He tells at the beginning of the treatise on the improvement of the understanding how in knowledge he found a good that could put all other goods in the shade. He experienced that in his hours of reflection (*modo possem serio deliberare*) he was freed from everything that could otherwise ensnare him. Possibly, however, he is influenced here by BACON, who says that just as in hunting one uses a falcon to catch other birds, so one feeling can be used to check or regulate other feelings (De Augmentis Scientiarum. VII, 3). In several features SPINOZA's ethics recalls BACON's account. Thus BACON divides ethics into the doctrine of the model (*exemplar*) and the doctrine of the work of bringing about agreement with the model (*cultura animi*) (De Augm. VII, 1). And this latter doctrine is divided again into the doctrine of the feelings (*de affectibus*) and the doctrine of the means of regulating them (*de remediis*) (De Augm. VII, 3). Both in scheme and in expression something related appears in SPINOZA. — After SPINOZA's time, too, this proposition, important both psychologically and pedagogically, has been maintained. Thus by ROUSSEAU, who in *Emile* (Livre IV) expresses it thus: On n'a de prise sur les passions que par des passions. KANT maintains it (in the third section of the essay on negative magnitudes and in the introduction to the "Tugendlehre"⁷³, without heeding the contradiction with his concept of freedom into which he thereby falls), and SCHILLER applies it in the eighth letter on aesthetic education. In my *Religionsfilosofi* (§ 116) I have shown what significance it has for the religious problem.

The proposition needs a corrective, however. For besides through the appearance of another, stronger feeling, a feeling, urge or desire can also disappear for lack of nourishment from the conditions under which life is lived, just as an organ can disappear for lack of use and — in consequence — of nourishment. And when a feeling is displaced by a new feeling, this is probably in fact also because the latter lays claim to all spiritual and bodily energy.

From Proposition 7 it now follows that if the knowledge of good and evil is to become a power in the mind, it must appear as a feeling (urge or desire) (14). But according to [75] III, 9 Schol. it is an urge or desire that leads us to regard something as good or evil. The

⁷³Note the distinction, fateful for KANT, between freedom as an abstract ability (*facultas*) and as actual strength (*robur*).

knowledge of good and evil is thus nothing but consciousness of joy or sorrow, that is, of the way in which our power of action is increased or diminished (8). What matters is that this knowledge can maintain itself even though the present affects us more strongly than the absent and the future, and even though the difference between what in our eyes is contingent, possible and necessary also exerts a great influence on us (9–13). Where the effect of what affects us at the moment stands in sharp opposition to the knowledge of good and evil we have so far gained, a conflict arises within us. The Preacher is right, then, that he who increases his knowledge increases his pain. This is no reason, however, to praise ignorance; but it contains a summons to investigate the conditions of spiritual strength and spiritual impotence (17 Schol.).

γ. In Proposition 18 it is maintained that the desire arising from joy is, other things being equal, stronger than that arising from sorrow. The reason lies in sorrow (pain) being a symptom of a decline in power of action.

In the scholium to 18 SPINOZA himself comes to admit the unsuitability of the “geometrical” method of exposition, especially because it leads to great prolixity and hinders a general view. Therefore, before he shows in detail how man can develop from being the passive prey of commotions of the mind to possessing self-control and freedom, he will give a survey of what reason shows to be the condition for reaching this goal.

What matters is to act according to the laws of one's own nature and thereby reach greater perfection, a goal that must be sought for its own sake, not as a means to something else. Those who entirely lose the urge of self-preservation and take their own lives are — perhaps without noticing it themselves — overpowered by external causes (*causæ latentes externæ*. 20 Schol.).

Among the means of self-preservation, cooperation with other men is of especially great importance. When several unite their forces for common purposes, they become as it were one soul and one body. Men who are guided by reason will therefore not desire anything for themselves that they do not also desire for others; they will be just, faithful and honorable. — One sees already here the difference between SPINOZA's and HOBBS' ethics. For SPINOZA social ethics is a positive and direct continuation of individual ethics, while for HOBBS it stands predominantly in a negative or indirect relation to it. In a letter (Ep. 50) SPINOZA himself has spoken of this difference.

c. Propositions 19–28.

The Ethical Character and the Highest Good.

α . The urge of self-preservation decides what is regarded as good and evil, and therefore everyone, according to the laws of his own nature, yearns for what he regards as good and abhors what he regards as evil. That urge is one with man's being. And the knowledge of good and evil is, as we have seen, nothing but consciousness of joy [76] and sorrow, i.e. of the increase and diminution of the ability to assert ourselves. — One sees here how knowledge, feeling and will in the end become one for SPINOZA, yet in such a way that it is a willing and acting that is our innermost being and that becomes conscious of itself in knowledge and feeling. Here lies the possibility of a richer and deeper psychology than the marked intellectualistic tendency that SPINOZA brought with him to his philosophizing could allow to develop.

But when man acts blindly or is guided by incomplete (inadequate) ideas, he does not, according to SPINOZA, act from himself; he is then not active, not free. There is therefore nothing of which we can know with certainty that it is good, except knowledge. SPINOZA speaks here, as one sees from the autobiographical fragment in the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, from his own experience. External things, he says in the appendix to the fourth book, are good for us only in so far as they are conditions for a share in that life of the mind which consists in knowledge (*ut mentis vita fruamur, quæ intelligentia definitur*. IV App. Chap. 5).

β . SPINOZA has, as mentioned earlier, not noticed any difficulty in the relation between the two starting points that condition his psychological and ethical train of thought, — the one according to which the urge of self-preservation, — the other according to which the urge for knowledge constitutes man's being. The opposition is there, but it need not have been insuperable. The urge of self-preservation can lead to regarding knowledge as a good, first perhaps as a derived good, a means, later, perhaps after a whole psychological process, as an end, a good in itself, so that it can be said (29 Dem.) that it is not for the sake of any other end that we strive after knowledge. When SPINOZA grounds this proposition on our not striving to preserve ourselves for the sake of any end at all (25), the presupposition underlying it is that knowledge and self-preservation are one. And yet experience shows, as SPINOZA's own experience had also shown him, that

they do not simply coincide. Through the third book's demonstration that displacement of motive is possible, SPINOZA had provided himself with a basis for understanding how what first has value as a means can later become an end in and for itself. It is strange that he does not make use of this theory here in the fourth book. His sound eye as a psychologist fails him here, and the reason must be sought in his being unable, given the fundamental concepts of his philosophy, to attribute any decisive importance to becoming, transition and development. He regards the urge of self-preservation and the urge for knowledge as identical, instead of holding to this, that the latter can develop out of the former according to natural laws and perhaps, at its height, gather all strength of mind into itself. — In the fifth book this peculiarity of his train of thought will come out even more sharply.

If we look back at the relation between knowledge and will in SPINOZA, we find three points of view that conflict in him: 1) man's being is thought (III, 1–3, cf. II, 40); 2) thought and urge are identical (IV, 25–26, cf. II, 49); 3) thought is dependent on urge (III, 9 Schol.). A genetic psychology would try to show how a development can take place [77] from 3) through 2) to 1). But the dogmatic and the genetic points of view conflict in SPINOZA in a way of which he himself was not conscious.

γ. True knowledge, which for SPINOZA stands as the highest good, would be a one-sided determination in an ethics meant to hold not merely for men of science (or rather for men of science in so far as they are merely men of science). The life of the mind (*mentis vita*) of which SPINOZA speaks can appear to us in more forms than the intellectual. The life of mood and of imagination are forms of the life of the mind that, just as well as the pure life of thought, can satisfy the spiritual urge, and can do so without breaking the norms of the life of thought. If we want to adapt SPINOZA's ethics to our own use, we must therefore put spiritual culture in general in the place of knowledge or understanding. New problems do indeed arise thereby, since conflicts can arise between the different spheres of culture; but this is precisely a testimony to the wealth the human life of the mind can possess⁷⁴.

⁷⁴Cf. my *Etik*, Chap. 27–35 and my essay *Aandelig Kultur* (Mindre Skrifter, Tredie Række).

d. Propositions 29–37 (and the Appendix Chap. 9–29).

The Significance of Social Life.

α . So long as men's feelings are essentially determined from without, it is a matter of chance whether they agree, and then it is also a matter of chance whether the individual man agrees with himself. There is soon a possibility of opposition and strife, for what different men strive for may be something that only one can possess. When Peter and Paul love one and the same thing, they agree, to be sure, about its value, but in reality they stand opposed to each other; for if Peter possesses the thing he will feel joy, but Paul will feel sorrow, and vice versa⁷⁵ (34 Schol.). If there is to be concord and a real life together, the feeling must be attached to something that can be a common good, so that the striving of the one does not hinder that of the other, but they can help and support each other. And this will be the case the more men are guided by active feelings, that is, by such as are conditioned by knowledge and reason. Reason is a spiritual good, in the acquiring of which the one does not stand in the other's way. Here it is no accident when men agree. Without the ability to rejoice in spiritual goods man would not be man. And a good such as knowledge the individual will not keep for himself, but will strive to communicate to all. As regards material goods too, it will be of importance that forces are united; one can then better secure oneself against danger and obtain what is required to sustain life.

In the sphere of material as well as of spiritual culture, then, common striving is [78] possible when man is guided by reason, — by what constitutes man's real being.

β . SPINOZA is not so optimistic, however, as to overlook the great hindrances to such a community. Art and vigilance are required to lead men in this direction. An education for freedom is required. And there is no way in which a man can better show his skill and his talent than by influencing men so that they come to live under the authority of thought itself (Appendix, Chap. 9).

Men are inconstant. Few are those who let themselves be guided by reason. Most are envious and vengeful. But one nevertheless goes the wrong way when one scolds men for

⁷⁵Already ARISTOTLE remarks that for all to will one thing is not enough for concord, when each wills the possession for himself alone (*Eth. Nic.* IX, 6). — KANT has a similar reflection (*Kritik der praktischen Vernunft* § 4 Anm.) and cites the words of Francis I: "What my brother Charles wants, I want too!" — For they both wanted Milan.

their faults instead of guiding them to the acquisition of valuable traits of character, and when one breaks their courage instead of strengthening it. One should bear men's insults with a calm mind and work for everything that can further concord and friendship, and that is one with working for what justice, equity and honor require.

The state is a support for this striving to subordinate what is changing and conflicting to common fixed rules. Its working rests on two psychological facts. The first is that a feeling is overcome only by another feeling, the second that fear of suffering an evil oneself can restrain one from inflicting an evil on others. The state relies on these facts with its threats of punishment, which can accomplish what reason cannot. Only in the state, therefore, not in the pure state of nature, can there be talk of guilt and merit, of wrong and right (37 Schol. 2). Beyond what can be compelled by threats the state has no authority, and therefore no right, and so there remains a sphere in which man, while living in the state, keeps the power and the right to follow his urge of self-preservation. It is of great importance that the state know its limits. For one cannot rely on a concord that is brought about only by instilling fear; it is not by arms but by love and magnanimity that souls can be conquered. (Appendix, Chap. 16).

SPINOZA gives a closer development of the relation between the individual and the state in the theological-political treatise, Chap. 16.

e. Propositions 38—58.

A Scale of Value for Joys and Sorrows.

α . As SPINOZA passes on to a valuation of the different feelings according to the standard he has gained in the foregoing, he begins with a biological and sociological consideration. Good is everything that makes the body fit to act in as many-sided a way as possible, and that preserves the constant relation between rest and motion within the body. Good, further, is everything that leads to concord in society and thereby makes it possible for men to live according to true knowledge.

Then the various feelings are gone through. The main proposition is that joy is always good in and of itself, sorrow (pain) in and of itself evil⁷⁶. For, it is said in the appendix [79]

⁷⁶On the justification of this proposition see my *Etik* VII, 1, where some historical notes on it are also given.

(Chap. 31), the greater the joy we feel, the greater the perfection to which we pass, and the more we partake of the divine nature. But it is joy as a total feeling (*hilaritas*) that is meant, — joy as embracing man's whole being. In this sense, now, joy is easier to conceive than to find in experience. For mostly there is a single special feeling that expresses itself in excessive degree and makes the mind fasten so on a single object that nothing else exists for it at all (44 Schol.). As for the joy that embraces only single parts of man's being, that is, partial joy, "titillation" (*titillatio*) ("pleasure" in the narrowest sense of the word), it can be carried so far that it is at the expense of the perfection of the whole individual. — As a partial feeling, sorrow or pain can be good. For it indicates that there is still life, — that the injured part is not rotten. Although repentance and shame, for example, are in themselves sorrow, he who is in such sorrow is yet more perfect than the shameless man who no longer has any urge for honor. (58 Schol.). A feeling of which sorrow is an element cannot be called good in and of itself. This holds of fear and hope, both of which presuppose pain (expected to come or expected to be removed), and it holds of feelings that presuppose a preceding hope and fear, such as the feeling of security and the joy over sorrow overcome (*securitas et gaudium*) (47 Schol.).

By total feeling SPINOZA, as one sees, means feelings that do concern man's whole being but are simple, homogeneous and uncompounded, — not such feelings as those in which elements and aftereffects of several mutually different, perhaps conflicting, feelings make themselves felt. To feelings of this latter kind he would in any case attribute a lesser value⁷⁷.

β. Hatred of men can never be good. The same holds of envy, mockery, contempt, revenge. Hatred is not rooted out by hatred, but by magnanimity. Those who are conquered in this way yield with joy, not from impotence, but precisely because their spiritual power is increased. Feelings such as repentance, pity and humility are not good in themselves, but, men being as they are, the feelings named can be of use and ease the transition to wisdom. Despondency, which is inclined to throw itself away (*abjectio*), is not good in itself either, but is yet easier to cure than self-overestimation and pride (*superbia*), to which, for that matter, it may very well be related (57 Schol.), since it is above all sorrow at one's own impotence, by comparison with the power and fortune of others, which in turn means that it easily passes into envy. — These last remarks recall

⁷⁷On the significance of such total feeling see *Den store Humor* Chap. 1. Cf. above p. 55 and 68 f.

NIETZSCHE's characterization of the unfortunate and their "slave revolt"⁷⁸. But there is a difference in principle in the standard: NIETZSCHE's standard is power in and of itself, SPINOZA's is taken from the spiritual goods that can become accessible to all, and from [80] which pride and humility can each in its own way exclude us.

γ. At the close of this scale of value of joys and sorrows SPINOZA reminds us that the whole valuation he has undertaken here holds only from the point of view that human striving provides. The laws of nature, he adds, concern the general order of existence, of which man is only a part. It has not been his task to report on men's faults and unreasonable conduct, but to show the nature and properties of things. It is still his intention to consider human feelings and their properties in the same way as other natural phenomena. And even if human feelings do not exactly bear witness to men's cleverness and wisdom, they still bear witness to the power and wisdom of nature, no less than other phenomena we delight in investigating (57 Schol.). For SPINOZA there is no discord between cosmology and ethics.

f. Propositions 59–66.

A Scale of Value for Desires.

α. Although SPINOZA has seen clearly that there is something artificial in distinguishing between feeling and desire, since desire is determined by the idea of the cause of the feeling (III, 12–15; 57 Dem.), he nevertheless says (IV, 58 Schol.) that now, having spoken of the value of joys and sorrows, he will go on to give a valuation of the desires.

The actions that spring from passive feelings can also be performed from true knowledge. For to act according to true knowledge (*ratio*) is nothing but to act according to the innermost being of our nature. When sorrow, and sometimes joy too, is evil, it is because they are passive feelings, expressions of a checked power of action. If the check falls away, so that self-assertion and transition to greater power of action become possible, the actions that were previously due to passive feeling are performed in a far more perfect way. As an example the difference between blind revenge and deliberate punishment is cited (59).

⁷⁸Cf. *Moderne Filosofen* p. 140.

It is of decisive importance whether the desire springs from only a single part of our being, or whether it takes account of all sides of our nature. Further — whether it springs from a cause that acts only in the present moment, or whether it takes account of the future. From the standpoint of true knowledge the whole difference between past, present and future falls away. The difference between the stages of knowledge rests essentially on this, that differences and relations of time play a part at the lowest stages but fall away at the higher stages, where one sees things “under the aspect of eternity”. (Cf. above p. 47–54). The knowledge of good and evil does not belong to the highest stage of knowledge, precisely because it presupposes the influence of differences of time. For we do not look equally clearly on past, present and future with regard to what is to be preferred. Therefore the knowledge of good and evil that we have, even if it is correct, is only abstract and general, and cannot gain in the particular case the influence that in and of itself it lies in its nature to exert. Knowledge of evil, now, is always an incomplete (inadequate) knowledge, since, being conditioned by a transition to lesser [81] power of action, it is not explained by our own being, but is understood only through our dependence on what is outside us. If we had only perfect knowledge, we would form no concept of evil. He who is guided by his own being, i.e. by clear thoughts independently formed, always does what he wills, namely what is for him the most excellent thing in life. He can in truth be called a free being (60–66).

β. If we now look back on the whole development of imperfect and perfect action that SPINOZA gives in the fourth book, it turns out that what is irrational in ethical respects is due, on his view, partly to differences in the degree of strength of the feelings (IV, 1–18), partly to differences between inner and outer causes (19–28), partly to differences with respect to time (59–66). In the end we come back to the fact that there are differences in existence at all, which brings it about that our thinking comes to consist in comparison (see the preface to the fourth book), not in beholding the inner bond between things. So long as we do not see everything as one, we act more or less blindly. The ideal (*exemplar*) is the free man, to whose characterization SPINOZA now passes.

Although in SPINOZA, then, a sharp opposition makes itself felt between man as experience shows him to us, tossed about in blindness and in illusions, and the ideal man, the model for our thinking and acting, he nevertheless feels a deep aversion to those whom he calls now the superstitious, now the melancholics, now the satirists, who are

better at castigating the vices than at showing the way to true freedom, — who teach men rather to shun evil than to love good, — and who work by instilling fear instead of leading men forward through true knowledge. (63 Schol. and Appendix Chap. 13 and 31, cf. already 35 Schol. and 45 Schol.).

g. Propositions 67–73.

The Free Man.

α. The free man denotes the highest unfolding of human nature, a life according to its own laws. As is clearly expressed in the *Tractatus politicus* (II, 7. 11), freedom is a virtue or a perfection; therefore man can be called free only when he follows true knowledge, exists and acts from the inner laws of human nature, from causes that are understood from man himself. Freedom in this sense does not annul necessity but presupposes it.

The free man thinks not of death but of life. He yearns for what is good for its own sake, not from fear of death. His wisdom is a meditation on life (*meditatio vitæ*). The difference between good and evil does not exist for him; this is the right thought in the old story of the prohibition against eating of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. His strength of mind shows itself as much in averting dangers as in overcoming them. Since he acts from true knowledge, he does not practice deceit. If true knowledge could permit deceit as a general rule, the whole of society would become impossible. The free man lives in the conviction that everything follows from the necessity of the [82] divine nature, and therefore, when something appears to him as evil, horrible or unjust, he will assume that the reason is obscure and fragmentary knowledge, and he will strive to understand things as they are in themselves, without letting himself be influenced by hatred and scorn, by anger and arrogance.

This characterization is, as SPINOZA himself remarks, a further working out of what was already described in the third book (III, 59 Schol.) as strength of mind (*fortitudo*) in its two main forms, as courage (*animositas*) and as generosity (*generositas*). That man rises above passive feelings, such as pity and sorrow, therefore by no means leads to self-absorption or cold indifference. At the height of spiritual development the opposition between one's own welfare and that of others no longer makes itself felt, because there is the strength and the mind to work for both, and — we may add in SPINOZA's spirit —

because in the full development of one's own personality the best contribution is made to the true interest of human society. The state's own end is freedom. (Tract. theol. polit. Chap. 20).

β. In SPINOZA's "free man" there appears the most thoroughly clarified form of the thought that, as already mentioned above (p. 61), carries the whole ethics of the Renaissance. This thought developed under the influence of Stoicism. But there is a significant difference between ancient Stoicism⁷⁹ and its successors in the time of the Renaissance. While self-assertion was with the Stoics a refuge, an expression of resignation, in the thinkers of the Renaissance (from TELESIO through BRUNO, DESCARTES and HOBBS to SPINOZA) it acquired an active and positive character; it sprang from trust in life and enthusiasm for its great laws, and it was nourished by the widening of the understanding of nature and of the view of the world that the new research brought.

The proposition (68) that if men were born free they would form no concepts of good and evil is of great importance. For it follows from it that the burden of proof rests on him who considers it necessary to pass moral judgment on human actions. The ethical problem lies not merely in the question whether and how ethical judgments can be grounded, but first and foremost in the question whether ethical judgments are necessary at all. That a man passes judgments of good and evil is for SPINOZA a sign that he does not live his life out of inner strength (with courage), and that he is not able either (with generosity) to help others to live their lives out of themselves. As it is put in a statement already quoted above: "There is no way in which a man can better show his skill and his talent than by influencing others so that they can live under the authority of thought itself". (Appendix. Chap. 9).

This thought contains the most intimate connection between individual and social ethics that is possible at all⁸⁰. By giving in to the inclination to moralize one easily comes to put obstacles in the way of what should be precisely the goal of all morality: the [83] development of independent personalities. That our actions are judged — by ourselves or by others — is ethically justified only when it is a link in an education for freedom. In ROUSSEAU's pedagogical gospel it was therefore also a main proposition that education must first and foremost proceed indirectly, or, as he puts it, be "negative". It is the principle

⁷⁹On Stoicism cf. my essay *Hedenske Sandhedssøgere* (Mindre Arbejder. Første Række) and the essays on *Epiktet og Marcus Aurelius* (Mindre Arbejder. Tredie Række).

⁸⁰Cf. on this my *Etik*, III, 10 and XIII, 6.

of personality itself that requires this.

In his grounding of the claim that the free man does not act deceitfully (72), SPINOZA uses a line of thought that later plays a great part in KANT, in fixing the general moral principle. KANT maintains that it could not be set up as a general principle that one may appropriate goods entrusted to one, or give a promise with the intention of not keeping it⁸¹. KANT did not see that underlying this line of thought is the presupposition that society is to continue, and that it can continue only through mutual trust⁸². SPINOZA, on the other hand, starts from society as a historical fact whose conditions are to be found. The reason by which the free man is guided in SPINOZA includes also the conditions of the continuance of society, and declares it absurd that society could continue without mutual trust (72 Schol.). In spite of all SPINOZA's speculation, it is always to be felt in his ethics, as in the other parts of his philosophy, that experience is for him the first stage of knowledge.

[84]

Fifth Book.

a. Preface and Axioms.

α . When SPINOZA begins the preface to the fifth book by saying that he now “passes on to the second part of the ethics”, he no doubt regards the fourth book as the first part, since ethics in the narrower sense begins with it. But when he says that this second part is to treat of “the way that leads to freedom”, its content does not stand in the same relation to the fourth book as freedom to bondage. Already in the fourth book he has shown the possibility of a development from dependence on feelings and desires aroused from without to spiritual freedom, and the book reached its height in the portrayal of the free man. The fourth book oddly enough bears the title “Of Human Bondage”, but this title does not fit its content. Indeed, already at the end of the third book (Propositions 58–59) the possibility is shown of a transition from passive to active feelings, that is, from bondage to freedom.

The fourth book ought to have ended with Proposition 66, and Propositions 67–73

⁸¹The line of thought is old and occurs already in PLATO (Republic I, p. 362 C).

⁸²Cf. *Den nyere Filosofi's Historie*², p. 72–84.

(the portrayal of the free man) ought to have formed one book together with the first twenty propositions of the fifth book, which deal with the remedies against dependence on the feelings (*de remediis affectuum*), that is, with the work of becoming a free man. The remaining part of the fifth book develops how he who has reached true knowledge is independent of time and stands as an eternal form of God or substance. Already in the fourth book (74 Schol. and Appendix Chap. 4–5) he had come to speak of intuitive knowledge as the highest goal and as what determines the value of everything else.

JOACHIM⁸³ determines the relation between the fourth and the fifth book thus: the fourth book describes man's knowledge and life at a stage where perfect ideas do guide his conduct but do not fill his whole soul. This view, however, decidedly conflicts with the portrayal of the free man at the end of the fourth book. What is added in the fifth book is the consequence that the free man is raised above time, not only thinks under the aspect of eternity but is himself eternal. At the end of 20 Schol. SPINOZA says that, having concluded the consideration of everything that concerns the present life, he will pass on to what concerns the continuance of the soul apart from the body (*sine relatione ad corpus*). Apart from the first twenty propositions, it is a religious-mystical rather than an ethical mode of consideration that is characteristic of the fifth book.

β. The preface is essentially a critique of DESCARTES' psychology, called forth by [85] DESCARTES' ascribing to man without more ado, like the Stoics, the ability to master the feelings. As BROCHARD remarks in his comparison between DESCARTES' and SPINOZA's psychology⁸⁴, SPINOZA dwells only on the points on which he disagrees with DESCARTES, and not on the agreements; thus he does not mention the weight that DESCARTES (like the Stoics before him) laid on understanding the nature of the feelings, and in general on the influence of ideas on the life of feeling.

SPINOZA's critique concerns four points:

1. DESCARTES gives no explanation of how soul and body (thought and a fragment of extension) can be united. He assumes such an opposition between them that he must appeal to God, the cause of the whole universe, to be able to solve the riddle. But that is no scientific solution, no explanation by a special cause (*per proximam causam*)⁸⁵.

⁸³ *The Ethics of Spinoza*, p. 268.

⁸⁴ *Le traité des passions de Descartes et l'Éthique de Spinoza* (in his book *Études de philosophie ancienne et de philosophie moderne*, p. 330).

⁸⁵ *Proxima causa* in SPINOZA corresponds to *vera causa* in KEPLER.

2. It becomes unintelligible how it can be decided whether the soul or the “animal spirits” are the stronger. Which of them is able at the decisive moment to give the pineal gland the decisive push? How can the two forces that are to meet here be compared? Willing and motion are not commensurable.

3. Anatomy shows that the pineal gland does not have its place in the middle of the brain, as DESCARTES thought. It cannot therefore be moved as easily and in as many ways as he supposed. Moreover, not all nerves lead out to the cavities of the brain⁸⁶.

4. A purely psychological explanation of the mastery over the feelings must be required. Since all spiritual power is conditioned by understanding alone, understanding must be made the basis where the talk is of remedies against bondage to the feelings. But instead of giving a purely psychological explanation of how understanding can develop and gain power, DESCARTES describes a purely imaginary struggle between soul and brain. The right procedure would have been to describe the phenomena of the soul in their mutual connection and then to consult anatomy and physiology. On SPINOZA's view every struggle between motives in the soul has its simultaneous expression in the relation between different brain processes. There can then be no question of the soul's being able to take a decision while at the same time the brain could initiate a movement in a quite different direction.

As regards the second objection, it rests on the reasons and points of view that led SPINOZA to his doctrine of the attributes. (See above p. 38–45). But he overlooks that he himself assumes a proportionality between psychical and bodily phenomena, so that he comes to face the difficulty of showing a common measure for the two groups of phenomena. There is, to be sure, the difference that in DESCARTES the one kind of phenomena was at a certain point to form the continuation of the other (the movement of the pineal gland to succeed the decision, or sensation and feeling to succeed the movement of the pineal gland) and to form a series within which continuity was broken at a single point, while in SPINOZA two series, each continuous in itself, run proportionally to each other, so that man's being shows itself precisely in this proportionality. But the difficulty then becomes that of finding a member of the one series that corresponds to certain [86]

⁸⁶These and similar anatomical objections had been made by THOMAS BARTHOLIN (1651) and STENO (1665). See on this *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 517. — STENO's critique SPINOZA may have known from his personal acquaintance with him in the years 1661–1663. STENO's treatise on the anatomy of the brain has been translated into Danish by Dr. MAAR.

members of the other series, a difficulty that becomes the greater the more weight is laid on the continuity within each series⁸⁷. To remedy this difficulty a concept of psychical work must be set up that can correspond to the concept of material work⁸⁸, and SPINOZA did not reach this, though he so often speaks of power of action in the spiritual as well as in the material sphere. It is his Cartesian philosophy of nature that hinders him in this. LEIBNIZ was the first to begin to see more clearly here⁸⁹.

γ. No new definitions are set up in the fifth book, only two axioms. — The first lays down that when two different activities (*actiones*) arise in the same person (*subjectum*), changes must take place in both of them, or at least in one, until the opposition is removed. It is evidently a proposition of experience that is to be set up here. But it is clear that this proposition rests on the presupposition that it is not indifferent to the two activities that they take place in the same subject. What is presupposed is a fundamental tendency to work together the different elements and processes that may occur within the same whole. By bringing out this presupposition SPINOZA would have arrived at a concept of work that could have been fruitful for his philosophy. The axiom is used in Proposition 7, where there is talk of the opposition between such feelings as are attached to thoughts of laws, that is, of “what holds alike in the part and in the whole”, and such as are attached to a single, isolated thing. The conclusion is drawn from Ax. 1 that feelings of the latter kind must in the long run yield to feelings of the former kind. What SPINOZA concludes here is no doubt also correct, although it can take a very long time before an impatient feeling, concentrated on a single thing, yields to feelings determined by relations that assert themselves again and again. The life of feeling, after all, develops more slowly than the life of ideas, single outbursts excepted. But even if SPINOZA is right in the special application of the axiom, he is hardly right in setting up the content of the axiom as the only possibility. It may be that there is a swinging between the two tendencies, or that a state of tension continues to exist between them, or that the one gains sole mastery, or that a total feeling arises whose timbre differs according to the mutual relation of the opposites⁹⁰. It is dogmatic to assume so simple a mechanical leveling as SPINOZA (and some modern psychologists with him) imagines. More psychical oppositions can persist [87]

⁸⁷I have touched on this point in *Filosofiske Problemer* (Universitetsprogram 1902), p. 23–25.

⁸⁸Cf. on this *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 4–6.

⁸⁹See *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 357–363.

⁹⁰Cf. *Den store Humor*, p. 39, 73, 88 ff.

side by side than one usually imagines⁹¹.

The second axiom — that the power of the effect is determined by the power of the cause — brings nothing new. It is accordingly grounded by a reference to III, 7, which in turn is grounded by I, 29. 36.

b. Propositions 1–20.

Remedies against the Feelings.

According to SPINOZA it is not really against the feelings themselves that remedies are needed. What matters is to annul the passive character some feelings have, by converting them into active form. Through a purely psychological development SPINOZA shows the possibility of this, which had, for that matter, already been hinted at in the third and fourth books.

According to SPINOZA's doctrine of the attributes and the identity hypothesis formulated in it, this possibility can and must be investigated both from the psychical and from the physical side, and it is indifferent from which side we begin. In the second, third and fourth books SPINOZA began his proofs from the physical side, though he constantly (see e.g. III, 12 Dem.) holds fast to the two-sided view. In the first part of the fifth book (1–20) he begins with the psychical side, evidently because, as regards the question treated here, this side is the better known. Later (from Proposition 21 on) he starts from the physical side, since here he thinks he has clear and simple premises to start from. It is not self-contradictory, as has sometimes been thought, but fully consistent, when SPINOZA thus sees the matter now from the one side, now from the other; and every scientific treatment of the questions at issue here in reality proceeds in this way, whether one is conscious of it or not.

The ways SPINOZA points out to mastery over, or metamorphosis of, the passive feelings are three.

α. What matters is to bring the feelings into new connections of ideas, in that the thought of their external cause is replaced by other thoughts (2). Of special importance here are the thoughts of the common properties of things and of their general laws, —

⁹¹Cf. AUGUST WIMMER: *Psylogene Sindssygdomme* (Jubilæumsskrift for St. Hans Hospital, p. 107), where this is grounded by way of pathological observation.

of what holds equally in the particular and in the whole and is always present (7). By being attached to such thoughts the feeling no longer has a single and vanishing ground, but is conditioned by true knowledge (*ratio*) and can be understood as a link in the great connection of things. Obscure thoughts are replaced by clear thoughts, and the feeling now acquires another character. Thus, for example, the lust for power or the pride that would force others to live as we see fit passes over into the generosity that strives to develop others to live according to clear understanding. It is one and the same urge that underlies the passive and the active states, but a metamorphosis has taken place in the transition to active form by means of clear knowledge of the circumstances (4 Schol.). [88] Sorrow ceases to be sorrow when its cause is clearly known (15 Dem.; 18 Schol.): for it is replaced by the joy of knowledge. A feeling transformed in this way will mean a greater power in the mind than a feeling attached to a single object. A firm connection of thoughts also gives connection in the life of feeling. Greater power is required to check feelings that are ordered and connected according to clear knowledge than to check indefinite and changing feelings (10 Schol.). The thought of the eternal and unchangeable can in the end limit the dominion of the passive feelings in the highest degree (20 Schol.).

For SPINOZA the transition to clear knowledge is a special case of displacement of motive. In and of itself displacement of motive can also lead to one passive feeling's being replaced by another passive feeling. Thus joy in a thing, or longing for it, can lead to envy of the one who possesses this thing (III. 32). But SPINOZA is undoubtedly right that a displacement is possible from joy in a thing to understanding of this joy and its cause, so that both the feeling and its cause (object) are thereby ordered in as links in a whole connection of nature, whereby the being ensnared and captivated by the single thing ceases. Clear understanding is SPINOZA's great universal remedy, and in this fifth book he can lay the main weight on this remedy all the more since here — after the fluctuations shown above in the third and fourth books — he decidedly returns to his intellectualistic view, according to which “the power of the mind consists in knowledge alone” (*mentis potentia sola intelligentia definitur*) (see the end of the preface and 20 Schol.). Only through clear understanding does the soul become wholly and fully itself.

β. But the development takes time. True knowledge is reached only step by step. What matters is to use the intervals between strong commotions of the mind for reflection. SPINOZA speaks here from his own experience. In the period of ferment he describes at

the beginning of the treatise on the improvement of the understanding, he felt freer when only he could give himself up to serious reflection (*modo possem serio deliberare!*). And the intervals in which this happened gradually became more frequent and longer. Therefore he now exhorts us (V, 10 and 20 Schol.) to use the intervals to impress on ourselves certain principles of life (*vitæ dogmata*) that may be needed when passive feelings again threaten to overwhelm us. Such principles of life are, for example, that hatred is not overcome by hatred but by magnanimity, and that men's conduct, like everything in nature, is subject to necessary laws. By impressing such thoughts on oneself one can make headway, even if it does not happen without fluctuations (*sine animi fluctuatione*). On the other hand it is an unfortunate path one takes when, for example, one consoles oneself for not being rich by reflecting on how often wealth is misused and how vicious the rich often are. One thereby only causes new sorrow in oneself. No, the guiding motive must be the urge for spiritual freedom (*amor libertatis*). One is then led to understand the origin of valuable traits of character, and the mind will be filled with the joy of knowledge.

γ. This joy of knowledge reaches its height when the understanding of our feelings and their causes goes back to the ultimate foundation of our knowledge, the thought of [89] God (substance, nature). In this foundation the joy of knowledge has its ultimate cause, and since all joy becomes love when it is combined with the idea of its cause (III, 53 and V, 15 Dem.), love of God will arise, — a love that does not demand love in return and gives no occasion for jealousy or envy, but that can occupy the mind in the highest degree as long as life lasts (14–20).

c. Propositions 21–40.

The Eternity of the Mind.

α. In this section SPINOZA again takes his starting point in the physical (physiological) side of man's being. He distinguishes between the body in its special or actual existence, with a definite time of existence and duration in time, and the nature of the body as contained in the eternal order of nature, which is expressed in the constant relation between rest and motion in the universe; for him the universe is a single great individual in which no change takes place, however great the changes that go on in its single parts. (See above p. 28–30; 43). In one of his letters he says that our bodies were not created but

existed before our birth, though in other forms (*qvamvis alio modo formata*) (Ep. 4, cf. the preface to the second part of the Short Treatise and L. M.'s preface to SPINOZA's exposition of DESCARTES' philosophy). In so far as the nature of the single body is contained in the material order of nature, and through it in the attribute of extension, it is an eternal mode, an object of knowledge "under the aspect of eternity". In a corresponding way the soul too is contained in the spiritual order of nature, and through it in the attribute of thought, as an eternal mode, an object of knowledge "under the aspect of eternity". Only so long as the definite existence in time lasts does the soul have sensation and memory. There is in God (substance, nature) a thought that corresponds to the existence of the body in all its forms (before and after birth and after death)⁹². Therefore the soul, no more than the body, becomes nothing at death (21–23).

This is grounded by means of II, 8 Cor., where already (see above p. 41 f) a distinction was made between a double form of existence for all single things (*res singulares*), — the one in so far as things are contained in God's attributes, the other in so far as they also have existence in time. This proposition SPINOZA now takes up, not only in the proof of 21 and 23, but more definitely in 29 Schol. (where reference is made back to II, 45, which in turn is grounded on II, 8 Cor.). The first-named form of existence is eternal, just as the relation between ground and consequent is. For there has never been a time when the ground (the premises) was, but the consequent (the conclusion) was not. When two chords intersect within a circle, the rectangles formed by the segments cut off are equal. [90] That is an eternal truth. In each single case only certain definite chords are drawn; but the others exist nonetheless as contained in the concept of the circle (II, 8 Cor.). It is here again SPINOZA's identification of ground and cause that makes itself felt. As determined in time, man is a link in a causal series in which every link is at once the effect of the preceding and the cause of the following; but in his eternal being he is an ungenerated, unchangeable and imperishable mode of substance. The opposition between these two forms of existence would stand out very glaringly, were it not the case for SPINOZA that the difference of time is altogether inessential to the causal relation, while what is decisive

⁹²"Our body presented before birth another relation between rest and motion [than after], and will likewise after death subsist under another relation between rest and motion [than before death]. But nonetheless there was then [i.e. before birth], and there will be afterwards [after death], just as well as now [in the lifetime], a thought corresponding to the body in substance as thinking, only not the same one, since the body will be placed in another relation between motion and rest". *Short Treatise*. II. Preface (Note 10).

is the timeless relation between ground and consequent.

SPINOZA recalls PLATO here. The Neoplatonic train of thought had indeed also influenced him through Jewish and scholastic theology. Just as for PLATO the world of ideas expresses the content of existence as eternal, while the things observation shows us are finite, imperfect and time-bound forms of this eternal content, so for SPINOZA the eternal relation between ground and consequent is the true reality, while the phenomena given in experience are time-bound formations (*affectiones*) of this eternal content. The difference from PLATO consists, as already emphasized above (see p. 48 f), in SPINOZA's putting (as BACON and BRUNO had already done) the concept of law in place of the concept of idea.

β. On the question of the relation between the part of man's nature that belongs to time and the part that belongs to eternity, SPINOZA relies (24–31) on his theory of knowledge. The more we understand single things, the more we understand God, who is the ultimate presupposition of their being and their continuance. We then build not on loose and chance observations, but on the lawful connection between single things, that is, on the foundation of scientific understanding, in which knowledge of the individual and insight into the general laws become one. (See above p. 51–54). Thereby not only is the innermost urge of the human mind satisfied, but the knowledge by which man comes to partake of God's being is possible only by means of what is eternal in man's being itself. The more man is absorbed in perfect knowledge, the more he can know that he is in God and is understood from God's own being, which is indeed the eternal relation between ground and consequent (30). To a knowledge of the kind named there corresponds, within the attribute of extension, not the body's time-bound existence, but the body's being as an eternal mode, seen under the aspect of eternity (29 and 31).

For SPINOZA the ideal of knowledge coincides with the ideal of existence, that is, with substance. But the highest kind of knowledge can be developed in very different degrees (26), and therefore the relation between the eternal and the perishable part of the soul can also be very different (38).

When intellectualism reaches its height in the interpretation of the highest human knowledge as God's indwelling in man, there nevertheless contributes to this a mystical tendency that never disappeared in SPINOZA, even after he had broken with his theological [91] past, but that comes out more strongly in the fifth book than in the earlier books. It is an immediate feeling of unity that presses forward. His religious urge will not acknowledge

any difference between thought itself and the highest, concluding object of thought. They are to become wholly one. Man's thinking of God is God's thinking of man. — If we compare the fifth book with the Short Treatise, mysticism has acquired a more intellectualistic stamp in the course of SPINOZA's development. But his intellectualism shows itself not in passive contemplations but in the activity of thought. It is by becoming wholly self-active in his knowledge, by living and acting from himself, that man becomes one with substance, becomes as it were one of the rays that go forth from it as from a source of light. God is not an object for thought, so that thought should stand in a relation of dependence on God. In the activity of thought itself God stirs. (Cf. above p. 7—9). SPINOZA's mysticism is here a consequence of his original presupposition about the relation between knowledge and its content.

SPINOZA does not investigate whether there might not be other forms of psychical energy, and thereby of spiritual culture, than the purely intellectual. When GOETHE found the foundation for his belief in immortality in the thought that our spirit is of an ever-active nature, and that if he was restlessly active until his death, nature was obliged to provide a new form of existence for him when the present one could no longer hold out, — he was thinking not of the energy of thought alone, but also of other forms in which the human spirit can act. The thinker and the poet agree, however, that only those men are immortal in whom a great energy has developed: “Wir sind nicht auf gleiche Weise unsterblich, und um sich künftig als grosse Entelechie zu manifestiren, muss man auch eine sein”. (Gespräche mit ECKERMANN. 1 Sept. 1829). SPINOZA says the same in his language, when he makes immortality conditional on the attainment of the highest form of knowledge and its dominion in the soul, and when he acknowledges different degrees in these respects (38—39). Starting from the highest knowledge as the expression of eternity, he could not arrive at immortality for all⁹³.

SPINOZA nevertheless thinks that all men are conscious of immortality, only they confuse it with duration or length of time and believe that after death there can be talk of memory and of pictorial ideas (34 Schol.). Strictly speaking, one can speak neither of a

⁹³Cf. *Den nyere Filosofis Historie*², I, p. 552 (Note 67), where a series of authors from antiquity and modern times is named in whom the thought appears that only those are immortal who have reached the highest spiritual development. To the names given there must be added RENOUVIER, and perhaps SIBBERN. — This assumption occurs among theologians too. Thus OTTO MØLLER interprets “eternal damnation” as annihilation (Brevveksling med RØRDAM, II, p. 321).

beginning nor of a ceasing nor of a continuation of the soul's true being (31 Schol. and 34 Schol.). The immortality SPINOZA speaks of lies not in the continuation of existence in time, but is in every moment and has always been. It comes to our consciousness when our activity of thought stirs in a decidedly active way. "We feel and experience", says SPINOZA, "that we are eternal, for we feel no less what we conceive in understanding (*res, [92] qvas mens intelligendo concipit*) than what we remember. The eyes of the soul are the proofs of thought themselves". The external difference between thought and object falls away in true knowledge. Eternity stirs in thought itself, not merely in its results.

There are two questions that press forward in face of this whole train of thought in SPINOZA. The one is whether a man's being, if it is to be wholly understood within the connection that knowledge points out, must not also include its relation to (its being conditioned by, and its intervention in) the definite circumstances of time and place under which it exists. This relation stamps and conditions its innermost nature and cannot be indifferent to the full understanding — even from the standpoint of eternity, in so far as it is possible for us to take that standpoint, which according to SPINOZA himself is possible only very rarely. This first question concerns the understanding of existence in time. The second question concerns its value. For according to SPINOZA a long theoretical and practical course of development (see above p. 89—90) is required to reach the stage where eternal existence first becomes self-evident. But then eternity becomes dependent on time, not merely the other way round. SPINOZA himself would surely have been very reluctant to admit that the whole spiritual work he has described so thoroughly should be an altogether indifferent episode. When the real validity of the form of time for our knowledge is not acknowledged, the reality of spiritual work cannot be maintained either. Indeed, the very concept of value presupposes the reality of time, since it presupposes urge and striving.

This presupposition, now, SPINOZA would not acknowledge. He demands, after all, that the perfection of things be judged by their "nature and power", and not by our urge. But the concept of value has not therefore disappeared from SPINOZA's philosophy; it has, as shown above (p. 21 f. 33), only come to rest in the fundamental thought of the innermost law of existence. And it is in relation to cosmological value that all other value in the end becomes vanishing.

γ. Man comes to partake of this value through the joy of knowledge. Since God, as the

ultimate ground of the possibility of knowledge, is the cause of the joy of knowledge, there arises an intellectual love of God (*amor intellectualis dei*). It is not directed toward any object in time, but toward an eternal being that only thought grasps (32 Cor.). Properly speaking there can be no talk of any object of this love. For just as God is and acts in human knowledge itself at its highest stage, so the intellectual love of God is a part of God's love of himself, as the one who acts in man's being when this has unfolded into an eternal mode of thought. The intellectual feeling is therefore an active feeling in the highest degree (36). In relation to it every other feeling pales.

From SPINOZA's own psychology there follows a difficulty with regard to the concept of "intellectual love", if this is to be a feeling that arises and persists according to psychological laws. It is to be eternal and unchangeable like substance, in whose being man comes to partake through the highest degree of knowledge. But according to SPINOZA's psychology (see above p. 63 f) every feeling presupposes a change of state and consists in a transition [93] — something he himself recalls in this connection (33 Schol.), in the same moment as he declares that intellectual love is not joy (*laetitia*), which consists in the transition to perfection, but blessedness (*beatitudo*), which consists in the possession of perfection.

At another point too, at the height of his mysticism, SPINOZA is compelled to alter psychological propositions he had set up earlier. In the axiom at the beginning of the fourth book it was maintained that there was not in existence (*in rerum natura*) any individual being that could not come to face something stronger. But now he teaches (37) that there is nothing in nature (*in natura*) that is stronger than intellectual love and could annul it. He has felt the contradiction himself, but maintains (37 Schol.) that the axiom in the fourth book concerns only individual beings as existing at a definite time and place, not eternal modes that are one with substance. But — a psychological development to clear knowledge and to the joy of knowledge does after all always take place under definite conditions of place and time. And SPINOZA himself teaches that intellectual love can only gradually permeate the whole soul, and that a great work is needed to bring it about that "the greatest part of the soul" is ruled by it (38–39). Intellectual love thus does appear in the psychological arena, and wherein lies the certainty that it will always conquer? One simply cannot escape psychology. It is omnipresent in the sphere of spiritual life, right up into the highest intellectual, ethical and religious regions.

Later thinkers too have sought to free themselves from psychology as regards these

ideal regions. KANT rejected every motive of feeling in the ethical sphere, and when he must nevertheless admit that the moral law can become a power within us only through the respect and reverence it inspires, he does not shrink from the consequence of declaring that respect and reverence are not feelings at all, since they have nothing to do with pleasure and pain, indeed cannot be explained by way of experience at all⁹⁴. A distinction like the one SPINOZA makes between blessedness and joy is made by CARLYLE between blessedness and happiness⁹⁵.

It would be wrong to see a mere dispute about words here, when eminent thinkers refuse to bring their highest ideals under psychological illumination. When continuity seems to them broken, it is because psychology has not succeeded in showing lawful and motivated transitions from the lowest to the highest forms of spiritual life. SPINOZA himself (in the third and fourth books) has given valuable contributions in this direction, but in spite of all that has been accomplished since, there are still always tasks here for descriptive and analytical psychology. In distinctions such as those SPINOZA, KANT and CARLYLE maintain, there are contained tasks for psychology that still demand to be treated.

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d. Propositions 41–42.

Ethics Is Independent of Speculation and Dogma.

SPINOZA's last word, however, is not speculation and mysticism. Proposition 41, the last but one in the whole work, runs thus: "Even if we did not know that our mind is eternal, we would still regard the sense of duty, religion, and everything that in the fourth book is reckoned to courage and generosity, as the highest". And in his proof of this proposition he points out that in grounding the value of these traits of character he has made no use of his doctrine of immortality. Most men, he adds, think otherwise, to be sure; they would not esteem those traits of character if there were nothing to hope or to fear after death. In one of his letters (Ep. 43) he maintains firmly that whether the ethical

⁹⁴See *Den nyere Filosofi's Historie*², II, p. 83 f. — KANT's "respect" belongs to what SPINOZA calls "active feelings".

⁹⁵*Sartor Resartus*, Book II, Chap. 9: Man can do without happiness, and instead hereof find blessedness. — Cf. my remarks on the terminology, *Etik* III, 11 and VII, 1.

propositions (*documenta moralia*) are God's commandments or not, they are equally divine and salutary. And already in the Short Treatise (II, 26, 4) he mocks at the fact that many who are regarded as great theologians say that if there were no eternal life they would seek only their own advantage. It is as if a fish were to say that, since no other life follows its life in the water, it would leave its own element and go up on land!

The last proposition of the *Ethica* (42) states that blessedness (*beatitudo*) is not the reward of valuable traits of character but one with them. We do not master our passive feelings in order to attain blessedness; but conversely — we can master the passive feelings because we possess blessedness. For the highest life of thought, and the joy bound up with it, are able to secure us against becoming the slave of passive feelings. It shows itself again in this closing consideration how deeply SPINOZA is convinced of the power of thought to harmonize life.

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Concluding Characterization.

a. The innermost nerve of SPINOZA's thinking is his conviction of the rationality of existence. The primal phenomenon⁹⁶ on which his system is built was this, that the things or events in the world could be conceived as links in logical and mathematical series, in which every link is related to the others as ground to consequent or as consequent to ground. By two ways, according to the conjecture put forward in the present treatise, the conviction of the reality of this primal phenomenon became fixed in him. In the concept of God to which he was led from his childhood he found, when it was thought through consistently, the principle of a rational ground for everything expressed. And he found the same principle as the presupposition of the new natural science's striving for a mathematical formulation of physical laws. The concept of God and the concept of nature met for him in the concept of substance, defined as that whose concept does not in turn presuppose any other concept. The series of grounds and consequents (causes and effects) must, if existence is absolutely rational, rest on a principle that in turn presupposes nothing, but "has its ground in itself" or is "cause of itself".

⁹⁶On this concept, which comes from GOETHE, and its significance for every attempt at a view of the world, see *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 311 f.

It was moreover his conviction that all spiritual life not only presupposes thought, but at its height is a life of thought. All spiritual needs are then satisfied when perfect knowledge is reached. All culture is for him in the end intellectual. All value is in the end contained in the joy of knowledge.

All science and all philosophy work, and must work, in the direction SPINOZA points out. It is always a matter of finding the inner connection between the different phenomena of experience (modes) and between the different sides or properties of existence (attributes). To that extent HEGEL was right when he said: "Entweder hast du den Spinozismus, oder du hast keine Philosophie".

b. About 60 years ago (1857) there appeared here at home a thorough and acute monograph on SPINOZA by HANS BRÖCHNER. In much my view of the great thinker agrees with BRÖCHNER's. It was indeed BRÖCHNER who first really taught me to value SPINOZA and his thinking, even if many years passed before I came to the view I have [96] put forward in the present work. And the memory of my teacher and friend, who in character and conduct of life had so much in common with SPINOZA, has accompanied me during my renewed immersion in the subject.

When BRÖCHNER's work appeared, VAN VLOTEN had not yet made the important find that brought "the Short Treatise" and the original text of the letters to light, and thereby not only corrected various biographical particulars but also threw light on SPINOZA's course of development. Not only in that I, like the many authors who in the last 50 years have occupied themselves with SPINOZA, have been able to use these documents, but also on several single points my view differs from BRÖCHNER's, and for that matter from that of the Spinoza scholars I know. I have especially sought to understand his ideas in connection with fundamental thoughts present in the natural science of the time, and have thereby come to stress the realistic character of his philosophy, which was wholly misjudged in the Romantic period, however much people enthused over SPINOZA. It is this realistic character of his thinking that has aroused so much interest in him in the last part of the nineteenth century. SPINOZA had the quiet conviction that in order to hold fast to the reality of spiritual life in the world it is by no means necessary to set limits in advance to the work of empirical science, either in the sphere of natural science or in the historical sphere. BRÖCHNER conceives SPINOZA "as the representative of the starting point of modern idealism", as the initiator of a movement that was to find its conclusion

in HEGEL. On my view, romantic idealism became possible precisely only through a break with the direction SPINOZA had taken. SPINOZA is no idealist, if that involves a denial in principle of the points of view and methods of empirical science.

But the most essential difference between my view of SPINOZA and BRÖCHNER's will appear from some remarks with which I shall close this treatise.

c. Can we really, as SPINOZA presupposes, conclude our science with the thought of something that is understood through itself and exists through itself? — Thinking consists in synthesis and comparison, the former as the presupposition of the latter. But every synthesis brings with it a limitation that can always be annulled by new experience, and every comparison presupposes a point of view that can itself become the object of comparison with other points of view. We can end with a question, but not with a thought that concludes once and for all. What for SPINOZA was the primal phenomenon, that which had its ground in itself, was the lawfulness in the world. But this lawfulness is a great hypothesis, which science in its constant work seeks to find confirmed through ever new application. And (as SPINOZA himself has admitted) the single phenomena and events cannot be derived from the very concept of lawfulness, even if they can be understood (and can only be understood) by applying this concept.

In his precritical period KANT pursued a line of thought that recalls SPINOZA's. He inferred from the lawful connection in nature an absolute being that lay at the ground [97] of everything. In this period it was for him "the only possible ground of proof" for the objective validity of the concept of God. But the transition to the critical philosophy was made when KANT no longer asked about the objective ground of the world, but about the possibility of an objective concept of the world, and when he found this possibility in the very fundamental form of human thinking, whose validity rests on this, that without strict logical connection of observations experience in the strict sense is not possible⁹⁷. The active character of thinking, which SPINOZA had so strongly emphasized, was now made the basis of the whole consideration. The concept of synthesis replaced the concept of substance, and while SPINOZA's philosophy was, or meant to be, first and foremost cosmology (metaphysics), a doctrine of the innermost nature of existence, the problem of knowledge now pressed forward ahead of all other philosophical problems, and a scientific cosmology came to stand as a limiting problem. To SPINOZA's substance ("that

⁹⁷Cf. *Om Kontinuiteten i Kant's filosofiske Udviklingsgang* (Vid. Selsk. Skr. 1893), p. 14–15.

which is in itself”) there corresponds in KANT’s philosophy “the thing in itself”, of which nothing can be known (not even that it “is understood through itself”).

A closer discussion of the problem of knowledge led in turn to distinguishing between different groups of categories, corresponding to SPINOZA’s distinction between substance, attributes and infinite modes of different degrees, but without the immediate metaphysical significance he attributed to them. A distinction is made between ground and cause, that is, between formal and real categories, and the concepts of value appear in their difference from both these groups. From this it follows in turn that all spiritual culture cannot, as SPINOZA at bottom presupposes, be one with intellectual culture.

But the ideal conception of the work of thought that SPINOZA maintained, and the inward joy of knowledge that for him shed luster over life, cannot be lacking in any true inquirer. Every observation and every thought that gives an insight into the great connection that all understanding of existence presupposes lets us feel the significance of the words of GOETHE, that faithful devotee of Spinoza: “Ort für Ort sind wir im Inneren”, although we cannot, as SPINOZA thought, unveil this inner once and for all.

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